



A NOVEL
JAL-PANJI

WATER REGISTER

Translated from the Original Maithili into English
by the Author Himself

GAJENDRA THAKUR

VIDEHA · MAITHILI LITERATURE IN TRANSLATION

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Author: Gajendra Thakur

CONTENTS

Chapter 1 — Kusaha
Chapter 2 — The Bundle of Manuscripts
Chapter 3 — The Panjikar's Method
Chapter 4 — Kosi — 1
Chapter 5 — Three Names
Chapter 6 — Mohan's Call
Chapter 7 — The Camp
Chapter 8 — The Erased Line
Chapter 9 — The Earth Shook
Chapter 10 — Witness One: The Priest

Chapter 11 — Witness Two: Sister-in-Law
Chapter 12 — Kosi — 2
Chapter 13 — Witness Three: The Ploughman
Chapter 14 — Witness Four: The Panjikar
Chapter 15 — What Was Not Written
Chapter 16 — The Flood of 1934
Chapter 17 — The Agreement
Chapter 18 — The Map
Chapter 19 — Kosi — 3
Chapter 20 — The Villages Inside

Chapter 21 — Two Mithilas
Chapter 22 — Marriage
Chapter 23 — The Famine of 1966
Chapter 24 — Engineer Babu
Chapter 25 — Silence
Chapter 26 — Kosi — 4
Chapter 27 — Anuradha's Voice Message One
Chapter 28 — Body and Caste
Chapter 29 — Voice Message Two
Chapter 30 — Bone

Chapter 31 — Mohan's Admission
Chapter 32 — The One Without a Name
Chapter 33 — Muscat
Chapter 34 — Kosi — 5
Chapter 35 — All of Us
Chapter 36 — The Village That Emptied
Chapter 37 — Voice Messages Three—Four—Five
Chapter 38 — The Panjikar's Clients
Chapter 39 — Kosi — 6
Chapter 40 — Kathmandu and Madhes

Chapter 41 — Return
Chapter 42 — Three Generations in One Room
Chapter 43 — Kosi — 7
Chapter 44 — Counter-Panji
Chapter 45 — What Survived
Chapter 46 — Writing the Name
Chapter 47 — Death and the Book
Chapter 48 — Kosi — 8

18 August 2008, Monday

The first entry in my diary for 18 August 2008 is at 6:40 a.m. It is not about the flood. It reads: “Milk came half a seer short. No reason given.” Beneath it, at 7:10: “Dampness has increased on the wall of the eastern room.” Between those two lines, the Kosi is not named. Until then, the water in my house was the water in the earthen pitcher, in the lota, in the brass bucket set before the hearth, and in four small hollows in the courtyard left by the previous night’s rain.

I have kept a diary for many years. Date, lunar mansion, the names of visitors, the purpose for which a genealogical register was consulted, the honorarium given, the honorarium not given, debts, sick people, medicines, letters received by post, delays of trains—each thing on its own line. It is not my work to write down the meaning of events. Meanings keep changing; the line remains.

At 8:05 the first telephone call came. It was not Mohan. It was a clerk I knew from the Birpur side, a man who called me “Uncle” although there was no kinship between his lineage and mine. He asked, “Have you turned on the radio?” I said, “No.” He said, “Things are not good up there.” I asked, “Where is ‘up there?’” Instead of answering, he mentioned someone else by name and said that calls had been going on since the night. The connection broke.

I did not turn on the radio. First I entered his words in the diary: “8:05, clerk from Birpur: ‘Things are not good up there.’” I put the words in quotation marks because they were his words. In the work of a genealogist, putting one’s own words into another man’s mouth is considered a fault.

At 8:23 came the second call. This time it was Mohan. His voice was clearer than the previous caller’s. He asked, “Babuji, is everyone at home?” I said, “Yes.” Then he asked, “Where are the papers that have to be kept high up?” I said, “Whatever papers need to be kept high are already high.” He fell silent. I asked, “Where are you?” He said, “At the office.” That was not a sufficient answer. The Water Resources Department’s “office” was not one room but the name of many places. I did not ask again.

He said, “The erosion beyond the twelfth kilometre is severe.” I asked, “For how many days?” He said, “A few days.” I asked, “Is there a written record of this?” Silence again. Silence on a telephone is not like a blank space on paper. A

blank on paper can be measured. In the silence of a telephone, you go on hearing the breathing at the other end.

I said, "If there is a written record, there will be a date." Then he said, "Reports of erosion had been coming in since the fifth of August." I wrote in the diary: "8:23, Mohan—erosion near 12.9 km; reports since 5 August." I did not tell him that I was writing. He already knew that I wrote everything down.

By nine o'clock three more calls had come. The first said there were too few labourers. The second said there were difficulties in getting materials through. The third said instructions would come "from above." "Above" had returned. The word had no fixed geography. For one man, above was Kathmandu; for another, Patna; for a third, the Chief Engineer's office; for a fourth, a minister's room. The river had one kind of above. The office had another.

I wrote down the times of all three calls. 9:07—labourers. 9:19—boulders. 9:36—instructions awaited. I did not write the names, because in all three calls the callers had already given their names and knew me; but later the omission troubled me. Had the names remained, the weight of each statement would have rested upon a person. With only the post remaining, the weight shifted to the office.

At 10:12 the postman did not come. That too was entered. On Mondays he usually arrived by half past ten. At 10:37 the electricity went out. At 10:41 there came, once, from the bamboo grove behind the house, a sound like a thick rope pulled taut and suddenly slackened. I went outside. The bamboo stood upright. The sky was grey. The wind came from the south-east. Nothing unusual met the eye.

At 11:02 Mohan called again. This time other voices were mixed into his. Someone was asking for papers, someone for a vehicle. He told me, "Don't keep the old registers down low." I said, "They are not down low." He said, "Babuji, listen—" and then someone at his end called him away. The line went dead.

What came after "listen" I could not record. In the diary it says: "11:02, Mohan. Sentence incomplete." An incomplete sentence is rare in a genealogical register. If the name at a birth cannot be found, a blank is left; if a marriage connection is doubtful, a mark is made; but there is no custom of beginning a sentence and abandoning it in mid-air.

At 11:48 I turned on the radio. The news mentioned the general flood situation, rainfall, river levels, and the district administration's preparations. I cannot now say with certainty whether the word "Kusaha" was spoken even once. In my diary "Kusaha" appears for the first time at 12:16. Beside it there is only this: "Kusaha. Eastern embankment. Damage?" The question mark is mine.

At 12:32 a motorcycle raced along the road north of the house. Five minutes later another. Then a jeep. The vehicles did not enter the village; they went towards the main road. At the time I thought that if officials were all going in one direction, the centre of the event must lie far from the village. Paper does not teach you in advance that distance is not safety.

At 1:03 a call came from an unknown number. A man's voice. He asked whether this was the house of Ramanu-grah Mishra, the genealogist. I said, "Yes." He asked, "Do you have an old map?" I said, "Of what?" He said, "Of the old channel." I told him, "I do not keep maps. I keep genealogical registers." He said, "The old names of the villages?" I asked, "Which village?" The connection broke.

Below that call in the diary, I wrote the names of five villages. I do not remember why. Perhaps I was trying to answer the stranger's question for myself. Of those five villages, two no longer appear under those names on the government map. One village occurs under three forms of its name in the genealogical registers. River, state, lineage—all three change their names, but not in the same way.

At 1:27 Mohan's third call came. He said, "Babuji, it has broken." I asked, "What?" He said, "The embankment." I asked again, "How much?" He said, "No one is saying anything certain yet." A voice in the background said, "From twelve point one to twelve point nine..." Then the words became unclear. Mohan said, "I'm hanging up."

I wrote: "1:27—erosion/breach. Between 12.1–12.9 km. Extent uncertain." The word "flood" does not occur in that entry.

At 1:45 an engineer I had known for years called. He was already retired. Having heard the news, he asked, "Do you have the 1963 survey list?" I said, "Yes." He said, "Look and see which villages the old channel used to touch." I asked, "Why?" He said, "Not now. Later." He ended the call.

I took out the 1963 list. The paper had yellowed. It was brittle along the folds. I read the names—one, two, three, four. I stopped at the fifth. A family bearing that village name had a genealogical register in my house. Sixth name. Seventh. Eighth. I folded the list again and put it away. In the diary I wrote: "Looked at list of old channel. No comment yet."

At 2:10 an announcement was made over the mosque loudspeaker; the wind was blowing the other way and I could not make out all the words. At 2:18 the bell at the temple began ringing continuously. It was not the hour of worship. At 2:25 a neighbour came. He had a plastic bag in his hand. He said I should move the important papers higher up. I told him they were all already high. He asked, "How much water will come?" I said, "I have no water gauge." He asked again, "Is there danger?" I said, "My office does not give me the answer to that question."

He found my answer curt. Perhaps it was. A genealogist's work is not prophecy. In my books, a birth was entered after the birth; a marriage after the marriage; a death after the death had been confirmed. Now everyone wanted me to read the next line before it had been written.

At 2:42 the telephone network almost ceased to exist. Calls would not connect. When they did, voices broke apart. In those broken voices three words returned again and again—"Birpur," "get out," "quickly." The words came from different mouths. In the diary I wrote only: "People are telling others to leave."

At 3:05, for the first time, I gathered in one place the household papers that were not part of the genealogical books—land documents, bank passbooks, the ration card, an old copy of Mohan’s school certificate, a copy of Anuradha’s birth record, two insurance papers, and a dingy envelope inside which there was no mention of any woman named Phuljhari. I did not know that last fact on that day; I understood it much later.

At 3:22 the sound of the road changed. Earlier the vehicles had gone one by one. Now there were footsteps, bicycle bells, children crying, bells on cattle and buffaloes, the growl of tractors, all together. I went to the doorway. People were moving west. No one stopped to tell me anything. Someone said, “Come.” No one took my name.

I went back inside. I opened the cupboard in the northern room. The genealogical registers were on the upper shelf. Red cloth, yellow cloth, two bundles wrapped in newspaper, a chest of palm-leaf manuscripts, the previous year’s entries. I did not alter their order. I only lifted the three volumes kept at the bottom of the cupboard and placed them above. In the diary I wrote: “3:35—three lower volumes moved up.”

As four o’clock approached, another call came. Not Mohan this time, but an assistant employee of the Water Resources Department who did not know me by name. He asked, “Mishraji?” I said, “Yes.” He said, “Mohan Babu says you should leave the house.” I asked, “Where is he?” He said, “He has gone to make arrangements for relief.” I asked, “Why didn’t he call me himself?” There was no answer. I heard paper being turned at the other end. He said, “A list is being made.”

“What list?” I asked. He said, “Of those who have to be moved.”

I put down the telephone and wrote in the diary: “4:02—a list is being made.” After that line there is almost a finger’s breadth of blank space. Such empty spaces are not ordinarily found in my diary. Perhaps my hand stopped then. Perhaps I had taken off my spectacles. I cannot say with certainty.

At 4:20 I checked the bolt on the front door. At 4:23 I closed the window of the back room. At 4:27 I brought inside the brass lota that stood by the tulsi altar. At 4:31 I tied the key of the manuscript cupboard into the knot of my dhoti. At 4:34 I closed the diary.

The final entry of that day, written before dusk, says only: “Order unclear. People leaving. Books presumed safe.”

Later I drew a line in red ink beneath the word “safe.” I did not strike the word out. A word struck out destroys evidence.

The Bundle of Manuscripts

19 August 2008

In my diary for the morning of 19 August, no time is recorded. At what hour of the night I slept is not written. The first line says only: “Did not leave the house. Books moved up. Movement of people continues.” Beneath that line there are four finger-widths of blank space. After it comes: “A bundle arrived.”

The man who brought the bundle was named Bhola Sahni. I had known him before, though not as a client of the genealogical registers. His father had once come to ask about a marriage connection; in that entry “Sahni” is written, but there is no entry for lineage-origin or village. Bhola worked a boat. He did not first tell me by which channel, by what route, or after how many halts his boat had reached my door that day. He came to the threshold and asked only, “Ramanu-grah Babu, might this be something for your work?”

In both hands he held a wet jute sack. Inside the sack, between two thin bamboo slats, lay a bundle tied in red cloth. Whether the cloth had originally been red, or had taken its colour in the water from some other cloth, was difficult to say at once. The knot was tied with black thread. The thread had swollen. Before opening it I asked Bhola, “Where did you find this?” He said, “Where there was a house yesterday.”

I asked, “The name of the village?” He gave one name. I repeated another pronunciation of it. He said, “Yes, that one.” It was one of the eight village names I had read in the 1963 list. I had not reopened the list during the night. Bhola spoke the name, and the line on the paper returned to me.

I called him inside. He took off his slippers at the threshold. Water dripped from the lower part of his dhoti. I spread an old piece of sacking. The sack was placed upon it. Bhola did not sit. He said, “I have to go back.” I asked, “From whose house did you pick it up?” He answered, “There was no house.” Then added, “A bamboo from the roof was caught there, near it.”

Before opening the bundle I brought the diary. I wrote the date. “One unidentified bundle of genealogical material received from Bhola Sahni.” Having written “unidentified,” I did not strike it out, for the owner of the bundle had not yet been established. To write an assumption about an object in one’s hand is not to make a record; it is to make a story. I had no practice in writing stories.

The knot was opened. The wet cloth was separated. Inside were palm leaves, handmade paper, strips of cloth, cotton cords, two thin pieces of wood, a small cloth pouch, and many folded sheets of paper. Because of the water, everything had adhered to everything else. I did not force anything apart. First I made a list of what could be seen.

One jute sack; two bamboo slats; one wet red cloth; one black thread; three yellow cords; twenty-seven palm leaves; forty-four sheets of handmade paper; eleven sheets of machine-made paper; seven spreads of blue ink; thirteen groups of black-ink letters; three round marks in red ink; two pencil scratches; one broken glass nib; one brass clip; four rusted pins; one dried tulsi leaf; two husks of rice; one black sesame seed; one small cloth pouch; five cowries in the pouch; one pierced copper coin; two half-torn postage stamps; one slip bearing a marriage date; one birth record; one date of death; the names of three villages; the name of one lineage-origin; one unclear notation of standing; one half-written gotra; one leaf with its left corner eaten away; one leaf with its middle portion decayed; thumb stains on two sheets; mud on five; a fine layer of sand on seven; an old ring of oil on one; a strand of someone's hair caught between two sheets; a knot of thread at the edge of one paper; one hole in a palm leaf; straight water marks on three sheets; one sheet completely blank; one bearing only "Shri"; one bearing "relationship"; one with a date but no name; one with a name but no date; and, at the very bottom, one thick fold that was not then opened.

After writing the inventory once, I counted again. I could not say with certainty that there were twenty-seven palm leaves, because in three places pairs of leaves were stuck so closely together that the number might increase once they were separated. So I put a question mark beside twenty-seven. Among the forty-four handmade sheets, too, five pairs were stuck together. A count describes the condition of an object; it is not truth's final number. In a wet bundle, even numbers must wait for the drying.

I had an old balance brought to me. Once the objects in the bundle had been separated, they could not all be weighed together again, so only the wet cloth, the bamboo slats and the jute sack were weighed. The figures for the weights are in the diary, but they were never used anywhere later. Many things are written down over a lifetime that are never needed again. Not being needed does not make what was recorded useless. The work of a record is not to foresee the wishes of the future, but to arrest the condition of the present.

At one corner of the red cloth something hard could be felt within the thread. I did not cut the knot. Feeling it with my fingers, I thought there was a very small folded piece of paper inside. It would not have been right to open the wet thread. I set it aside and wrote: "Knot in cloth—paper possibly inside." I did not write "letter." I did not write "slip." The written record should say no more than the object itself says.

Of the five cowries in the little cloth pouch, two were whole and three broken at the edges. The hole in the copper coin was not round but square. Only half the numeral remained on the stamps; no post-office name. On the slip bearing the marriage date, the groom's name could be read, but ink had spread over the bride's. I did not transcribe the name. One letter copied wrongly can later alter a lineage. The dried tulsi leaf broke into two while I was making the inventory; in the diary I had first written "one," and later added, "two pieces, originally one."

Each wet object had its own time. The jute sack could bear sunlight; the genealogical manuscripts could not. The bamboo slats could bear air; strong air was not suitable for paper carrying ink. I kept the wood separately, the sack in the shade of the courtyard; I did not hang the cloth on a line—the weight might tear the knot. I laid the paper flat, changed the cloth beneath the leaves, and did not touch any sheet that did not separate of its own accord. All this was slow. Outside, people were moving in haste; inside, my work was slow.

When the inventory was complete, I looked at the clock. 9:17. Bhola was still standing. I asked him again to sit. He sat, but no farther inside than the threshold. His eyes remained on the bundle. I asked, “Did you open it?” He said, “No.” “Did anyone else?” “Not that I saw.” “Was anyone there where you found it?” He said, “There were people, but everyone was looking for their own things.”

“Their own things” was a sentence worth recording. I wrote it in the diary. I did not write the conclusion that before the water recedes people search not for houses but for objects. A conclusion without evidence would have been mine. What Bhola had said was enough.

I tried to lift the first palm leaf. It was stuck to the second. The moment my nail touched it, an exceedingly thin layer of the surface began to lift. I stopped. I had a brass plate brought, turned it upside down, spread a strip of cloth over it, and gave the uppermost leaf as much support as I could. At that time I had no modern equipment for conserving records. In a panjika’s house, the means of saving old books came from experience—shade, air, dry cloth, neem leaves, distance from smoke, protection from rats, and protection from impatient hands.

Bhola asked, “Will it survive?” I said, “The paper?” He said, “All this.” I answered, “First save whatever letters have survived.” He asked nothing more.

There was no name on the outer cloth of the bundle. On one bamboo slat were three lines scored with a knife. On the other, something like half a letter. I did not remove the mud. Removing mud from a wet object is often the first act of destroying it. Let the mud dry; then it can be brushed away. In the time of water, patience too is an instrument.

At 10:05 Bhola stood up. I asked, “Why did you bring this bundle to me?” He said, “People in the village said that old written things should be shown to the panjika.” “Who said so?” He gave two names. The first I did not know. The second I knew, but his house was not in that village; it lay seven kos away. I wrote down both names. Names are written so that they may be checked later, not so that they may be believed.

As Bhola was leaving he said, “If you find anyone’s name, let us know.” Who “anyone” was in that sentence was not clear. Whether he was looking for the names of his own people or of the village, I did not ask. A question can sometimes narrow the limits of an answer. A man who has brought an object should not, at that very moment, be burdened with the work of giving testimony.

After he left, I made a separate place for the bundle in the northern room. I put two bricks on an old low wooden stool. On the bricks, a flat bamboo lattice. On the lattice, a piece of dry dhoti cloth. On that, the palm leaves and papers separately, as far as they could be separated. I opened the window, but allowed no direct draught. I drew the curtain halfway so that sunlight would not enter.

At 11:10 one corner of the first sheet lifted. The ink had bloomed, leaving a faint blue halo around the letters. But the middle line could be read. The first word was not “Shri”; it was a name. Before the name stood the word “village.” The letters after it had half dissolved in the water. I brought a magnifying glass. Under the glass the letters grew larger, not clearer. Enlarged uncertainty is not clarity.

I left that sheet and turned to another leaf. On palm leaf, the pressure of the stylus survives better than ink. The surface was wet, but here and there the impressed letters remained. When I cast the light from the side, the lines appeared. I read a lineage-origin, a village, the name of a man, his father’s name. After the fourth word the leaf had rotted away. The lineage seemed to stop there. I did not immediately make meaning out of it. In water damage, a line stops.

By noon I had eaten nothing. That is not written in the diary. At 12:48 the diary says: “All objects separated at preliminary level. Reading of letters not to be considered begun.” I underlined this sentence twice. Reading and seeing are different acts. What falls before the eye cannot therefore be treated as read.

At 1:20 Mohan called. I told him about the bundle. He was silent at first, then asked, “From where?” I gave the village name. Silence again at the other end. I asked, “Do you know this village?” He said, “I’ve heard the name.” His answer was brief. I did not tell him that the village matched the 1963 list found in the bundle. He, too, said nothing to me about the embankment. Between father and son that day two separate records were being made, and in both, some things were deliberately being left out. I did not write that conclusion in the diary that day; it is an understanding that came later.

All afternoon I kept changing the dry sheets beneath the wet pages. The smell of wet paper filled the room—earth, old ink, cloth, the first smell of mould. I did not record the smell; a genealogical register has no section in which to enter smells. Yet even now I could distinguish that smell from any other.

At 3:06 the outer sheet of the thick fold separated a little. Inside was a thin straight line of red ink. Above the line were two names, below it a date, and a small mark at the side. The names were not yet fully legible. I did not close the paper again, nor did I open it further. I left it in the state into which it had opened by itself.

At 4:11 I wrote the day’s last long entry in the diary: “Ownership of bundle unverified. Possible genealogical material. Severe water damage. Forced separation prohibited. Numbering deferred for now. Lineage-origin/village reading later.” Beneath it I wrote: “Bhola Sahni to be treated as witness to receipt.”

The moment I wrote the word “witness,” my hand stopped. In genealogical work, a witness usually appears in matters of marriage, kinship, dispute or doubt. Here the witness was merely to the arrival of a bundle. I did not yet know that the hardest thing in the bundle would not be to read the letters, but to read what the witnesses said.

Before evening, the upper three sheets had dried enough for an edge to be lifted. I raised the first. At the top of the second sheet beneath it, three names were written in the same ink. The first was clear. The middle letter of the second had washed away. The final vowel-sign of the third was erased. After the names, where the next line of descent should have been, there was only a wet white space.

I took it to be water damage. In the diary I wrote: “Three names; subsequent portion appears destroyed.” I retained the word “appears.” Without evidence, “destroyed” could not stand alone.

At night the bundle remained in the northern room. It was not put in the cupboard, because wet things decay in enclosed places. The key was of no use this time. I closed the door, left the window half open, and wrote the final line in the diary: “The book is not yet a book; first let it dry.”

The Panjikaṛ's Method

20 August 2008

A panjikaṛ's work is not merely to write down names. A name can be heard from anyone's mouth and put on paper. A genealogical register comes into being only when, with the name, its place, ancestors, relationships, source and the limits of verification are also recorded. On my first day my teacher told me: "What you have not understood, do not add. What you have heard, say you heard. What you have seen, say you saw." I have never received more useful instruction than those three sentences.

On the morning of 20 August, the upper five sheets of the wet bundle had dried a little. Before reading them, however, I wrote in my diary the method of genealogical work. The reason was simple. If one writes down one's rules before reading an unfamiliar record, there is less room later to alter them for convenience. To accept as evidence the line that pleases me, and dismiss as water damage the line that obstructs me—that is not a panjikaṛ's work.

I set down the method in seven parts: identification, lineage-origin, village, standing, relationship, evidence, and record. Seven words sound small; within a lineage, each of them carries the weight of generations.

I. Identification

The first entry concerning a person is the name, but a name alone is not an identity. The same name may occur in many villages, and in many houses within one village. Therefore the name should be accompanied by the father, grandfather, the maternal line where available, residence, title, or some other marker that distinguishes it from another identical name. A surname may change; pronunciation may change; spelling may change as well. When a panjikaṛ turns sound into letters, he must not imagine that the letters have become the owners of the sound. If two forms are current, both should be written, together with whose mouth each form was heard from.

Once, three men named Vachaspati came to me on the same day. One man's father was Harinath, the second's Harinarayan, the third's Harihar. All three wrote only "Vachaspati Mishra" on their papers. If the lines for father and grandfather were omitted, three lives would enter a single line. In a genealogical register, abbreviation is sometimes another name for falsehood.

2. Lineage-Origin

A lineage-origin is not merely a gotra. A gotra may be a broad identity; the lineage-origin identifies a particular point of beginning in a descent, or an acknowledged ancestral line. When recording it, one must not correct its spelling according to one's own preference. The form found on the old leaf should first be copied as it stands; the form now in use may then be written separately. If the names of two lineage-origins resemble one another, to treat them as identical is a serious fault. In the examination of a marriage, carelessness over one letter may erase the distance of many generations.

A client usually asks about lineage-origin in a hurry: "This is our line, isn't it?" A panjikar's answer should not be "yes" or "no" so quickly. First look at the line, the date, the hand of the first entry, the later additions. If anything on an old leaf is unclear, write "unclear." A panjikar's shame is not uncertainty; it is unverified certainty.

3. Village

A village is not the present postal address. The ancestral village of a lineage, the village of residence, the village of displacement, and the revenue village written on a document may all be different. Rivers change course, settlements move, a hamlet begins to be counted within another village, boundaries shift. Therefore, when reading the name of a village, read its time as well. "Where is it now?" and "Where was it then?" are different questions. A genealogical register must not force an old place into a present-day map.

In my own lifetime I saw five village names altered in government papers while the older forms continued in the genealogical books. One village shifted on paper between two districts, though not in people's mouths. Half of another was cut away by the river; the survivors settled elsewhere, yet at the time of marriages they still named the old village. A village is not only land; in a record it is the memory of a lineage's place. Memory is not evidence, but it is certainly a road towards evidence.

4. Standing

In a genealogical register, "standing" does not mean authority alone. It indicates which relationships were treated as valid, which branches were considered eligible to enter into marriage with which others, and on what recorded basis such a decision rested. Standing cannot be examined apart from the order of descent. A panjikar does not create standing from his own will; he states its position from old records, accepted genealogical chains, and whatever evidence is available. If the record is incomplete, a decision may be deferred. Deferral is not an insult; it is protection against a false decision.

People want a decision, especially when a marriage is being arranged. The date is fixed at home, guests invited, grain ordered, vehicles engaged. At such a moment, “the examination is not complete” is hard to hear. But a genealogical register must not become subject to the haste of a household. A wedding is for one day; once an error is written, its effects may endure for generations. The greater the pressure upon the panjikaṛ’s pen, the slower that pen should move.

5. Relationship

When recording relationships, a man’s paternal line alone is not sufficient. In examining a marriage one must also look at the distance through the maternal line, previous marriages, branches, known prohibitions, and old decision papers or equivalent records. The purpose of relationship is not to make comments upon people’s bodies, but to examine genealogical proximity and previously established boundaries. What is not in the genealogical register must not be written as though the register says it. A social practice that has no documentary basis should be kept separate.

I myself have failed at this rule many times. When the paternal line appeared clear, my mind would assume that half the work was done. My teacher would rebuke me: “Where did the mother go?” Then I would search for the maternal grandfather’s line. Genealogical books are filled with men’s names, but the distance relevant to a marriage is incomplete without the woman’s lineage. If fewer names were written, their importance does not thereby become less.

6. Evidence

Evidence may come in four forms—an old entry, a later verified record, the statement of a living witness, and an external document. The four do not carry equal weight. An old entry may contain an error; a living witness may forget; a name may be distorted in an official document; a family book may have been cut or extended for convenience. Therefore compare one source with another. If they do not agree, record the disagreement. A panjikaṛ’s work is not to erase disagreement, but to state where it lies.

The words spoken by a witness must remain the witness’s words. Do not turn “I had heard” into “I saw.” Do not turn “people used to say” into “it happened.” In oral testimony, ask about time—when was it heard, from whom, was that person alive then or not? Where no answer is found, leave a blank. The mind begins to place its own words into empty spaces; therefore preserving the blank is itself part of the work.

7. Record

The final rule concerns the making of the record. Write the date. Write the name or mark of the person who writes. Do not strike through the old line. If an error

is found, write the correction separately, with the reason. If a word cannot be read, do not copy a conjectured letter as though it were certain. If the paper is torn, say it is torn; if the ink is erased, say it is erased; if a line has been deliberately scraped away, and there is evidence, then write “scraped.” Water, termites, hands and intention leave four different kinds of damage. Not every vanished letter is the fault of water.

As I wrote that last sentence, my hand paused. I remembered the three names in the wet bundle in the northern room. The previous evening I had written: “subsequent portion appears destroyed.” I had not written the cause of the destruction. I had assumed water. While setting down my method, my own entry from the day before began to question me.

I opened the diary. Beside yesterday’s line I made a small mark: “Re-examine cause.” I did not strike out the earlier record. A panjikar’s first discipline should apply to his own writing as well.

The seven parts of the method could have ended there, but my teacher used to speak an eighth rule aloud and seldom wrote it on paper. The rule was: “A client’s desire and a record’s statement are not the same thing.” One person wants a longer lineage, another a shorter one; one wants a name added, another removed; one wants a title moved forward, another a marriage line pushed back. A genealogical register is not a document of wishes. What is verified will remain; what is disputed will be called disputed.

I understood the second half of this rule only much later: the panjikar’s own desire is not some pure substance separate from the client’s desire. I too have a clan, honour and humiliation, fears, interests, a family. So when the name of one’s own house enters the genealogical book, the pen does not remain impartial by itself. To keep it impartial, one needs rules, witnesses, another hand to examine the work. A record of one’s own lineage should not be written in solitude.

As I wrote this, I remembered many lines in my great-grandfather’s hand. I knew the letters—the long vowel sign, the “r” leaning to the right, the small double stroke after a date. In our house, his handwriting was accepted as evidence. But evidence and sacredness are not the same thing. A human being writes a genealogical register. A human hand tires, errs, fears, bends under pressure, and at times becomes greedy. Old handwriting should therefore be respected, not worshipped.

Before noon I folded the pages containing the method separately and placed them in the diary. At the top I wrote: “For my own use before reading the wet bundle.” This was not a public manual. It was not for a pupil. It was a paper meant to bind me to my own rules.

Then I opened the bundle. The upper leaves had now stiffened a little. On the first sheet, half the name of a lineage-origin could be read. On the second, the village was clear. On the third, a man’s name, his father, his grandfather. On the fourth, a marriage date. On the fifth, a structure resembling an old decision record, but the top had decayed. I began assigning numbers—Provisional 1,

Provisional 2, Provisional 3. The original order was unknown, so permanent numbering would have been improper.

Along the right edge of one sheet I saw a faint scratch. Yesterday I had taken it for shrinkage caused by water. Today, when I cast the light from the side, the scratch did not appear straight but repeated—like a sharp object passed over the same place several times. The letters were still unreadable. I did not write “scraped.” I wrote only: “Right edge: surface damage; cause uncertain.” Rule Seven permitted no more.

The page bearing the three names came before me again. After the first name ran a sequence of father and grandfather. After the second, two letters and then a blank. After the third, a fine line and then a white patch. Whether that whiteness had been made by water or by a hand could not yet be decided. I gave it oblique light, used the magnifying glass, and could not turn the page over. Conclusion deferred.

The benefit of writing down the method was immediate. Yesterday, on seeing three names, I could have begun making a story—flood, extinguished lineage, washed-away line. Today I saw only three names and three different kinds of blank. Sometimes a genealogical register asks no more of a human being than that he restrain his haste.

At 2:14 in the afternoon an elderly visitor came. He had heard the village name associated with the bundle. He said, “My ancestors were from there.” I asked the name. He gave it. The name was not on the sheet. He gave another pronunciation. I searched that too. No. Then he asked, “So I’m not from that village?” I said, “I can say only this much: in the part of this wet bundle that has so far been read, the name you gave me has not been found.”

He did not like the answer. He wanted to say that his grandfather’s marriage had been in such-and-such a house, and everybody knew it. I said, “‘Everybody knows’ is also a kind of evidence, but it must be written down—from whom, from how many, and since when.” He rose to leave. As he went he said, “You make too much of papers.” I did not answer. A panjikar’s work can sometimes look like unnecessary scrutiny. Remove the scrutiny and the genealogical register becomes memory alone.

In the evening I read the pages of method again. I drew a small line beneath the word “standing.” It occurred to me that standing concerned not only which relationship was accepted with whom, but also whose name was allowed to enter the record at all. But I did not add this thought to the rules. At that time it was not an established method; it was my private suspicion. A private suspicion does not take long to become a rule if one lets it.

At 8:35 p.m. Mohan called. He asked, “Is the book drying?” I said, “Yes.” He asked, “Found anything?” I said, “A lineage-origin, a village, some names.” He said, “That’s all?” I answered, “That is all for now.” I did not then tell him that there were three blank spaces after the three names. Rule Six said: extend a statement only when the evidence is complete.

After ending the call I wrote the day's final entry in the diary: "Method first, reading afterward." Beneath it I wrote the seven words again: "Identification. Lineage-origin. Village. Standing. Relationship. Evidence. Record." After the seventh word I left a space. I did not know then why I had left it. Now I understand: there is a method for examining what has been written in a genealogical register; what has knowingly not been written requires a different method. That was the method I still had to learn.

CHAPTER 04
Kosi — I

I am flowing now and this is called my flowing but my flowing is not walking along a single road I lift sand I leave sand behind I cut one bank I make another bank by night I may be beside a field and by dawn I may have reached its middle the wet line of a channel I abandon remains beneath the grass for many days and people call it the old channel when houses rise upon that line and bamboo is planted there and a tulsi altar is built the name becomes new but beneath the soil the fine sand keeps the memory of that former passage I descend between stones and when I reach level land I search for room to spread embankments rise to stop me levees rise earth is filled sacks are laid boulders arrive wire cages are tightened posts are driven registers are opened measurements are entered orders are issued signatures are made and beside all these my water goes on carrying its weight when someone says I have been stopped I do not understand the word stopped I understand only height I understand slope I understand wet earth I understand pressure at the edge I understand water filling from within and if somewhere the earth cannot bear my weight I go there for me breach and path are not different words they are different for people because people build houses draw boundaries measure fields write names open accounts and tell their children this land is yours I do not hear these words but every mark laid upon the land comes into my touch the furrow of the plough the stubble of paddy the rim of the pond the courtyard plastered with dung the brick foundation the ash of the hearth the ring of the well the roots of the peepal the bamboo of the watch-platform the ashes of the dead the posts of a wedding pavilion all of them come into me not once but in time and I cannot keep them all with me some I leave some I carry forward some I cover beneath sand some I uncover again and therefore what people believe lost sometimes appears once more upon a bank but what appears again is not as it was before the ink on paper is spread the wood is swollen earth clings to bone rust lies on metal half a letter of a name survives and the rest asks for conjecture I give no conjecture I only change the bank on which what survives comes to rest people call me one river but villages leave their shapes upon my body boat landings field ridges hearth ash the bamboo of platforms and innumerable footprints fall into my water but water does not ask their caste caste is asked upon the bank at the well in the line for food upon marriage papers and when a bundle of those papers soaks in my water the difference between letters is reduced to the colour of ink and the thickness of paper I do not preserve one name and erase another my water has no lineage but on my banks the books of lineages are kept and the line that looks straight inside a book is no straighter than my channel someone adds a letter someone leaves out a name someone records a marriage someone leaves the place of marriage blank someone knows a date of birth someone forgets the day of death someone with the scrape of a hand cuts one generation away from

another and the paper remains silent until someone opens it again I do not remain silent I have sound but my sound is not testimony by night it is the rubbing against the body of the embankment by day the tapping beneath a boat it is the rustle of grass caught in brushwood the muffled roar of a distant field-ridge breaking the knock of timber turning in deep water and sometimes a sound that brings people outside to look and they see nothing because what is changing does not become whole before the eye in a single instant first water fills the earth from within then the edge softens then a line appears then the line widens then people telephone then an office records the time then another office waits for an answer then someone counts sacks someone counts vehicles someone counts labourers someone counts kilometres someone says there is still time and I do not understand the word still I understand only the growing of pressure rain from the sky falls upon me mountain water enters me the earth at my edge becomes wet and in the narrow place allotted to me I increase depth I increase speed with the unending touch of water against the foot of the bank I remove soil and people seek the date of that removal although the event has been making itself for many days I keep no clock but clocks keep running beside me in telephones on office walls on the table of a relief camp in a panjika's diary and now while an old hand writes down the time and an engineer at the other end of the telephone holds back certain words and a boatman preserves a wet bundle between bamboo slats I do not stop before any of them I flow the memory of the old channel opens beneath the earth the pressure of the new channel climbs at the edge the village name is still intact upon paper the wall of the house still stands the tulsi leaves still take the wet air the ash in the hearth is still warm and no line has yet been completely written about the next touch of my water

Three Names

I did not hear the Kosi's first voice. What I had before me were four days of written entries, wet leaves, two cotton cords, and three names. The river might go on with its work; a panjikar's work was to examine the order of names. That morning I first separated the three sheets. Through the night they had lain between two layers of paper. A small wooden board had been placed above them, and on the board two old dictionaries, so that the leaves would not warp. At 5:58 in the morning I removed the board. The leaves were still damp, though less than the day before. I did not touch them with my fingers. With thin bamboo tweezers I raised an edge and altered the direction of the light.

The first name was "Shridhar Mishra." Before the name I could read "Kaushik"; after it, the first two letters of the village name were clear, the rest blurred by water. Father—"Vachaspati." Grandfather—"Raghupati." The sequence remained intact up to that point. Afterward, where the next record of a son or marriage connection should have stood, three lines appeared blank. The blank was not completely white. The paper itself was yellow-brown, and here and there it held fine particles of soot. My first thought was that the ink must have dissolved while the water passed over it. I wrote in the diary: "Name 1. Sequence available. Subsequent record illegible. Possible water damage." I did not underline the word possible.

The second name—"Ratneshwar Jha." The lineage-origin could be read; the village was unclear. Father: "Dayakant"; of the grandfather's name only the final "nath" survived. At the bottom of this sheet was a dark water stain. Its boundary was irregular, not circular. When I turned the sheet, the letters on the reverse had also spread at the same place. Here an inference of water damage was easier than with the first name. Yet after Ratneshwar's name there was a small mark—two dots with a thin upright line between them. In the old books of our house this sign meant "sequence continues," but there was nothing after it. I copied the sign into the diary and wrote: "Name 2. Continuation mark present. No subsequent record."

The third name took longer to read. I could not decide whether the first letter was "j" or "y." As the leaf dried, the outer skin of the ink was cracking. I set it down again. At 7:20 I looked a second time. The light now came directly from the east. The letter proved to be "j." The name—"Jayanarayan Mishra." Father: "Madhav"; grandfather: "Devadatta." The village name was the same one the boatman who brought the bundle had given me. After the name, for half a line, there appeared something like a fine scraping, but I did not write "scraping." In the diary I put only: "Name 3. Subsequent portion unclear. Examination pending."

The three names belonged to separate genealogical sequences, yet all three records seemed to fall within roughly the same decade. No complete date had survived. In one place there were two digits of an era year, in another a month, in a third the name of a lunar fortnight. If these three sheets were consecutive parts of the same book, such proximity in time would not have been unusual. But in all three places the subsequent sequence was broken. A coincidence of that kind can occur in genealogical records. A family may end; there may be no son; there may be daughters only; a man who has gone away may have no later details entered in the register; the sequence may continue in another volume; or a sheet may be missing. A panjikar's first duty is not to treat coincidence as a crime.

I opened my old chest. Inside were five copy-books my father had given me. I searched them for the village name. The first copy covered 1912 to 1927, the second 1928 to 1941, the third marriage records, the fourth copies of disputed entries, the fifth an incomplete index. The village name appeared once in the first copy and three times in the second. Shridhar, Ratneshwar, Jayanarayan—none of the three names appeared.

I did not treat their absence as evidence. The copy-books were not complete. My father had said many times that in genealogical work “not found” and “did not exist” are two different statements. The first describes the limits of the panjikar; the second is a judgment upon history. I wrote in the diary: “Unavailable in copies. Conclusion deferred in absence of original source.”

At 8:10 smoke rose from the hearth in the courtyard. My granddaughter's room was closed; she was in Delhi then, and at that time her room usually remained shut. I did not look at the pages while drinking tea. Keeping food or drink beside wet leaves was against my rules. After tea I washed my hands, dried them, and sat again.

One way of understanding the sequence of a name is through marriage records. If a man's direct genealogical sequence does not continue, his marriage connection may survive in the register of another house. I had three old copies of marriage records connected with that village. The ink on the first had faded, but it was legible. The name “Shridhar” appeared twice—once as a witness, once as the bride's maternal uncle. The father's name did not match. Therefore this was not my Shridhar. Ratneshwar did not appear in the second copy. In the third there was a “Jayanarayan,” but the village was different. Identity of name does not prove relationship. Genealogical registers contain many identical names.

At 10:05 a question arose: why did the writing break off after all three names? I immediately restrained the urge to write an answer. I wrote down the question and left the place for the answer blank. Leaving a blank is itself part of the method. To give language to what is not yet known is not to make history; it is to make a story. I am not a writer of stories. I am a panjikar.

After writing that sentence, for some time I looked at my own hand. An eighty-year-old hand. Old ink stains beside the nails. The joint of the forefinger hard. The skin thick beneath the right thumb. I have no count of how many names this hand has written. But it would not be true to say that a name survives

merely because it has been written. A name lasts only when someone later seeks it, reads it, and acknowledges the relationship. A page may remain, but if the relationship does not, the record may become only a word.

At 11:18 the boatman came again—the same man who had brought the bundle the day before. The lower part of his dhoti was still black with mud. He asked, “Will the book survive?”

I said, “Some leaves will. Some will not.”

He did not ask to hear the three names. He asked only the village name. I told him. He nodded. After a while he said, “The people of that village are scattered through the camp. No one has papers. When they make the ration list, they will ask the village name.”

I asked, “Has your name been entered in the ration record?”

He said, “Not as of yesterday.”

I wrote his name, his father’s name and village on a separate page of the diary. Not in the genealogical register. He said, “Put it in this book.”

I told him, “This book is not your ration record.”

He did not laugh. He said, “A written name is a written name.”

I did not answer at once. To him, perhaps, all records had begun to serve the same purpose: let the name exist, and the person will be acknowledged. No name on the government list, no grain. No name in the genealogical register, no relationship. The rules of the two records were different, but in both, when a name was omitted, the consequence fell upon a person. I let his name remain in the diary, but did not enter it in the genealogical book.

After the boatman left, I read the three names again. Shridhar. Ratneshwar. Jayanarayan. Not aloud. In my mind. Pronouncing a name does not alter the shape of its letters, but sometimes sound awakens an old familiarity. At Jayanarayan, for one instant, a page from my great-grandfather’s book came back to me. The memory was not clear. I took out the fourth copy from the chest—the copy of disputed records. On page 17 I found “Jayanarayan,” but there was no surname, no father’s name. Only one sentence: “Matter concerning Jayanarayan deferred.” The date was blurred.

“Matter deferred” was not a usual formula in our genealogical registers. I had never heard my father use that sentence. In my great-grandfather’s papers I had seen “decision deferred,” “evidence pending,” “standing disputed,” but seldom “matter deferred.” I made a copy of the page and returned the original copy-book to the chest.

At 1:37 in the afternoon Mohan called. Many voices could be heard behind him. He was at a relief camp. He asked, “Babuji, found any names?”

I said, “Three.”

“Whose?”

I gave him all three.

There was silence at the other end for three or four seconds. Then he said, “I don’t know any of these names.”

I said, “You need not know them.”

He asked, "Anything after them?"

"No."

"Meaning?"

"No meaning yet."

He seemed about to say something, but someone behind him called him. He said, "I'll call again tonight." The line went dead.

I wrote the time of the call in the diary. I did not write Mohan's silence. A diary was a record of facts, not a record of sound. Yet the question remained in my mind: why had he gone silent for a few seconds after hearing the three names? I had no answer. Therefore the question too was not written.

By afternoon the leaves had flattened a little more. On Shridhar's sheet, at the beginning of the first of the three blank lines, I saw an exceedingly faint letter. "Pu" or "pau." I applied the magnifying glass. "Pu" could not be established. A fibre of the paper looked like ink. I removed the glass. Water does not merely destroy; sometimes it makes the shape of the thing that has been destroyed. The panjika's eye can create illusion in the very act of reading. For that reason I wrote: "Uncertain mark—not to be treated as record."

Ratneshwar's sheet presented another difficulty. After the continuation sign, the paper in the blank portion was slightly thinner than the rest of the page. Wet paper can become so through friction. The sheets may have stuck and then separated. I saw no mark there of any sharp object. Therefore I retained the inference of water damage.

I looked at Jayanarayan's page last. The fine line across half a line stood before me again. Yesterday I had taken it for a scratch; today I had written that examination remained. After drying, broken paper fibres could be seen within the line, but the breaks did not all run in one direction. Water, rubbing, or something deliberately removed—three possibilities remained open. I did not write the third in the diary. To set down a grave possibility without evidence may allow the possibility itself to assume the shape of evidence.

At 4:21 in the evening I made a table of the three names. Name, father, grandfather, lineage-origin, village, available date, condition of sheet, condition of subsequent sequence. Eight columns. Three rows. Where something was not known, I did not put a dash; I wrote "unknown." A dash is a blank. "Unknown" is a boundary of knowledge. The distinction mattered to me.

Once the table was made, something became visible: the three records had not been written by different hands. The slant of the letters, the vowel signs, the shape of "r," the manner of writing numerals—all seemed to belong to the same writer. A writer may have kept the genealogical register for many years, so the dates could differ. But if all three records were in the same hand and all three sequences broke in the same fashion, the coincidence of water damage became a little less easy.

I stopped there. "Less easy" is not evidence. In the diary I wrote: "Writer possibly one. Handwriting examination required."

There was no equipment for handwriting examination in the house. I had only my eyes, the old copies, and time. I knew my great-grandfather's hand, but familiarity is not proof. I deferred the decision until the next day.

The evening light declined. The pages were again placed between layers of paper. Copies of the three names went into separate envelopes. On each envelope I wrote: "Provisional copy. Verification against original pending." I did not write the names Shridhar, Ratneshwar, Jayanarayan, only the numbers 1, 2, 3. An envelope bearing a name might be opened by someone else in the house. A panjika's duty of confidentiality is not only to living clients. The names of the dead may also awaken disputes within a family.

Mohan did not call that night. I waited until 8:55. Then, before closing the diary, I wrote the day's conclusion: "Three names. Subsequent sequence unavailable. Water damage possible. Other cause unverified. Decision deferred."

As soon as I wrote "water damage possible," I felt a certain ease. Ease is not evidence. I knew that. Even so, when a sheet has come wet from a river, the human mind naturally wishes to attribute its blank spaces to water. I too am human. The panjika's method was made against precisely that human ease.

I closed the diary. I did not place the chest key beneath the pillow; I kept it in its old place, tied to the cord at my waist. The three sheets would remain under pressure through the night. I would look again at dawn. So far, no lineage had been erased in my record. There were only three names, after which nothing could be read.

CHAPTER 06

Mohan's Call

Mohan had not called in the night. In the morning I did not write that down. A call not coming was not an event, only the non-fulfilment of an expectation; I did not record expectations in my diary. At 5:44 I looked again at the three wet sheets. At 6:12 the fine line on Jayanarayan's sheet appeared as before. At 7:05 the leaves were placed under pressure again. At 7:37 the first call came. The number was not Mohan's.

At the other end was a young man. He said he was speaking from the relief camp and that Mohan Babu was busy. He asked, "Ramanu-grah Mishra?" I said, "Yes." He said, "Mohan Babu says you should not leave the house." I asked, "Why did he not call himself?" The young man answered, "He is in a meeting." I asked, "Whose meeting?" He said, "The department and the district administration." Then someone behind him called his name. He said, "He'll call again." The line went dead.

I wrote down the time. "7:37—unknown young man; message from Mohan—do not leave the house." I had not been able to ask the young man's name, so I wrote "unknown." I had not asked the name of the relief camp either. The entry was incomplete.

At 8:11 Mohan himself called. His voice sounded tired, but I did not write "tired" in the diary. Tiredness is an inference. Behind him names were being called continuously—"Sadarpur... Bhelahi... Basantpur..." Between them came the sound of papers being turned. Mohan's first sentence was, "Babuji, are you all right?"

I said, "I am all right."

He asked, "Has water entered the house?"

"No."

"The well?"

"I am not using it for now."

"Drinking water?"

"Two pitchers remain. Ramdev brought them yesterday."

He said, "Boil the water before you drink it."

I said, "I know."

Again he said, "Don't go outside."

"I received the message."

The conversation might have ended there. But he did not put down the telephone. Nor did I. At the other end the calling of names continued. At one point he said to someone, "Write the family number separately in this list." Then he said to me, "The book?"

I said, "It is drying."

"The three names?"

"The same."

"Anything after them?"

"Not yet."

He was silent. I could have asked, "Why didn't you call last night?" I did not. Such a question usually receives one of a small number of answers—fatigue, meeting, battery finished, network failure. The question I needed to ask was not that one.

Mohan said, "There is a great difficulty with names here."

I asked, "Whose names?"

"People's. The same village has been written three different ways. In one list a hamlet is separate, in another it is part of the main village. Someone's voter card has washed away, someone's ration card. Everyone says, write the name first."

I asked, "On what documentary basis?"

I could not tell from the sound whether he laughed. He said, "Your genealogical rules won't work here."

"Will a record work without rules?"

"We have to make it work."

"Having to make it work and its working are not the same thing."

He fell silent. Again someone called him from behind. He said, "One minute." The line remained open. I could hear papers rubbing, plastic chairs being moved, people speaking. Someone said, "Two families have been left out." Someone else answered, "Distribute first to those already on the list." Mohan's voice came from a distance: "Write the omitted names separately. Don't strike anything out."

That sentence caught my attention. "Don't strike anything out." The words belonged to the panjika's rule, but he was using them for a relief list. A few moments later he came back to the telephone.

"Babuji?"

"Yes."

"Where were you?"

"Here."

"I thought the call had dropped."

"No."

I could have told him that I had heard his "don't strike anything out." I did not. In a conversation between father and son, it is sometimes unnecessary to reveal what one has overheard.

Mohan asked, "Do you have medicine?"

"For six days."

"I'll send some."

"See to the people in the camp first."

"Aren't you one of the people in the camp?"

"I am still at home."

He did not answer. It seemed to me that he might have been irritated, but that was an inference. I never entered a state of mind in the diary merely on the basis of a voice.

After a few moments he said, "I'll remain on this side for two more days."

"Departmental orders?"

"Yes."

"Will you go to Kusaha?"

For the first time there was complete silence from Mohan's end. The background noise remained, but he did not speak. Then he said, "Not now."

I asked, "When?"

"When they say."

"Who?"

"Orders will come from above."

"Above whom?"

At this he said, "Babuji, not all this on the telephone right now."

I could have asked what "all this" meant. I did not. The phrase was itself unclear, and around uncertainty there is room for many conjectures. I restrained conjecture.

Mohan was a junior engineer in the Water Resources Department. On the day of his appointment I had entered nothing in the genealogical register; genealogical registers do not record livelihoods. I had, however, written in the household diary: "Mohan appointed; Water Resources." I do not now remember the date. His first posting was in a subdivision responsible for embankment maintenance. Because of that fact, whenever people in the village spoke of erosion, repairs, sacks, boulders, payments, measurement books or contractors, they asked me questions as though being his father meant that departmental records were kept with me. They were not.

After the breach at Kusaha, the weight of the questions had changed. Since the previous evening two people had already asked, "Was Mohan Babu involved in that work?" Both times I had answered, "I do not know." The answer accorded with the facts. A father does not know many things, especially about his son's office. Yet saying "I do not know" does not make the question disappear.

On the telephone I asked, "How far from here is your subdivision?"

Mohan said, "What does distance mean at a time like this?"

"The question is about distance."

"One distance on the map, another by road, and now a third by what can be reached."

"From Kusaha?"

Again he was silent. Then he said, "That was not my regular area."

The answer went a little farther than the question I had asked. I felt an urge to write "regular area" in the diary, but the call was still in progress. The pen was in my hand. I wrote only the time.

I could have said, "Not your regular area—but the work?" I did not. An accusation was entering the question. An accusation without evidence is against

the panjikar's method. Whether the same rule should apply within a family, I had never settled.

Mohan said on his own, "Many agencies work on an embankment. The department, contractors, local teams, Nepali officials, people from the Centre... everything is not in one person's hands."

I took note of the list. I had not asked the question; he was supplying the answer.

"I did not say one person."

He replied at once, "I'm speaking generally."

"I understand."

"There—you said 'I understand' in that way again."

I asked, "What way?"

"When you have written something down but do not say it."

I should have answered. I did not. Between a father and son there are old sentences whose origin is forgotten but whose meaning both understand. Mohan had watched me write in diaries since childhood. He believed that I wrote instead of speaking. Perhaps that was partly true.

Someone in the background said, "Sir, Engineer Sahib is calling." Mohan answered, "Coming." Then he said to me, "I'll call at night."

I said, "You said that yesterday too."

He fell silent. Then said, "Yesterday it was not possible."

"I understand."

"There, the same thing again."

"What?"

"Nothing."

The call ended. It was 8:26. The conversation had lasted a little more than fifteen minutes. In the diary I wrote: "8:11–8:26, Mohan. Inconsistency in names/villages in relief records. Advice not to leave house. Said medicine would be sent. At camp under departmental orders. Has not yet gone to Kusaha." After writing the last sentence I stopped. I added: "That was not my regular area"—preceded by the words "Mohan's statement." A statement and a fact must remain separate.

I did not enter the sentence about "many agencies," because it was a general statement, not a verified account. Even so, the sentence remained in my mind.

Mohan did not call again by noon. Twice I heard motor vehicles outside. Once something was said over a loudspeaker, but I could not hear clearly. I saw three families from the northern side of the village moving south; bundles on their heads, children in their arms. I did not leave the veranda. Whether I was obeying Mohan's message or judging the condition of the road, I cannot say.

At 11:49 a woman called. She identified herself as Mohan's colleague. Her name was Kiran. She asked whether Mohan had kept any old map at home. I said, "Not to my knowledge." She asked, "Old papers?" I said, "Which papers?" She said, "Not the embankment—old village maps, revenue maps." I told her, "I

have genealogical registers, not revenue maps.” She said, “I understand,” and ended the call.

I recorded the call in the diary. “11:49—Kiran, Mohan’s colleague; question concerning old village/revenue map.” For the first time, on one page, I saw written the village name from the wet bundle and a departmental question about maps. Whether there was any connection between the two was unknown. Therefore I added nothing.

At 1:07 in the afternoon a short message came from Mohan: “Will get the medicines to you by evening.” It was not in Devanagari, but in Roman letters shaped into something like Maithili. I did not copy the message; I recorded only its meaning.

At 2:55 a motorcycle arrived. A young man handed me a plastic packet of medicines. It contained tablets for blood pressure, fever tablets, two packets of ORS, and a bar of soap. There was no prescription. I asked the young man’s name—Subhash. He was a volunteer at the relief camp. He could not say for certain whether the medicines had been provided by Mohan or by the administration. I accepted the packet and entered an inventory of its contents in the diary. Where the source was uncertain, I did not write “Mohan” as the source.

As Subhash was leaving he said, “Mohan Babu has been working day and night.” I merely nodded. Praise too is not evidence.

At 5:20 in the evening I looked again at the three names. Shridhar, Ratneshwar, Jayanarayan. Nothing new about them had emerged from Mohan’s telephone calls. I deliberately kept departmental matters and genealogical matters on separate pages. The mind seeks connections; the work of a record is to keep things separate until a connection has been established.

At 6:43 the electricity failed. The telephone battery was below half. I made no arrangement to charge it. A night call could be missed. I was surprised that the possibility disturbed me. All day I had kept saying to myself that a call was only an event, not an expectation; but as evening fell I was waiting for the telephone. The diary and the mind have different rules.

At 8:09 Mohan called. His voice was lower than before. There was less noise behind him. Perhaps he was outside the camp or in a room.

He asked, “Did you get the medicines?”

“Yes.”

“Everything all right?”

“The items are intact. The source is unclear.”

After a short silence he said, “Babuji, does the source have to be written down even for medicines?”

“For whatever I write in the diary, the source matters.”

“I sent them.”

“I’ll write that now.”

He laughed. This time the laughter was unmistakable. He said, “You have not changed.”

I said, “At eighty there is little time left for changing.”

He said, "Not little time. Little desire."

I had an answer to that sentence—"You too." I did not say it.

There was silence on the telephone for a few moments. Then Mohan himself asked, "What are people saying in the village?"

"About what?"

"The embankment."

It was the first time he himself had spoken the word "embankment." I said, "Many things."

"About me?"

I did not answer at once. It was true that two people had asked. It was also true that no accusation supported by evidence had been put before me. I said, "Two people asked whether your work was in that area."

"What did you tell them?"

"That I do not know."

There was a sound like a long breath, but I did not consider it a fact fit for the diary. He said, "That's all?"

I said, "That's all."

"And you?"

"What about me?"

"What do you think?"

The question reached the edge of the one thing that had circled between us all day. I could have asked about the repairs at Kusaha, the measurement book, the contract, inspections, payments, which files bore his signature. I could have said, Why are people asking your name? I could have spoken simply as a father: Tell me the truth. But I had no paper, no direct evidence, only my son's voice and other people's questions.

I said, "An opinion is not evidence."

Mohan answered at once, "You speak to me in the language of the genealogical register too."

I said, "Changing the language will not change the facts."

He said, "Not all facts are on paper."

At that sentence I remembered the three names. I could have said, "What is not on paper has another kind of evidence." I did not. In that moment, the telephone call between father and son would have become an argument about the genealogical method.

Mohan said, "I am extremely tired."

This time he himself named the fatigue, so it could be entered in the diary. I said, "Rest."

He said, "Not yet."

"Food?"

"Had it."

"At what time?"

"Don't remember."

"That answer is unverified."

He laughed again, but briefly. He said, "Are you my father or an investigating officer?"

I answered, "It may not be possible to avoid being both."

After the words escaped me, I considered their meaning myself. Mohan remained silent. After a while he said, "I'll call again tomorrow."

I said, "Yes."

Before ending the call he said, "Babuji." Only that. I said, "Yes." What he had wanted to say, he did not say. What I had wanted to ask, I did not ask. The call ended. It was 8:32.

I opened the diary and wrote: "20:09–20:32, Mohan. Confirmation of receipt of medicine. Discussion of questions in village concerning department/embankment. Mohan's question—"What do you think?" Answer—"An opinion is not evidence." Mohan—"Not all facts are on paper." I wrote the last sentence word for word. I put it in quotation marks because it was his statement.

Beneath it I felt like writing: "Questions remain." I did not. Once a diary begins making a list of unanswered questions, the mind begins composing answers of its own.

At 9:07 I checked the board placed over the three wet sheets. Everything was in place. The key was on the cord at my waist. The telephone battery was at twenty-three per cent. Darkness outside the house. No sound of any distant vehicle.

I wrote the final entry of the day: "No new fact concerning the three names." After that one line I stopped the pen. There was no new fact concerning Mohan either. There were only many sentences, and between those sentences a question spoken aloud by neither side. A blank line is visible in a genealogical register. On the telephone a blank cannot be heard; yet it is there.

CHAPTER 07

The Camp

The morning call was from Subhash, the young man who had brought the medicines the day before. He said a list was being made at the relief camp for people from three villages, and members of the same family were giving the name of their village in three different forms. Mohan had given him my name. Subhash asked, "Could you come for a little while?" I asked first about the time, then the reason. After hearing the reason I said, "I will not certify a government list." He said, "Not certify it. Just help us understand the names."

At 7:45 I left the house. The chest was locked. The three wet sheets were inside. In my shoulder bag I carried the diary, two blank sheets, a pencil, my spectacles, and the old village list. Subhash had brought a motorcycle, but instead of sitting behind him I said I would walk half a kos. He looked at my age and said nothing. In the end, after we saw two deep water-filled hollows in the road, I got on the motorcycle.

The camp was in the compound of the high school. At the entrance stood a blue tarpaulin. Beneath it was a table; on the table, two registers, carbon paper, three seals, red thread, pins in a plastic box, a stack of paper, drinking water in an empty glucose bottle, and two cups. On the right, sacks of rice. On the left, a medicine chest. A line of people in the veranda. Rows of tarpaulins in the field. Mud splashed across the school's nameboard.

The first register was headed "Family Registration." The second, "Distribution." The word for "registration" had been misspelled; I did not correct it. I had no authority to amend the spelling in a government record.

Subhash gave me a chair. I asked, "What is the work?" He placed a sheet before me. At the top were the names of three villages: Basantpur, Sonbarsa, Belahi. After Basantpur, in brackets, was written "Eastern Hamlet." Nothing after Sonbarsa. After Belahi, a name struck out twice. He said, "People say the revenue village is one thing, the hamlet another, the post office another." I said, "Then write all three." He said, "The form has space for only one."

That was the first inconsistency: on the land a person could belong to more than one place; on the form, to one.

The first woman in line was Kaushalya Devi. About fifty-five, a widow. The employee asked, "Head of family?" She said, "I am." He paused for two moments. Then wrote: Kaushalya Devi. In the box for husband's name: "Late Lakshminarayan Jha." Two sons, both away. In the camp she was alone. Family size: one. She would receive rice for one person. If one searched for her in a genealogical register, her name would not appear on the principal line; her husband's and sons' line of descent would. In the relief register, the family began with her.

I wrote the difference on my paper: "Widow herself head of household." No comment.

The second family had five people. The man was Shambhunath Yadav, the woman Parvati, two children, and an old woman. The employee asked the old woman's relationship. Shambhunath said, "Mother." The old woman at once said, "Not mother. Aunt." Shambhunath did not laugh. He said, "She lives with us." The employee asked, "Count her in the family?" Shambhunath said, "Count her." The old woman said, "Write my name separately." Three minutes were spent deciding whether rations should be calculated for five or four. In the end, the old woman received a separate serial number, but the tarpaulin number remained the same.

A genealogical register asks the name of a relationship. A relief register asks the number of bodies present. The questions are not the same.

A young man came third. His voter card had washed away. Name—Ajit Paswan. He gave his village as "Belahi." The employee looked at the list. "There are two Belahis. Which one?" The young man pointed south. "The one inside the embankment." The employee asked, "Revenue thana?" The young man was silent. An old man standing behind him said, "The old name was Belahi Musahari." The employee stopped his pencil. The form had no box for caste, but neither did it have a separate place for the hamlet. In the end he wrote "Belahi—inside."

"Inside" was not a revenue name. But that was how people in the camp were identifying the village now.

Subhash asked me, "Is this right?" I said, "The question is not right or wrong. There must be a way to find the person again." He added "Musahari" in brackets after "Belahi—inside."

This time I did not stop his hand. The panjikar's rule says that a word heard should retain its source. Here the source was the old man standing before us. I asked his name—Ramcharitra Sada. The employee had not written it. On my own sheet I wrote: "Local witness: Ramcharitra Sada."

Ramcharitra Sada asked, "Why is my name going on the paper?" I said, "You said the hamlet has long been known by that name." He said, "Then write it." That was all.

At the other end of the veranda children's names were being entered. Many birth dates were unknown. One mother said, "Two years before the flood." The employee began estimating the year. I said, "Mark an estimate separately." He looked at me. He was under thirty. He said, "Baba, things cannot be done like that everywhere here." I answered, "Then at least do not write what is uncertain as though it were certain." He wrote "approximately" on the paper.

Mohan was not there. Subhash said he had gone to another centre. I did not ask which one.

At 10:05 distribution began. Serial numbers were called. People showed their slips. A sack of rice was opened. Iron weights, a balance, a plastic bucket. Five kilos, ten kilos, according to family size. One woman's slip showed four

members; the register showed three. She said her daughter had come from another camp during the night. The employee said, "Her name is not on the list." The woman took her daughter by the hand and brought her forward. A girl of about twelve. Four bodies present. Three in the register.

The employee said, "Her name will be added tomorrow." The woman asked, "And today's rice?" The employee looked at the distribution register, then around him. Whether he finally gave five kilos extra I could not see for certain; the bucket disappeared in the crowd. I could not enter that as a fact in my diary. I wrote only: "Slip 4, register 3; girl present."

At eleven a man recognised me. His name was Nityanand Jha. He said his grandfather was in my great-grandfather's genealogical register. I said, "Possible." He immediately asked, "Then write down my family." I asked, "For what purpose?" He showed me his relief slip. It listed a family of seven; five were in the camp. Two sons were in Delhi. The employee said that people not in the camp were not to be counted in the immediate relief calculation. Nityanand said, "They belong to this house too." The employee said, "They are not present here."

Nityanand wanted the genealogical record before me to prove that the two sons belonged to the family. The genealogical record could do that. The relief register wanted proof of presence. The genealogical record could not provide it.

I told him, "Genealogical relationship and presence for relief are two different records." He was not satisfied. He said, "Paper is paper." I said, "When the purpose changes, the meaning of evidence changes." He folded his slip and went away.

After saying that, I looked at my own paper. In the chapter on the panjika's method I had written that a record's authority comes from its purpose. Here the same thing stood before me in another form.

Near noon a Musahar family came. The man's name was Budhan Sada, the woman Rampatiya, with three children. They had no identity document. The water had taken their hut in the night. The employee asked, "Any paper?" Budhan shook his head. From behind, Ramcharitra Sada said, "I know them." The employee said, "Two witnesses are needed." A second witness was sought. Five minutes later the school cook came; she knew Rampatiya. The names were entered.

I opened my old village list. There was no genealogical record concerning that hamlet. The absence was not surprising. My registers were not a complete census of every caste. Yet in the camp register Budhan, Rampatiya and their three children became five clear lines, while in my own records there was not a single line for their lineage.

For the first time I saw two registers open together—one in my bag, one on the table. In one, seven generations of some people, but not even the names of the five people standing before me. In the other, five people present today, but for even one generation behind them there was only the word of two living witnesses.

I made no comment. I drew two columns: "Genealogical Record" and "Relief Record." Beside the Budhan Sada family, the first column blank, the second five. Beside Kaushalya Devi, the first showed relationship through her husband's lineage, the second showed her as head of family. Beside Nityanand, the first could establish a relationship of seven members, the second recorded five present.

The two registers did not prove each other false. But if anyone treated either register as the whole truth, a human being became smaller. I did not write that sentence in the diary; a diary is not the place for conclusions.

At 1:10 food was distributed. Flattened rice, jaggery, a small packet of salt. In one corner of the veranda stood a drum of drinking water. Its tap was loose. Mud beneath it. Two children filled empty bottles. One corner of a tarpaulin rose in the wind and fell again. The school bell hung without a rope. On the blackboard in a classroom the date of the last lesson was still written: "16-8-08." Beneath it, in chalk: "Homework."

Subhash tried to give me food. I took half a portion of flattened rice, no jaggery. He said, "You have been eating less since yesterday." I asked, "What is the source of that statement?" He said, "My eyes." I said, "Evidence insufficient." He laughed.

A little after two, a government employee came with an old list prepared at the block office. He read out the names. Some families said their village names had been distorted. "Sonbarsa" appeared as "Sonvarsha," "Belahi" as "Belahi" with a different spelling, "Parsauni" as "Parsauna." The employee said, "Whatever was entered in the computer is what got printed."

I asked, "The original paper?" He said, "At the office." "Whose handwriting?"—"Don't remember." "Correction?"—"Later."

I kept the answer in mind. In genealogical work, when an incorrect name is corrected, the old reading is not obliterated; the reason is added with the new record. I did not know the procedure for correcting errors in a government list, so a comparison would not have been proper. Still, when I heard "whatever was entered in the computer," it occurred to me that the scribe of the new record had become invisible.

By three the line had shortened. Corners of papers on the table were bent. Blue from the carbon paper stained hands. Ink in the seal pad was running low. A stain of rice marked page 17 of the distribution register. A round drop of water marked page 9 of the registration register. No register is sacred; all become soiled in use.

Subhash showed me the three village names again. Two families from Basantpur called their hamlet "New Basantpur." The revenue list did not contain the word "New." I said, "Do not strike out the old name. Add the current name in brackets." Subhash did so. Whether my panjika's method had been applied to a government paper or this was merely ordinary caution, I did not decide.

Then an elderly woman came. Name—Phulkali Devi. She gave her natal village as Chhatapur, her marital village as Basantpur. The employee had asked

for the family's permanent village, and wrote the marital village. The old woman said, "I have been at my natal home for three months." The question arose: displaced from which village? The house at her husband's village was under water, but at the time of the event she was at her natal home. On which list should relief be given?

The employee scratched his head. Subhash looked at me. I said, "My genealogical register cannot answer this question."

Phulkali Devi did not laugh. She said, "If I am here, where will my name be written?" In the end the employee put her name on the Basantpur list and added in the remarks: "At natal home at time of event." The small note seemed useful to me. A person's place had not been closed inside a single word.

At 4:10 Mohan arrived. Mud on his shoes, the sleeves of his shirt rolled to the elbows. On seeing me he first looked at Subhash. He asked, "Babuji, when did you come?" I answered, "Left home at seven forty-five; reached here at eight twenty." Mohan said, "I wasn't asking for the time."

I said, "The question was 'when.'" He said nothing.

He looked at the register. Turned the pages. Paused briefly at Budhan Sada's name, not at Kaushalya Devi's. Read the note beside Phulkali Devi. Subhash said, "Babuji said not to strike out the old name." Mohan looked at me. Whether what I saw in his eyes was fatigue or displeasure, I could not say.

Mohan said, "Things have to be written very quickly here." I said, "Haste increases the need to record reasons; it does not reduce it." He answered, "If we keep writing every reason, when will people receive the supplies?"

I accepted his point. I said, "Then write the minimum—on whose statement."

Mohan put his finger on page 9. "This is a government record, not a genealogical register."

I said, "Precisely for that reason, more people's lives depend upon it." As soon as the sentence left me, I felt that it was not the language of a diary. Mohan too was silent for a few moments.

He said, "Come with me. We'll leave the house." I said, "Yes."

Before leaving, I looked once more at the first five pages of the registration register. Name, age, relationship, village, identification, number of members. Very little by the formulae of a genealogical register; very much by the immediate needs of life. This register had no gotra, no lineage-origin, no genealogical standing. My genealogical register had no ration quantity, no tarpaulin number, no estimated age of a child standing present. The empty boxes in the two records were different.

As I put the old village list back into my bag, the line for Budhan Sada's family returned to me. Blank in my list. Five names in the camp list. Then Kaushalya Devi—identified in my genealogical register through her husband, here head of the family in her own right. Nityanand—in the genealogical record a lineage including sons away from home; in relief, only the five present.

At the top of my sheet I wrote: "Two records. Purposes different. Absences different." Nothing beneath it.

Mohan was bringing out the motorcycle. The tarpaulins in the field flapped in the evening wind. The line was almost gone. But the register on the table remained open. The employee was writing the final slip. A child stood beside his elbow, watching the letters of his own name.

On the way home Mohan spoke only once. "You should not stand around so long in all this." I said, "I was sitting most of the time." Then silence.

At one place the motorcycle slowed to cross water on the road. I pressed the bag against my chest. There was no genealogical register inside, only the village list and my written account of the day. The original sheets were safe in the chest at home. Even so, my hand closed around the bag of its own accord.

At 5:56, after reaching home, I opened the diary. I copied the camp details in sequence. The last line I wrote was: "What is in the relief register is a record of immediate presence; what is in the genealogical register is a record of descent and relationship. The absence of one is not evidence supplied by the other."

Then I took out the three wet sheets. Shridhar. Ratneshwar. Jayanarayan. The later sequence after them was still unclear. All day at the camp I had watched names being added. At home I was looking at blanks after three names. The inconsistency between two kinds of register was not sufficient reason to change my inference of water damage.

Before closing the diary I wrote only one question: "Is a name not being found the same thing as a name not being written?" I wrote the date before the question. I did not write an answer.

The Erased Line

The morning after returning from the camp, I opened the wet sheets again. In three days the smell of the paper had changed. At first it had been a mingling of water, mud and old ink; now the smell of drying fibre was stronger. The pages were not wholly dry. Some edges were still soft. I did not open the window. The wind outside was strong. I spread cotton cloth over the table in the inner room and placed the first sheet upon it. Time: 6:42.

The first entry in the diary: “Re-examine subsequent sequence after the three names. Distinguish water damage from record damage.”

The signs of water damage were familiar to me. Letters spread; ink leaves green-brown shadows toward the edges; paper fibres swell; two sheets stick together and transfer a reversed impression of letters. Sometimes water does not lift a letter away; it merely distorts its form. If the upper surface of the paper has been abraded, if the fibres lean in one direction, or if the paper has become thinner where the letters should have been, then another cause must be sought.

First name: Shridhar. The blank beyond it was somewhat lighter. Earlier I had taken this to be the reverse effect of a water stain. Today the sheet was drier, and the edge of the pale area could be seen more clearly. It was not straight. Roughly two fingers long and half a finger wide. Fine fibres rose from its surface. I did not touch it with a nail. I drew a thin bamboo splint along the edge. The splint caught in the fibres. A water stain does not offer such resistance.

I wrote in the diary: “Blank after Shridhar—surface abraded?” I added the question mark.

Second name: Ratneshwar. A blank there too. But here the ink had spread and the paper surface remained intact. Water damage possible. Third: Jayanarayan. After his name the right corner of the sheet had torn away. Here the subsequent entry might indeed have washed or torn off. The three blanks did not have one cause. That was the first new fact.

I returned to Shridhar’s line. On the left side of the table lay a small brass cover from an oil lamp. I sometimes used its polished inner surface to redirect light. The dawn light was weak. I turned the cover toward the window so that the sheet received the light obliquely. The lifted fibres cast shadows. Within the abraded area, at three or four points, were exceedingly small flecks of ink. No letter could be read. But there had been writing on the surface and it had later been removed—there was enough basis to say that much.

I did not write “erased” in the diary. I wrote: “Strong possibility of human abrasion.” A conclusion and a possibility are not the same thing.

At 7:10 I opened the old chest. The genealogical register of our own house was tied separately in cloth. I had been avoiding taking it out. The wet bundle belonged to another village; opening our own family register would bring the

inquiry into the house. But without comparison it was impossible to date the abrasion.

I recognise my father's hand in our family register at once. My grandfather's too. The writing of my grandfather's father—who died long before I was born—I know only from the genealogical books and two old letters. His letters were small and leaned slightly to the right. The headline over "Shri" usually did not continue to the end of the word. When he wrote the conjunct "tra," the first upright stroke was short. The lower curve of his numeral 3 remained open. When making a correction he did not draw a straight line through the original text; his habit was to put two small diagonal marks at the left edge of the line. Their meaning: this reading has been reconsidered.

None of this had been written in the rules of Chapter 3. A panjika's general method does not describe the private habits of handwriting in every household.

I chose three pages from our family register on which the entries of my grandfather's father were certain. One contained a correction to a marriage relationship, another a correction of a village name, the third a later entry of a year of death. At the left edge of the line in all three were the same two diagonal marks. Very small. Like two thorns of ink.

I placed the wet sheet before me again. The left edge of Shridhar's line was dark with a water stain. At first sight there was nothing. I put two layers of cotton cloth beneath the sheet and turned the light obliquely. Within the dark stain appeared two tiny diagonal strokes. One complete, one half.

I did not immediately write a conclusion.

First I measured. In the family register the distance between the two marks was about two millimetres. On the wet sheet, approximately the same. The angle was similar. The colour of the ink looked different, but every ink on the wet sheet had altered. Colour was not evidence. Shape was useful. Position was useful.

Then I looked at the right edge of the abraded area. There survived half of a cut-off letter—only an upright stroke and a lower curve. Nothing after it. It would have been improper to guess the letter. I copied only the shape onto a working sheet and wrote beneath it: "Letter unreadable; form only."

8:05. The boy who brought milk called from outside. I covered the sheet and went to the door. I took the milk. Not in the large glass, in the small bowl. I did not ask his name; he came every day and I knew it. I came back in and bolted the door from within.

That action cannot be called concealment. Keeping the door shut while protecting wet papers was ordinary. Nevertheless I entered it in the diary: "08:07 door bolted from inside." During an examination, one's own actions too should be recorded.

Our family register and the wet sheet lay open together on the table. I assigned no meaning to the sight. Assigning meaning is not the work of examination.

I reread an old entry by my grandfather's father. The date was clear. At the right edge of the page there was no signature, only a small abbreviation of his

name. In the final letter of that abbreviation was a distinctive curve—the descending line suddenly bent left. Below the abraded portion of the wet sheet, outside the line itself and within a water stain, I noticed a small ink mark. At first I had taken it for a dot of mud. I used the magnifying glass. Not a dot. Two strokes. The first straight, the second curving left. Not the whole abbreviation, only its final part.

Whether I held my breath is not a fact fit for writing. My hand trembled slightly—that could be seen. When the pencil point touched the paper it struck the same point twice. A small dark dot appeared in the diary.

On the working sheet I drew the final portion of the abbreviation from the family register. Beside it, the one from the wet sheet. To call them the same would have been haste. To call them different would also have been difficult.

I sought a third piece of evidence. The style of the date at the top of the page. On the wet sheet the date of the original record was in an older hand; after it, in slightly smaller writing, a later year had been added. The numeral 3 in that year had an open lower curve. The 3 written by my grandfather's father in our family register was the same. A numeral alone cannot identify a writer. But the marks, the remnant of the abbreviation, and the shape of the numeral all pointed in one direction.

I wrote in the diary: "Later intervention on abraded line corresponds with handwriting of grandfather's father. Other original records required for decisive comparison."

I did not wish to write "my great-grandfather." Writing the relationship would not strengthen the evidence. So instead of the genealogical position, I wrote of the handwriting.

At 9:20 the telephone rang. Mohan. I did not answer. It rang four times and stopped. A minute later it rang again. This time I picked up.

"Babuji, have you eaten?"

"No."

"Why?"

"I am working."

"What work?"

I said, "Examining the pages."

He was silent for a few moments. "The three names?"

"Yes."

"Found anything?"

Before answering I looked at the table. The table could not be seen through a telephone. Even so, I did not answer at once. I said, "The water damage is not the same everywhere."

Mohan said, "What does that mean?"

"The meaning is not yet certain."

He said, "There you go again."

"Again what?"

"Every answer is 'not yet.'"

I said, "Where the answer is not yet known, it would be wrong to give it now."

He took a long breath; the sound was clear through the telephone. He said, "I'll come in the afternoon."

I considered saying no. Instead I said, "Come." The call ended. Time: 9:26.

I entered the call in the diary. "Did not tell Mohan about the abrasion." I paused over that sentence. Deliberately not telling a fact and telling an untruth are two different things. But both should be on record.

By ten I had searched the remaining sheets in the wet bundle for the same two diagonal marks. I found them in five places. In four, the earlier text had not been erased; a later note had simply been added. In one, a village name had been corrected. The letters of that correction corresponded with the hand in our family register. This strengthened the possibility concerning the writer of the marks.

In a fifth place one line had been lightly rubbed, but the text could still be read: the old village name had not been struck out; a new name was written above it in small letters. The scraping there was minimal. The reason was clear: the earlier reading had been preserved. After Shridhar, the earlier text had not been preserved. The surface had been worn so deeply that the original letters were almost gone.

The distinction mattered. Correction and erasure are not the same act.

In the diary I made two headings—"Correction" and "Removal." Under the first, four examples. Under the second, only Shridhar's line. After writing "Removal," I stopped the pencil. It was a severe word, but it described the condition of the paper, not a person's intention.

At 11:13 I compared, for the first time, my own family's line of descent with the page. Shridhar's name connected to an outer branch of our lineage. The relationship was distant; that much I had already known. But in the time of my grandfather's father, that branch and ours lay within the jurisdiction of the same panjkar. His hand appearing on that sheet was therefore not impossible.

Not impossible is not evidence. Yet the question had changed. Earlier the question had been: what did the water erase? Now it was: if someone erased it, why?

I did not write that second question in the diary. "Why" asks for intention, and there was as yet no evidence of intention. I wrote instead: "When was the abrasion made, and by whose hand?"

After "whose" I wrote in brackets: "Preliminary comparison: grandfather's father."

As I wrote those four words, the pressure of the pencil increased. The letters became dark. I did not erase them. Pressure too had become part of the written trace.

At 12:05 I ate. A little rice, dal. While washing the plate I noticed a faint stain of ink on my hand, perhaps from the old page. I washed with soap. Some stain

remained. That fact has no relation to the story, and I did not write it in the diary. Not every visible thing becomes a written record.

At 12:37 I sat at the table again. Now I read the line beneath the abraded one. It contained a marriage relationship, but its date was later than the abraded entry. The names were clear. If the erased line had originally been part of a genealogical sequence, removing it might alter the meaning of the later relationship. But this was only a structural possibility. I added no name.

At 1:10 Mohan came. He knocked. I did not cover the sheet. I merely moved our family register to the right because two pages had overlapped. He came in, looked at the table, removed his shoes at the door.

“Food?”

“Done.”

He sat in the chair. He did not reach toward the pages. “May I see?”

I said, “Dry your hands.” He had washed before coming, but wiped them again on the towel.

I showed him Shridhar’s line. At first he understood nothing. He said, “There is nothing here.”

I said, “That is what has to be looked at.”

“The blank?”

“How many kinds of blank can there be?”

He looked at me. “Don’t ask a question. Give me the answer.”

I cast the light obliquely and showed him the raised fibres. He bent closer. “Has it been scraped?”

“Strong possibility.”

“By whom?”

I opened the family register. I showed him three comparisons: the two diagonal marks, the numeral 3, the curve in the abbreviation. Mohan did not look for long. He was an engineer; handwriting examination was not his work. Even so, he could see the resemblance in the marks.

He asked, “Whose hand is this?”

I said, “My grandfather’s father’s.”

For the first time the word of relationship came out of my mouth. Until then it had not entered the diary.

Mohan leaned back against the chair. After a few moments he said, “Certain?”

“No. A very strong correspondence.”

“So he erased it?”

I said, “The intervention corresponds with his hand. To say ‘he erased it’ needs further examination.”

Mohan bent his head over the page. Then he asked the first question I myself had not had the courage to put into the diary: “Why?”

I answered, “Unknown.”

He did not immediately ask another question. A bicycle bell sounded on the road outside. From the back of the house came the sound of a vessel being set down. Two genealogical books lay open on the table.

Mohan said, "Is this about our family?"

I said, "It is about the genealogical register. The family connection extends only as far as the evidence establishes it."

A hardness entered his voice. "Can you separate everything like this?"

"During an examination, one has to."

"And after the examination?"

I did not answer.

Mohan got up and went to the window. He looked outside. Then asked, "Of the three names, only one line has been scraped?"

"So far."

"The other two?"

"One has water damage. One has a torn page."

He turned to look at me. "Then the three are not the same thing."

"No."

With that answer, the assumption of my first five days ended. I had been treating the three blanks as the result of the same event of water. There was no longer any basis for doing so.

Mohan said, "I'm going."

"Work?"

"Yes."

At the doorway he turned again. "Babuji, don't tell anyone this yet."

I asked, "Why?"

He said, "Until it is certain."

I said, "That is a proper reason."

He left. Time: 1:58.

After closing the door I opened the diary. I wrote Mohan's words exactly: "Until it is certain." Beneath them, my reply: "Proper reason." Here father and son had arrived at the same rule, though perhaps not for the same reason. I did not write that last part in the diary. It was a thought.

At 2:15 I made a separate copy of the abraded line: page number, line number, measurement of left and right boundaries, direction of the raised fibres, ink flecks, the two diagonal marks, the half-letter, the later year—everything. At the top of the copy, in red pencil, I wrote "NOT ORIGINAL." The original sheet was placed again between cotton cloth.

Then, as I was closing the family register, an entry by my grandfather's father caught my eye. An ordinary entry. Two brothers, one marriage, a village name. The same small, slanting, disciplined letters. A hand that measured years, names and relationships before writing them. On the wet sheet, traces of that same hand stood beside the act of removing a line.

I assigned no moral meaning to it. The beauty or ugliness of a hand is not evidence. Only the identification of the writer was relevant.

At 3:04 I wrote the day's conclusions in the diary:

- “1. The blank portion after Shridhar is not solely water damage. The paper surface appears to have been removed by human abrasion.
2. The paired diagonal marks at the left edge of that line, the nearby form of a later numeral, and the remnant of an abbreviation correspond strongly with verified entries in the hand of my grandfather's father.
3. Ratneshwar's blank is possibly water damage. Jayanarayan's blank is connected with a torn page.
4. The previous assumption that all three blanks have one cause is to be abandoned.
5. The original words of the erased text remain unreadable. Purpose unknown.”

After the fifth line I stopped the pen. For the first time the word “erased” had entered a conclusion. No question mark. The paper surface was sufficient.

I closed the diary, then opened it at once. Beneath the date I added one more line: “From this point the inquiry may be affected by family interest; therefore all further comparisons require double evidence.”

The line was necessary. The distance a panjekar keeps when examining another lineage does not create itself when his own lineage comes before him. It must be created in writing.

Near four o'clock I put the pages back in the chest. I did not wrap Shridhar's sheet separately; separation too would assign meaning. I kept the three sheets in the order in which they had been. The copies above them, but not the diary. The diary remained apart. The key on the cord at my waist.

As I locked the chest, I remembered the sentence from the first day: no new fact concerning the three names. Now there was a new fact. Before one of the three names, it was not water but a hand. And the hand was not unfamiliar.

I wrote no explanation. I only pulled the lock twice to test it. Time: 4:09.

Part II — The Genealogical Register (1901-1934)

The Earth Shook

15 January 1934

I was not there on the day the earth shook. I was born two years later. Even so, in my childhood 15 January 1934 was not a date that had passed into history. The elders of the village treated it not as a day but as a boundary: before the earth shook, and after the earth shook. Ask the age of a house and the answer would be, “Built two years before the earthquake.” Ask for an estimate of someone’s birth and they would say, “He was still in arms when the earth shook.” Ask when a marriage took place, and memory would carry that too to the same boundary. Written dates were few; the tremor of the earth had become a common date within everyone.

I first wrote about the event when I was twelve. I have no diary from that time, but five lines survive on the last page of an old school exercise book. “Grandmother says the bell rang first. Grandfather says the wall fell first. Whether the pond overflowed or not—they say different things.” It is a child’s handwriting. Two or three words are misspelled, but the disagreement has been preserved as it was. Perhaps that was my first exercise in becoming a *panjika*r: not destroying two accounts of the same event by merging them into one.

In my grandfather’s telling, the earthquake began with sound. He would say that the earth did not move first; first there rose from below a deep rumbling, as though many bullock carts were approaching at once along an unmetalled road. The people of the house looked outside, but the road was empty. Then the brass *lota* beside the *tulsi* altar slid of its own accord. The sound of that *lota* falling remained clearest in his memory. In his account, the first thing to collapse was the western wall of the house. When it fell, a cloud of dust rose, and he seized his younger brother by the arm and led him across the courtyard.

My grandmother did not accept this sequence. According to her, the temple bell rang first, of its own accord. No one had pulled the rope. At the second or third stroke she stopped the hand with which she was picking through the rice. Then the ground rose like a wave. “The *lota* fell later,” she would interrupt my grandfather. He would say, “Your eyes were on the bell; mine were on the *lota*.” Neither of them laughed. This was not the ordinary banter of married life; each was defending the authority of memory.

In my grandmother’s account, it was not the western wall but a corner of the cowshed that fell first. One bullock broke its rope and ran; the other remained tethered to its peg. She would say that for many days she remembered the eyes of that tethered animal—its body trembling, its gaze fixed. My grandfather was silent about this detail. Cattle did not appear in his account. He spoke only of people, walls, and measurements. My grandmother spoke of objects and bodies:

an overturned earthen jar, lime scattered into the grain, a red cloth caught in the thatch, and a little girl whose foot was pierced by a shard of kans metal.

The old village vaidya, Ramlochan Jha, had a third account. According to him, the first sign was neither sound nor movement but the colour of the water. He said that shortly before the earthquake the water in the well had turned cloudy. He repeated this until the final years of his life. If anyone asked whether the water had clouded before the tremor or after it, he would grow irritated: "I saw it with my own eyes." But his younger brother said that the well had shed earth only after the earthquake. The two brothers lived in the same house and drank from the same well, yet each possessed a different time for the well.

Ramlochan Jha's was a physician's account. Whose head was split, whose arm was dislocated, whose leg was trapped under a wall, who crawled out by his own strength, who had to be carried out by four men—he could recite the names in order. When, as an adult, I searched for that old list of his, no written list was found. I was told that the paper had rotted during a later monsoon. Then I understood how many lists live only in the mouth, and end when the mouth closes.

The fourth account belonged to Budhan Sada. When I was a boy he was the oldest man in the Musahar hamlet. No one knew his date of birth; he himself would say that when the earth shook he was "the father of two children." His account contained no temple bell, no lota of my grandfather's, no well of the vaidya's. His first words were: "The earth split open." With his hands he would indicate two directions and say that a long fissure opened in the field behind the hamlet, that water mixed with sand came out of it, and that after a while it filled in again.

Once I asked him, "How wide was it?" He spread his feet apart to show me. Another time I asked, and he pointed from one joint of a bamboo to the next. The third time he said, "Why do you need so much measuring? It had split. That is enough." To alter a witness's speech for one's own convenience is to alter the evidence.

There was one more thing in Budhan Sada's account: everyone from the village spent the night in the same open field. On the first night no one trusted a wall. Brahmin families, Kayastha families, people from the Dusadh hamlet, people from the Musahar hamlet—keeping their distances, yet in the same field. He would say, "The earth did not ask anyone's caste." Some villagers grew uncomfortable on hearing this. Another elder would immediately add, "Their eating and drinking vessels were separate." Budhan Sada did not laugh. He would merely say, "The earth was one."

Accounts of that night vary most of all. My grandmother said people stayed outdoors for two nights. My grandfather said five. Ramlochan Jha spoke of seven nights of treatment, but not that everyone remained in the field for all seven. Budhan Sada would say, "When the earth fell silent, people looked toward the mouths of their houses." When did the earth fall silent? For him, the answer was not a date but the fear held in the body.

On one point almost every account agrees: the spire of the old Shiva temple in the eastern part of the village was cracked. But disagreement over the bell remained. Some said it rang by itself; some said a roof beam fell across the rope and made it ring. One old priest even insisted that the bell had not rung at all, that the story had been added later. When I asked why so many people then told the story of the bell, he replied, "People remember a sound, not an event; if they cannot find a sound, they make one." That was his opinion, not evidence. I wrote down both.

There were three versions of what happened to the pond as well. In one, the water crossed the bank and came toward the courtyard. In another, only the surface shuddered and fish leapt upward. In the third, the pond remained still; a cloud of dust kept people from seeing clearly. Later, when I examined old land maps, I found that the pond had been measured differently before and after the earthquake, but that did not prove what the water had done at that instant. Paper does not answer every question either.

There is somewhat more written record of the damage to houses. Revenue papers mark one dwelling "wholly damaged," another "partially." But the house that occupies a single line in a government record may have been a five-generation thing in a family's memory. My grandmother spoke of a chest whose lid was smashed by bricks from the wall. Inside were wedding clothes, two silver coins, an oil portrait, and several letters. The chest does not appear in the revenue list. Without the chest, my grandmother's account is incomplete.

The village was rebuilt after the earth shook, but not as it had been before. Some doorways opened south instead of east. Two families did not rebuild over the foundations of their old walls. One lane widened because the walls on both sides had fallen and no one later rebuilt all the way to the former boundary. Some huts of the Musahar hamlet shifted to higher ground, but after the rains they moved back down again—the question of whose higher ground it was could not be separated from the earthquake.

Listening to stories of this rebuilding, one thing always struck me. People said, "The village survived," but the old village did not return in its entirety. The name remained the same, the shrine was called the same shrine, the pond the same pond; yet doorways, walls, lanes, the edges of hamlets, the depth of wells, the fissures in the fields—all had changed in some way. The village-name did not change in the records, so in the eyes of paper it was the same village. In the eyes of body and earth, it was new.

My grandfather spoke little of this new village. His story was sharp up to the moment of the tremor and brief about the rebuilding: "The walls rose again." That was all. My grandmother gave details—where the first hearth was lit, which family lived for two months on whose veranda, whose daughter's wedding had to be postponed, whose stored rice was mixed into the earth. Ramlochan Jha kept the order of illnesses and wounds. Budhan Sada kept the order of earth and labour. The same village was rebuilt four different ways.

In my youth I once tried to decide which of these accounts contained the “reality.” On a sheet of paper I made four columns: sound, first collapse, water, length of time spent outdoors. I wrote the witnesses’ names opposite them. Two hours later, looking at the page, I understood that I was not measuring the event but the disagreements. I added a fifth column: “What everyone agrees upon.” It was astonishingly short: the earth shook with extreme violence; many houses fell; people ran outside; there were injuries; the shape of the village changed.

The genealogical register says almost nothing about the earthquake. Here and there, a gap between dates suggests that a wedding was postponed. The ink changes on one page. On another, the word “house-collapse” is written in the margin. But there is nothing about the earth splitting, the tethered bullock, whether the bell rang, or the broken chest. The register was not meant to record such things. Yet if a later generation reads only the register, the village of 1934 will appear remarkably quiet.

Here record and memory are not enemies of one another. Both are incomplete, but their incompleteness is of different kinds. Memory preserves an event and, in preserving it, alters its sequence. Record preserves the sequence and, in preserving it, leaves the event out. The panjikaṛ’s difficulty is not deciding which one to choose; it is preventing the two, once combined, from becoming a third and more convenient falsehood.

In 1981, a few months before my grandmother died, I asked her once more, “Did the bell ring first?” She looked at me as though the question itself had grown ancient. “Does your grandfather still say it was the lota?”

“Yes,” I said.

She smiled. “Then write this: he heard the lota, I heard the bell.”

“Which came first?” I asked.

“The earth,” she said.

The answer fitted none of my tables. I wrote it down exactly as it was.

Long afterward, in 2008, while opening the water-soaked bundle, I remembered those accounts of 1934. Looking at the abrasion on the paper, I was beginning to understand that a blank too can be an event. But the understanding was not new. Since childhood I had heard how, within the same tremor, five people preserved five different things—one a lota, one a bell, one a well, one a fissure in the earth, one a wounded body. What survived was not only the event; the witness’s own place in it survived as well.

And of what did not survive, there was nothing yet to write. The story of the village in 1934 did not end with the earthquake. Something else happened within that same year, something the elders did not repeat as openly as the story of the earth. The memory of the earthquake contained disagreement; the memory of that other matter contained silence. Disagreement can be written down. Silence has to be measured by another method.

Witness One: The Priest

Event: Magh 1934 · Testimony: Harinarayan Jha

The old priest who, while recounting the earthquake, had denied the story of the bell was named Harinarayan Jha. I recorded his testimony concerning the marriage many years later. I was young then; he was old. The moment he heard my question, his first words were, “Do not write the word marriage first. Whether what happened was a marriage at all—that is the question.” I wrote the date, wrote his name, and told him I would write it exactly as he said it. He replied, “Then write the limits first.”

He had five limits. First: he had not gone there to conduct anyone’s marriage. Second: he had recited no mantra. Third: no sacred fire had been kindled by him. Fourth: there had been no kanyadan. Fifth: without consulting the genealogical register, he never pronounced any relationship valid. After stating these five things, he looked at me and asked, “Have you written that?” I said, “Yes.” Only then did he begin his account.

“After the earthquake, the order of the village had already broken down,” he said. “Walls had fallen, the shrine was cracked, people were living outdoors. At such a time the rules of dharma do not change. In a crisis, the need for rules does not diminish; it increases. When the walls of a house are gone, people must carry the boundaries in their minds.” This was his first act of self-defence. I did not call it that at the time; I simply wrote the sentence down as he gave it.

He did not speak Phuljhari’s name at first. He called her “that woman of the household.” I asked, “Which woman?”

“You know,” he said.

“Records do not proceed by inference,” I said.

Only after a long pause did he say, “Phuljhari.” Having pronounced the name, he began to drink water. His teeth made a small sound against the rim of the brass lota. I wrote that down because the silence at that moment was long.

According to him, Phuljhari had not left the house alone that evening. A young man was with her. When I asked the young man’s name, Harinarayan Jha said, “What will writing the name accomplish?”

“A person is not separate from his name,” I said.

“I do not remember the name,” he replied.

Later, within the same testimony, he mentioned the young man’s father’s occupation, the direction of his hamlet, and the peepal tree near his house. Only the name had escaped him.

“Did the two of them come to the temple?” I asked.

“Not inside the temple,” the priest said at once.

A little later he said, “They may have come as far as the threshold.”

Then he said, "I was not there at the time."

Three answers to one question. I wrote all three.

In the first version of his account, Harinarayan Jha was performing his evening prayers at home when a boy came and told him that two people were sitting near the shrine. The priest sent the boy away. He said that after the earthquake such reports were ordinary: houses had collapsed; people sat wherever they found a place—at shrines, in orchards, on raised platforms, in empty courtyards. Hearing that "two people are sitting there," he did not go.

A few sentences later he supplied a second version himself. "When I saw a woman in a yellow sari standing outside the threshold, I understood that this was not merely a question of shelter."

I stopped him. "You saw her?"

"People told me."

"The yellow sari?"

He became a little displeased. "Yellow or faded yellow—do not start a dispute over colour after so many years."

I did not dispute the colour. I merely wrote that he remembered the colour of the sari.

He said there was a red thread around Phuljhari's right wrist. Without my asking, he added that the thread was not a sign of marriage. "Women in the village tie thread around their wrists—for vows, for worship, during illness. Do not write it as a marriage-thread."

"I am writing only 'red thread,'" I said.

"Then let it remain."

He had fewer words for the young man. "He stood outside." "He spoke with his head lowered." "He was not a Brahmin."

At that I asked, "Caste?"

The priest looked at me for some time. "What use is it to ask the caste of one who has no standing in the genealogical register?"

"To understand the event."

"The event is simply that no valid relationship was possible."

The talk of scripture began there. Harinarayan Jha repeated five words: gotra, lineage, conduct, standing, sacrament. He quoted no verse from any text. I asked, "Which rule?"

"The one everyone accepts."

"Written?"

"Not everything has to be written in a book."

At the time, the answer seemed ordinary to me. After I became a panjikar, it came to mean something else: when a rule is unwritten, in whose hands do its boundaries lie?

On the question of what Phuljhari wanted from the priest, his testimony was most evasive. First he said, "A blessing." Then, "A witness." Then, "Only that I should not tell anyone."

"Which of the three?" I asked.

“A woman’s speech follows emotion, not ritual.”

I had put a question mark beside that sentence. I understand now that the question was not about Phuljhari’s speech. It was about the priest’s memory.

One thing he stated clearly: Phuljhari had expressed her own wish herself. No man spoke in her place. “She said, ‘I will live with this man.’” Harinarayan Jha spoke the sentence more softly than the rest.

“Those exact words?” I asked.

“That was the meaning.”

I asked for the original words. He did not give them.

The young man too had said something. The priest claimed not to remember what. He did, however, remember that the young man’s hands were joined in supplication. “Joining one’s hands does not make a marriage,” he added immediately. I had not asked. Throughout his account, the things he added of his own accord were generally the things that defended him.

“Was there a fire?” I asked.

“No.”

A little later he mentioned an earthen lamp kept near the temple threshold. “There is always a lamp there at evening.”

“So there was no ritual fire, but there was a lamp?”

“It would not be right to call a lamp ‘the fire’ and turn it into a marriage.”

I recorded the two words separately.

Then he said that Phuljhari sat down on the ground near the threshold. The hem of her sari was wet. There was mud on her feet. A small cut marked the heel of her left foot.

“If you saw so much,” I asked, “how can you say you were not there?”

He fell silent. After a long while he said, “I did go there, but not to perform a rite.”

The first limit had shifted. He had now been present at the place of the event; he had merely not acted there as priest.

He said he advised Phuljhari to return home. “Your people will be spoken to. The register will be consulted. Then whatever the proper rite requires.”

Phuljhari, according to him, neither laughed nor wept. She merely asked, “Where in the genealogical register is my wish written?”

Harinarayan Jha himself gave me that sentence. If it is accurate, it is the clearest sentence of that night. If later memory fashioned it, it is still significant, because in the priest’s memory Phuljhari’s question was addressed to the register.

What did he answer her? At first he said, “I explained the bounds of scripture.” When I asked for the words, he said, “A woman’s wish alone is not proof.” Then came gotra and lineage. Then standing. Then ancestors. But nowhere could he say by which line Phuljhari’s wish was annulled. His argument moved in a circle: the relationship was invalid because the register conferred no standing; there was no standing because such a relationship was invalid.

“What was the young man doing meanwhile?”

“Silent.”

“Where was he standing?”
“Two arm-lengths from the lamp.”
“Near Phuljhari?”
“A little behind.”
“What was he wearing?”
“A dhoti.”
“What colour?”
“You could not tell for the mud.”

No name for the young man, but distance, clothing, mud—all remembered.

Harinarayan Jha again made it clear that he had recited no mantra. When I asked whether Phuljhari and the young man had held hands, he first said, “No.” Then, “I did not pay attention.” Then, “I saw the red thread on the woman’s wrist.” The three statements did not fully agree.

One object from that evening remained especially vivid to him: a small brass plate containing rice, two betel nuts, a box of sindoor, and a dried flower. The priest insisted these were not wedding articles but ordinary articles of worship.

“Who brought them?” I asked.
“I do not know.”
“Whose hand held the plate?”
“It was lying there.”
“From before?”
“Possibly.”

He remembered every object on the plate, but not the person who had brought it.

At this point in his testimony Harinarayan Jha narrowed his role once more. “I only stated the boundary of dharma. That is all. I gave no order to seize anyone, stop anyone, beat anyone, or tie anyone up.”

Until then I had asked him about none of those four acts. He named them himself. I wrote all four.

“Then whom did you inform?” I asked.

“How could it be wrong to inform the eldest man of the household?” The answer came as a question.

When I asked for a name, at first he would not give one. Later he supplied two, but added, “They came only to reason with them.”

“To reason with whom?”
“The woman of the house.”
“And the young man?”
“That is not my concern.”

His tone changed there. Scriptural words diminished; household words increased. “The night was advancing. After the earthquake it was not safe to remain outside. The woman should return home. That was in everyone’s interest.”

“Did she return?”

The priest did not answer. He drank from the lota and said, "Someone else will answer that question."

"When did you return home?"

"In the evening itself."

"When did the elders of the household arrive?"

"Later."

"Did you see them?"

"People told me."

A little later he said, "By the time they arrived, the lamp had burned halfway down."

"But you said you had returned home in the evening."

"I was told later how much of the lamp had burned."

Yet the first time he had spoken as though he had seen it with his own eyes.

Phuljhari's final position in his account was not fixed. In one place she was seated by the threshold. In another she stood at the edge of the courtyard. In a third she moved toward the young man as soon as the elders of the house arrived.

"What does 'moved toward him' mean?" I asked.

The priest was displeased. "She took two steps. Why must two steps be made to mean something?"

Movement in a record also requires direction. He did not give one.

According to him, no marriage took place that night. He repeated his reasons: no mantra, no ritual fire, no kanyadan, no sacrament performed by an authorized priest, no standing in the genealogical register.

"Two adults stated their wishes," I said. "They declared a decision to live together. There was a plate with articles of worship, there was a lamp, there were witnesses. What would you call all that?"

"Avidhi," he said—outside the prescribed rite.

"An avidhi marriage?" I asked.

"Only avidhi."

Between those two words he was constructing the safety of an entire life. Call it a marriage and the register, lineage, descendants, and standing all became questions. Call it merely avidhi and the event became an improper act by individuals. Here the choice of word was not description. It was judgment.

"Where did Phuljhari go afterward?" I asked.

"I did not see."

"The young man?"

"I did not see."

"The elders of the household?"

"I had gone home."

"Then what happened afterward is not part of your testimony?"

"No."

A few moments later he added of his own accord, "I heard something the next day, but hearsay is not evidence."

"What did you hear?"

He would not say. "What is the use of writing hearsay?"

"I will write it as hearsay."

"No."

At that one point he chose the boundary of the record himself.

I changed the question. "Was Phuljhari's name in the genealogical register?"

"Women's names are not written everywhere."

"The line recording her marriage?"

"If there was no valid marriage, what line could there be?"

"Her relationship with the young man?"

"No standing."

"Then how would the event enter the register?"

"It would not."

As I wrote that answer, I understood for the first time that an absence in a record is not always proof that an event did not occur. Sometimes an event occurs for which no box has ever been made in which to write it. I did not give the priest this conclusion then. I merely asked the next question: "If there is no place for it in the register, what about in people's memory?"

"Memory is not scripture," Harinarayan Jha said.

When the testimony was over, he asked to see my pages. I read them aloud. He stopped me in three places. First: add "possibly" before "yellow sari." Second: add "for worship" before "red thread." Third: add "in fulfilment of duty" before "informed the eldest man of the household." In the first two places I recorded his corrections separately; I did not erase the original words. At the third too I wrote, "His statement: in fulfilment of duty."

"Are you making me guilty?" he asked.

"I am not keeping an account of guilt."

"Then why so much detail?"

"Because everyone tells the broad story. The differences live in the small things."

As Harinarayan Jha rose to leave, he searched for his walking stick. It was leaning against the wall on his right. Without looking, he reached out and found it at once. At the doorway he turned back.

"Write one thing," he said. "I had told her to go home."

"That is already written."

"And write that I wished no harm to anyone."

I wrote that sentence too. Intention is not an event, but it forms part of a witness's self-defence.

Long afterward, when I read the testimony again, I marked five contradictions separately. One: at first he says he was not present at the place of the event; later he sees the threshold, sari, wrist, foot, plate, and lamp. Two: he does not remember the young man's name, but remembers his hamlet, the direction of his house, and his father's occupation. Three: he says he returned home in the evening, yet describes later arrivals. Four: he rejects the word marriage, but accepts that two people clearly expressed a wish to live together.

Five: he accepts that he informed the elders of the household, but severs himself entirely from whatever happened afterward.

None of these contradictions by itself proves the truth. Old memory may change. Self-protection may change memory. My questions too may change the shape of testimony. I therefore recorded no verdict. I wrote only: "Witness rejects the performance of a marriage rite; limits of presence unclear; acknowledges the woman's self-expressed wish; silent concerning subsequent events."

From this witness I did not recover Phuljhari's own original words. One sentence of hers survived in the priest's memory: "Where in the genealogical register is my wish written?" The sentence may itself have been made by him. But if it was made, the question remains: while fashioning a story in his own defence, why did the old priest put precisely that question into Phuljhari's mouth?

I did not answer the question then. I do not answer it now. The work of evidence is not to manufacture answers, but to show their limits.

Witness Two: Sister-in-Law

Event: Magh 1934 · Testimony: Kamala Devi

The second witness was Kamala Devi, Phuljhari's elder sister-in-law. Harinarayan Jha had begun his testimony by enumerating the boundaries of dharma; Kamala Devi began hers with three things from the kitchen: a large earthen pot, a small brass plate, and a half-full bottle of mustard oil. "Write these three things," she said. "The rest afterward." I wrote them down. Then she asked, "Did the priest tell you about the plate?"

"He did."

She did not laugh. "It was not his plate. It came from my kitchen."

Kamala Devi's memory moved according to the order of household work. Time was fixed not by a clock but by the hearth. She said that before evening that day, rice had been put on to cook for the second time. After the earthquake, many members of the household were living under a temporary shelter built outside the courtyard, and meals had to be cooked in two batches: the first for the old people and children, the second for everyone else. Phuljhari had not eaten with the first batch. Saying, "My stomach will not take it," she had pushed her plate away. Kamala Devi did not regard this as illness. In her account it was "stubbornness of the mind."

"Did she work through the day?" I asked.

"She did not leave her work," Kamala Devi said. "At dawn she fetched water, twice she wrung out washed clothes, she oiled the little one's hair, but she did not eat herself. If you write, write everything. Do not write as though the thought of leaving the house came to her and she sat in a room all day. She worked too. She hid the matter too."

This sentence was the first clear expression of her bitterness. Her chief accusation against Phuljhari was: "She hid the matter." Before I could ask what matter, Kamala Devi corrected the detail of the sari. She rejected the priest's "yellow sari."

"Not yellow," she said. "It was a white sari. An old turmeric stain may have made it look yellow. The border was ochre. I had washed it myself."

"Was she wearing that sari that day?"

"Yes. Her other sari was wet on the line."

Her account of the red thread was different too. There had been a red thread around Phuljhari's right wrist, but not for worship. Three days earlier, while lifting an earthen water jar beside the hearth, she had scraped her wrist. Kamala Devi had tied a small pad of cotton there with red thread. By that day the cotton had fallen away; the thread remained.

"The priest turned it into the thread of a vow?" she asked.

I did not answer.

“One who knows nothing of the inside of a house thinks every thread is for worship.”

When she heard about the cut on the heel of Phuljhari’s left foot, she corrected that too. “Not the heel. The skin was split beside the big toe. Salt water made it burn, so she could not put her full weight on that foot.”

“Why do you remember?”

“For two days I had been applying mustard oil and turmeric to it. The one who tends a wound remembers where it is.”

Whether Kamala Devi loved Phuljhari seemed an unnecessary question. In her testimony there were fewer words of affection than acts of care. She had washed Phuljhari’s sari, bound her wrist, rubbed oil into her foot, and at the same time she said, “She did not preserve the honour of the house.” Both things existed together.

According to Kamala Devi, Phuljhari herself had taken the small brass plate from the kitchen. Rice, two betel nuts, a box of sindoor, and one dried flower: on these four objects her account agreed with the priest’s. But she added a fifth—a piece of jaggery.

“Is the jaggery written?” she asked.

“The priest did not mention it.”

Kamala Devi then described the lid of the kitchen chest, the knife used to cut the jaggery loaf, even the shape of the small square piece cut that evening. “I asked her, ‘Where are you taking it?’ She said, ‘It is to be offered at the shrine.’”

“The sindoor?” I asked.

Kamala Devi was silent for a moment. Then she said, “She took it herself. She did not ask me.”

“Did you stop her?”

“No. The sindoor box stayed beside the household shrine. She was a woman of the house. Why would she need permission to touch the box?”

This was a different kind of answer from the priest’s language of standing and authorization. Inside a household, the right to use objects was governed less by formal rule than by practice. Kamala Devi disagreed with Phuljhari’s decision, but she did not say that Phuljhari lacked the right to touch the plate or the sindoor.

When did Phuljhari leave the house? Kamala Devi answered by the sequence of domestic things. “The milk had already been taken off the fire. The small children were being fed rice. There was still light in the west. The cattle had been tied, but the lamp by the tulsi had not yet been lit.”

After I had written down these four markers, I asked, “So before evening?”

“Yes, but not long before.”

She did not invent a clock-time.

She said Phuljhari went out through the doorway alone. The young man was neither inside the house nor at the entrance. Kamala Devi explicitly disagreed with the priest’s claim that Phuljhari “went out with him.”

"I was at the doorway. She left alone."

She did not see where the young man was. "That he was seen near the shrine later is another matter."

"Did Phuljhari say anything?"

"She said, 'I am going to leave the plate there and come back.'"

"Only that?"

"That is all she said to me."

Kamala Devi often stopped herself precisely where inference would have begun. When I asked whether Phuljhari had planned beforehand to meet the young man, she said, "I do not know. I can tell you that she took the plate, went out alone, and did not eat. The plan was in her head, not in my eyes." That single sentence made her testimony useful in many places.

Her information about the young man was limited, but more concrete than the priest's. She would not pronounce his name. "Writing his name will bring people around his family again."

I told her the event was very old.

"Old humiliation has no age," she replied.

Then she described the direction of his hamlet: southeast of the village's main settlement, toward the low ground where rainwater collected first. The young man's father worked as an agricultural labourer; the young man himself ploughed fields, cut earth, and sometimes ferried people across by boat. Kamala Devi did not name his caste.

"You have understood," she said.

"Understanding is not written evidence."

"Then do not write it. Write what I said."

Kamala Devi had not directly witnessed what happened at the shrine. Even where she might have been tempted to contradict Harinarayan Jha, she did not cross that boundary. "I was not there," she said. "Do not write from my mouth what mantra was or was not recited there, whether they held hands or not." But what happened in the house she described in detail.

Phuljhari returned. This was the first fact in Kamala Devi's testimony that the priest had evaded. She said that by then the lamp beside the tulsi had been lit, the second batch of rice had been taken off the fire, and the children were being prepared for sleep. Phuljhari came to the doorway. There was mud along the edge of her sari, dust and earth clung to her left foot, and the plate was no longer in her hand. The red thread remained on her wrist. Her hair was not undone; she returned as she had gone. There was no dramatic transformation in Kamala Devi's description.

"Alone?" I asked.

"As far as the doorway, alone."

"The young man?"

"I saw a shadow behind the bamboo fence. It was a person. Whether it was he or someone else, I will not say."

On whether Phuljhari entered the house, Kamala Devi made a very fine distinction. "She crossed the doorway, but she did not go into the inner room. She stood on the veranda." According to her, two elderly men of the household were already sitting there. Of the priest's statement, "I informed the family," Kamala Devi said, "The news reached the house before the priest did."

Who brought it? "The little plough-boy."

His name? She gave it; I wrote it down. The boy's testimony is not useful in this chapter because I was never able to question him myself.

According to Kamala Devi, Harinarayan Jha also came later, as far as the entrance of the house. "Not inside—only to the doorway." This partly agreed with the priest's own account and partly collided with it. He had said that he informed the eldest man of the household; in Kamala Devi's version the elders already knew, and the priest himself arrived at the doorway afterward.

Kamala Devi remembered three sentences that Phuljhari spoke on the veranda. First: "I will live with him." Second: "What will you do by stopping me?" Third: "What is not written is not therefore false."

At the third sentence I stopped her. "Were those the exact words?"

"I am completely certain of the first two," Kamala Devi said. "The meaning of the third was this; the words may have changed."

Beside the third sentence I wrote: "Memory of meaning; original words uncertain."

I would have made the distinction even if she had not, but she made it herself.

She was less clear about what the men of the household said. She remembered one sentence: "First the genealogical register will be consulted." Another: "She will not go out at night." Who said which, she could not say. One old man held a bamboo walking stick. It was his ordinary stick; Kamala Devi attached no special meaning to it.

"Do not make a story out of the stick," she told me. "The old man could not walk without it."

I asked whether anyone raised a hand against Phuljhari. Kamala Devi looked at me for a long time before answering. "I remained on the veranda until the voices grew loud. After that I took the children into the back room. I will not say what I did not see."

"Sounds?"

"Voices. Once, something made of brass fell. I do not remember the sound of weeping."

"A man's voice?"

"There were many raised voices. To attach words to particular mouths now would be false."

After this answer she began listing things from inside the house. A little girl had asked for water. The ash in the hearth was doused. Half of the second batch of rice remained uneaten. No separate plate was served for Phuljhari because she never sat down to eat. Her bedding was not opened that night. The pillow

remained as it had been placed. A wooden comb, two saris, a small iron trunk, a pair of kans bangles, a spindle for spinning thread—all remained in the room.

“If she had meant to leave home for some far place, she would have taken something,” Kamala Devi said. “But that is my inference. The objects remained—that is the fact.”

I recorded inference and fact separately.

Kamala Devi’s account of the later part of the night was brief. “I stayed inside with the children. I did not see each time the door opened or closed. Once when I went out, the veranda was empty. No old men. No Phuljhari. No priest. The lamp had gone out.”

“The young man?”

“I did not see him.”

“Where did Phuljhari go?”

“I did not see.”

“With whom?”

“I did not see.”

Three answers in exactly the same form. Here too she added no inference.

At dawn, Kamala Devi said, her first task was to sweep the courtyard. After the earthquake the ground was uneven—cracked earth, fragments of brick, dust. She said she saw two kinds of footprints outside the doorway, but many people had come and gone through the night, so no meaning could be drawn from them. “If you write ‘footprints,’ write beside it: whose, unknown.” I did exactly that.

By dawn the small brass plate had not returned to the house. Nor had the sindoor box. Naturally the piece of jaggery had not. But there was another sindoor box in the household shrine; ordinary life in the house did not stop. Kamala Devi herself listed these absent objects.

“Was the plate found later?” I asked.

“A few days later, behind the shrine. Filled with mud. I washed it and used it again.”

There was no sacred dread in her answer. The object belonged to the house; it was washed and put back to work.

When I asked whether Phuljhari was ever seen in the house again, Kamala Devi answered, “I did not see her.”

“Did anyone say they had?”

“Many things were said. If you write down every piece of hearsay, the paper will fill up, not the truth.”

The sentence sounded like Harinarayan Jha’s rejection of hearsay, but there was a difference. The priest would not even say what he had heard. Kamala Devi enumerated the kinds of reports: some said Phuljhari had run away with the young man; some that she had gone toward her natal home; some that she had crossed the river; some that the family had sent her elsewhere.

“I saw none of it,” she said. “So I accept none of them as mine.”

Her bitterness toward Phuljhari had not lessened. "A woman can speak her own mind. But everyone has a life within a household. What she did brought shame upon all of us."

"What was shameful?" I asked. "That she spoke her own wish, or that she wished to live with a man across caste?"

"How are those two things separate?" Kamala Devi replied.

Her answer made the boundaries of her social world plain. Reliability about facts and narrowness of moral vision do not cancel each other out. A witness may accurately report the smallest sequence of an event and still be prejudiced about its meaning.

I read the priest's five limits back to her: no mantra, no ritual fire, no kanyadan, no register, no rite. Kamala Devi listened and said, "There was a lamp. There was the plate. She took the sindoor herself. She herself said she would live with him. Whether you call it a marriage or not, that is for you people of the books to decide. What matters to me is that she spoke what was in her own mind before the household."

"Did you try to stop her?"

Kamala Devi was silent for a long time. Then she said, "I told her, 'Do not go now. Wait until dawn.' She said, 'If I wait until dawn, I will never be able to go.'"

This was the only place in her entire testimony where her voice softened.

"Those exact words?" I asked.

"I remember those words."

"Why did you want her to wait until dawn?"

"It was night. The men of the house were angry. After the earthquake everyone's mind was overheated. I wanted the night to pass."

"Did you fear that something harmful might happen?"

Kamala Devi did not answer at once. Then she said, "I need no scripture to write whether anger can lead to harm."

I wrote the sentence exactly as she said it.

Then I asked, "Did you tell anyone not to leave her alone?"

"I told my younger sister-in-law. But her child had a fever. How much could she watch?"

"The men?"

"Does telling an angry man not to be angry stop his anger?"

I gave no answer.

As her testimony came to its end, Kamala Devi enumerated the three objects once more: the earthen pot, the brass plate, the bottle of oil.

"Why the pot?" I asked.

"Half the rice remained. If that night had been ordinary in the house, that much rice would not have been left. Everyone's stomach had closed."

"The oil bottle?"

"I had been putting it on Phuljhari's foot. That night it was not applied. In the morning the bottle stood exactly where it had been."

"The plate?"

“She took it with her. Later it was found behind the shrine.”

Then I understood that Kamala Devi remembered the event not through words of feeling but through unfinished tasks—the uneaten rice, the unapplied oil, the unopened bedding, the plate that did not return home. Her bitterness had not destroyed those minute details. Perhaps it was because of that bitterness that she remembered things others forgot.

At the end I asked, “If you disagreed with Phuljhari so deeply, why do you tell her part so carefully?”

Kamala Devi replied, “Does disagreement change what one saw?”

“People change it,” I said.

“Then you must not.”

At the end of my written account that day, I wrote four lines: “Witness was present inside the household. Extremely precise regarding domestic sequence and objects. Explicitly opposed to Phuljhari’s decision. Usually distinguishes among what she saw, what she heard, and what she infers. Phuljhari returned home after evening; on the veranda she again expressed her wish; in the later part of the night the witness did not see her again.”

Outside those four lines I wrote one thing separately: “Wait until dawn.” The event itself does not answer why one woman gave that advice to another. But the advice makes one thing clear: Kamala Devi did not regard the anger of the men in the house that night as ordinary. I had no separate written evidence for that condition. The sentence was direct memory. So I preserved it.

CHAPTER 12
Kosi — 2

I am flowing now and the earth beneath me is still not still people see a wall standing and call it stable and see the water of a pond silent and call it motionless but fine lines keep moving within the soil layers of sand slip upon one another damp earth breathes in the belly of an old channel and when the earth shakes whatever stands above it sheds its name and becomes the weight of a body a wall is no longer a wall it becomes a heap of earth and tiles the ring of a well is no longer round it leans to one side the tulsi altar cracks the bamboo of the cowshed falls the stakes set for threshing rice tremble water crosses the boundary of its vessel and people run outside then in one person's memory the bell rings first in another's the wall falls first in another's the pond overflows in another's the sound of the earth comes first and in another's memory there is no sound at all only the ground moving beneath the feet I flow among these testimonies and for me before and after are not so cleanly divided as people wish because the same tremor that brings a tiled roof down in one house clouds the water of a well elsewhere and in a third place opens such a fissure underground that rain enters it and the water of that rain later alters the slope beside me when old people tell one event again and again their words change but the movement of their hands often returns to the direction where in memory a wall fell or a body was trapped or a path was closed words alter their order the body's memory does not forget its direction I cannot read the memory of the human body but I read the direction of earth I read the cutting of banks I read the colour of sand I read roots laid bare I read water filling newly split ground and where people call the earth dry I see inner dampness still rising and know that some old water continues moving below people tell me an earthquake changes the course of a river and that statement is half true because a course does not change in one day alone the slope of the land shifts a little somewhere sand subsides somewhere an old drain opens somewhere a pond breaks into a field somewhere a field-ridge becomes a path for new water then the next rain enlarges that weak line and I reach the place where before there had been only a fine wet mark the village gives this change a single date but the earth keeps many dates the village says on that day the earth shook the earth says on that day one line opened on another day water filled it on a third day its edges softened in the month of rain the seed of a new channel fell there and after several years people understood that the old map no longer matched the village ground the map still kept its straight lines the names still remained inside their boxes the genealogical register still kept the succession of lineages but the earth apart from all of them was making its own record I flow over that record and sometimes erase part of it sometimes cover it with sand sometimes open an old layer by cutting the bank and then objects come into human hands about which no living person is certain whose courtyard did this

brick belong to whose plate was this fragment of kans is this bone animal or human was this red thread for marriage or worship such questions do not remain with me but they remain among people and the older a question grows the more stories gather around it one person protects the lineage another protects the honour of the house another conceals the fear of the body another stops the matter by naming someone else's caste another denies having been present another says everything happened before his eyes and another does not even name an act whose mark survives as a blank within his account I understand blanks because a current too has blanks where the water appears quiet from above while a turning eddy underneath cuts the soil there the silence of the surface does not erase the work below and so in human testimony silence is sometimes not an empty place around it the order of time changes the order of objects changes who arrives first who leaves later who calls whom who goes out through which doorway in all these things small differences accumulate and when after many years someone sets every account beside the others the unlike things speak more loudly than the things that match when two currents meet in my water the mingled water cannot afterward be separated but when testimonies meet their separate colours remain the priest keeps the language of scripture the sister-in-law keeps the order of hearth and plate the village elders keep the sounds of their fear and the one who tills the soil keeps in memory the hardness and softness beneath his feet I flow beside that field where the point of the plough cuts an old layer of earth I keep damp sand under the mound whose name is small upon a map but which is high ground beneath human feet I do not see as people see yet whatever touches me alters my movement and whatever touches the earth alters the earth's shape and therefore beside both what someone says and what someone does not say the soil leaves its mark I do not choose names I do not apportion blame I do not judge I only flow and as I flow I cut away a piece of an old bank and lay it upon new sand where tomorrow someone will drive a plough and before its blade there may appear an object that makes people open their old stories again and among those stories there will be one voice that belongs neither to scripture nor household nor office but to the hand that tills a field and that hand before saying what it saw will brush the earth from its palm many times

Witness Three: The Ploughman

I recorded this testimony from Budhan Sada in Jeth of 1961. I was twenty-five then and travelled from village to village with my father on the work of the genealogical register. Budhan Sada gave no exact count of his age. "Write that I was a young man when the earthquake came. That is enough." An old callus lay in the middle of his right palm; the index finger of his left hand remained half-bent. The shape a body acquires from holding a plough-handle is clearer than papers that count its years.

Instead of sitting on the veranda of my house, he asked me to sit beside the bamboo grove to the south. When I asked why, he said, "The walls of a house have ears." I did not write it down. He himself said, "Do not write that sentence. Understand it." It was the first time I understood that some witnesses choose a place before they choose their words.

Budhan Sada looked at my paper. "Will you write names?"

"Yours?" I asked.

"Mine you may write. Will you write the name of the one this is about?"

"If you tell me."

For a while he scratched at the earth. Then he said, "First write what my work was. I drove the plough. The field belonged to the landlord, the bullocks belonged to the landlord, the sun belonged to me."

The language of his testimony was unlike that of Harinarayan Jha or Kamala Devi. Instead of lineage, standing, rite, clan, honour, he spoke of paths, fields, bullocks, earth, feet, and night. I asked questions in the manner of the register; he answered in the manner of the field.

The first thing he remembered about those three weeks was the fissure in the earth. After the earthquake, a long crack had opened in a field to the southeast. On the first day dry dust could be seen in it, on the second dampness shone from within, and on the third water had gathered in two places. "We thought the belly of the earth had split," Budhan Sada said.

"How long was it?"

He indicated the distance across two lengths of bamboo. It was not a measurement. The direction was clear.

Beyond that fissure lay the Musahar hamlet. The priest had not named the hamlet. Kamala Devi had given a direction. Budhan Sada gave its name.

"Our hamlet. I did not know what name it had on paper. People called it the Musahar hamlet."

He spoke the words without shame and without irony. It was simply the name of a place, like the northern pond or the western fields.

"Was the young man from that hamlet?" I asked.

Budhan Sada looked at me. "Why will you write 'the young man'? He had a name."

After a long while he said, "Jagesar Sada."

I asked again.

"Jagesar. His father was Dalit Sada. Their house was near my uncle's. Seven or eight years younger than me."

For the first time, the name the priest had forgotten and Kamala Devi had knowingly withheld appeared on my paper.

What did Jagesar do? "Ploughing, earthwork, boats—whatever work came. More boat-work in the rains, more ploughing in winter." This matched Kamala Devi's testimony. Budhan Sada added, "He could read a little. At fairs he would stand behind men who read papers. He could write his own name."

No other witness had said this. I asked for his basis.

"I saw him. He would write it in the earth with a stick."

At Phuljhari's name he fell silent. I did not repeat the question. After a long time he said, "In your houses her name was spoken softly. In our hamlet, openly."

"Why?"

"She spoke to us as though we were human beings."

I wrote the sentence exactly as it was. Budhan Sada looked at the paper but did not read the letters.

He was not certain how long Phuljhari and Jagesar had been meeting. "I saw them in the fields. Three times, four times—I did not count. Sometimes she gave him water, sometimes they spoke."

"Alone?"

"How can a field be alone? There is the sky, there are bullocks, there are people on the path."

There was neither mockery nor defence in his answer.

He said that after the earthquake many households had built shelters outside. The old boundaries of the village loosened. People moved more often through one another's courtyards, fields, ponds, and shelters.

"The earth knocked down everyone's walls," he said, "but people soon began raising the walls in their minds again."

"Which walls?"

"Caste."

On the evening described by the priest and Kamala Devi, Budhan Sada was not in the Musahar hamlet. He had gone into the outer fields to bring back his landlord's bullocks. The sun was sinking. On his way back he encountered Jagesar behind the shrine.

"Was he alone?"

"At first. Then Phuljhari came."

"The plate?"

"In her hand."

"The sari?"

"White, with a coloured border. I will not name the colour."

His description stood closer to Kamala Devi's.

Had Budhan Sada stopped there, or kept walking? "I was taking the bullocks home. Why would I stand there? The two of them fell silent when they saw me. Jagesar said, 'Uncle, do not tell anyone.' I said, 'What is your business to me?' But the mouth said one thing and the mind understood another."

"What did the mind understand?"

"This was not a game."

I wrote the words down. Then he said again, "The two of them were not playing. They had decided to live together."

"Marriage?"

Budhan Sada looked directly at me. "You people of the books may give marriage whatever name you like. In our hamlet, if two people say before everyone that they will live together and take responsibility for one another, people call it setting up a household. Whether a priest comes or does not come is another matter."

"Did you see any rite that evening?"

"No. I did not stand behind the shrine. I took the bullocks and went."

"The lamp?"

"There was light from a distance."

"Sindoor?"

"I did not see it."

"Holding hands?"

"I did not see it."

What he had not seen, he did not add.

After darkness fell, a boy came to call Budhan Sada. He gave the boy's name. It was the same name that appeared in Kamala Devi's account as "the little plough-boy." The boy said that a quarrel was growing in the main settlement and Jagesar's family needed to be informed.

"Where is Jagesar?" Budhan Sada asked.

"There."

"Phuljhari?"

The boy gave no answer.

Budhan Sada went with two men from the Musahar hamlet. When I asked where, he first said, "Near the shrine." Then he corrected himself. "Not the shrine. By the old mango tree to its north." I wrote the direction. At the question of what he saw there, his testimony broke for the first time. He drank water twice. Then he said, "I will not tell everything I saw."

"What you will not tell, I will not write."

"But what everyone tells backwards, write it straight."

"What is that?"

"They did not run away."

"Who?"

"Neither of the two ran away."

After that answer I stopped questioning. He went on of his own accord. "By dawn the village was saying that Phuljhari had run away with Jagesar. Then someone said Jagesar had gone toward Nepal. How can both things be true at once? If they ran away together, that is one story. If one went to Nepal, where did the other go? But no one asked."

"What did you see that makes you say they did not run away?"

Budhan Sada rubbed the callus in his right palm. "I saw blood."

"Whose?"

He did not answer.

"A body?"

"One body lay on the ground. There was no other person there."

"Who was it?"

Again he was silent. Later he said, "I will not write the name now."

"Without a name the record will remain incomplete," I objected.

"Let it remain incomplete. An incomplete thing can stay alive. If I give the name, some people will begin beating the name again."

This was said in 1961. Twenty-seven years had passed since the event. Fear was still in the present tense. I respected it. On the paper I wrote "one body" and left the name blank.

"Was the person alive?"

"When I reached there, the person was not speaking. I could not make out any breath. I was not a vaidya."

"Wounds?"

"There was blood by the head. That is all."

"A weapon?"

"I did not see one."

"People?"

"There were some footprints. The soil was soft. A footprint does not tell you a person's name."

After this sentence I understood that he was drawing the boundary of evidence deliberately. He had not seen a killing. He had not seen the killer. He had seen only the place afterward. But against the village story that they had "run away," he held the memory of a body.

"Then why do you use the word 'murder'?" I asked.

Budhan Sada answered very slowly. "Because in the evening a person stood on his own feet, at night that person's body lay in blood, and at dawn the village said he had run away. That is not running away. That was murder."

Of all four witnesses, he alone used that word: murder. But he did not answer three questions—who had been killed, who had killed, with what. I did not press him then. I understand now that he carried courage in the word and fear in the name at the same time.

"What happened to the body?"

At first he said, "I do not know." After a while: "What happens to every body." I remained silent. He corrected himself. "Strike that answer out. I will not say."

I did not strike it out. Beside it I wrote, "Witness withdraws answer."

He said one more thing about Phuljhari. "After that night I never saw her alive." This resembled Kamala Devi's "I did not see her," but carried more weight.

"Did you hear anything?"

"Many things. Across the river, her natal home, Janakpur, Darbhanga—every direction. The more directions people name, the less solid their knowledge usually is."

"And Jagesar?"

"His name began to be spoken softly in the hamlet. For two months his mother kept looking toward the road at evening. Later she left the house and went to relatives."

"Death rites?"

"No."

"Any written record of the marriage?"

"What writing would we have? People's memory was the record."

"The genealogical register?" I asked.

For the first time he laughed, though not at me; he laughed at the condition of things. "Where are our names in your register? A book that does not record my birth—what will it write of my marriage?" The laugh ended at once. "But Phuljhari's name was there, wasn't it?"

I hesitated before answering. Women's names did not appear uniformly in every register; the priest had said so. But on one old page in our house there was a notation connected with Phuljhari's paternal line. The space after "marriage" was blank. I did not tell Budhan Sada.

He said on his own, "If you are a man who writes, write one thing: she had spoken her own wish. She did not change caste; she chose a human being. The village turned her into caste."

I did not immediately understand the final phrase. "What do you mean?"

"When people stopped speaking her name and said only that a woman of a high household had gone with a man from a low hamlet, two human beings vanished and two castes remained."

I wrote that testimony with great care. Budhan Sada had not turned Phuljhari into a symbol. He gave two traits of her nature as well. "She had a temper. She cut people off in speech. If she disliked something, she said it to your face." Then he added, "Jagesar too was no innocent washed in milk. Stubborn. He would leave work to go hear a song. Whether their tempers would have matched or fought, I do not know." These small details restored two bodies as human beings, not as a story.

I read him part of the priest's testimony: no mantra, no fire, no kanyadan, no register. Budhan Sada listened and said, "Between those five things, where are the two people?"

I did not answer.

I read him Kamala Devi's sentence: "Wait until dawn." Budhan Sada lowered his head. "That sister-in-law understood."

"What?"

"The night was not good."

"How?"

"People's speech had changed. When human beings stop using a person's name and begin using caste, the night is no longer good."

Before ending the testimony I asked once more for the name of the body. Budhan Sada did not become angry this time.

"You are young," he said. "You think paper is very powerful. Paper is powerful—that is why I am afraid. Once a name goes onto paper, it will pass again into people's hands. For now I am protecting one thing; I am not making a lie."

"When will you say it?"

"When paper no longer belongs only to the masters."

I did not understand that sentence then. In 2008, opening the soaked bundle, looking at the erased line, recognizing the handwriting of my grandfather's father, I remembered it again. Whose is the paper? Who has the right to write a name? Who has the right to erase one? Budhan Sada had not supplied answers. He had merely changed the owner of the questions.

At the end of my written account in 1961 I wrote five lines: "Witness: agricultural ploughman. Resident of Musahar hamlet. Gives young man's name as Jagesar Sada. Direct statement that Phuljhari and Jagesar had resolved to live together. Says he saw one bloodied body at night; refuses to name the body. Did not directly witness killer or act of killing. Rejects popular account that they 'ran away'; uses the word 'murder' for the event."

Beneath those five lines I left one blank line. At the time the only reason was that Budhan Sada had not given the name. Long afterward I understood: a blank line is not itself evidence, but sometimes it shows what the courage to write on paper had not yet become.

Witness Four: The Panjkar

Page 217. Disputed branch.

Lineage-origin — Kaushik. Village — as before. Standing — as before.

Shridhar Mishra. Father — Vachaspati Mishra. Grandfather — Raghupati Mishra. In Shridhar's household line, one daughter — Phuljhari. Year of birth 1901. No pre-marriage record available.

Examination concerning relationship.

In the weeks after the earthquake the ordinary order of the village was disturbed. Walls of houses had fallen. Many families were living beneath temporary shelters outside their courtyards. In this condition, a dispute arose concerning Phuljhari's relationship. Statement of the elders of the family — the daughter, contrary to the honour of the household, maintains companionship with a man from the southern hamlet. The man's name not given in the first statement.

Statement of priest — no marriage was completed according to prescribed rite. Mantra, ritual fire, kanyadan, clan consent, and standing in the genealogical register absent. Presence of daughter and man near shrine acknowledged.

Daughter expressed her own wish. Priest refused to perform rite.

Testimony of woman of household — daughter left house before evening, carrying a brass plate, rice, betel nuts, sindoor, flower, and a piece of jaggery.

Returned home before night. On veranda, before elders, stated that she wished to live with the man she had chosen. In later part of night, woman of household did not see her again.

Statement of ploughman from southern hamlet — man's name Jagesar Sada. Works at ploughing, earth-cutting, and ferrying boats. Phuljhari and Jagesar have resolved to live together. Because of the ploughman's caste and hamlet, elders of family do not consider his testimony fit to be accepted.

List of evidence.

One — oral statement of priest. Two — oral statement of senior woman of household. Three — statement of ploughman from southern hamlet, disputed by family side. Four — brass plate found behind shrine. Five — bedding, saris, comb, spindle, bangles, and bottle of oil found in daughter's room in their places. Six — no bundle found indicating preparation for travel or prolonged absence. Seven — statements concerning movement of several men in and out of house during later part of night, but sequence of persons inconsistent.

None of the objects above, by itself, proves a marriage. Taken together, however, they contradict the claim that the daughter departed in broad daylight on a pre-planned journey to a distant place. Family side objects to this conclusion.

Chronology.

Before evening — daughter outside house. Reported present near shrine.

Evening — daughter returns home. Dispute on veranda. After darkness falls — movement in and out of house. Later part of night — daughter outside sight of woman witness of household. Dawn — daughter not in house. Jagesar not in his

hamlet. After dawn — statement spreads that “the two ran away.” No single eyewitness available for this entire sequence.

First entry.

Shridhar Mishra’s daughter Phuljhari, of her own will, accepted a household relationship with Jagesar Sada; mutual vow made near shrine; no permission from family.

Two diagonal marks to left of this line. Fine abrasion over line. First entry suspended pending subsequent decision.

Objections.

One — Jagesar Sada is not within the marriage-circle accepted by the family.

Two — application of gotra examination to this relationship difficult, because the man’s lineage-line is not available in this genealogical register.

Three — no consent of clan elders.

Four — priest refuses to accept that Vedic or clan-prescribed rite was completed.

Five — daughter’s statement alone not to be regarded as sufficient evidence to establish marriage-standing.

Six — testimony from southern hamlet disputed by family side.

Counterstatement.

More than one person directly heard the daughter speak. Testimony agrees upon her wish “to live together.” Testimony also agrees upon presence near shrine.

Evidence available concerning plate, sindoor, rice, betel nuts, flower. Priest does not wholly deny Jagesar’s presence. Therefore the wish for a relationship cannot be called imagined.

Nevertheless, wish and accepted marriage are not the same thing — objection of family side.

Opinion of priest — wish is personal; marriage is a matter of clan-rite and standing. Opinion of woman of household — daughter stated her decision before the household. Testimony from southern hamlet — both persons had resolved to live together. The three opinions do not lead to a single conclusion, but together they weaken the statement that “there was no relationship.”

Event of the night.

Dispute increased after evening. Daughter returned home. Men of household present. No new evidence as to whether any rite was completed or not. Mutually contradictory statements concerning whereabouts of daughter and Jagesar in later part of night. Some say both left village. Some say man went toward Nepal. Some say daughter went to natal home. No direct evidence presented for any of these statements.

Statement that an untoward event occurred toward southern hamlet in later part of night; one human body reported seen upon ground, identity not established in writing.

Two diagonal marks to left of above line. Dense ink over words “one human body.” Greater abrasion over latter half of line. Identity not established, therefore decision that this statement is not admissible in matter of genealogical marriage.

Words death or murder not entered in principal record. Reasons written — no direct evidence identifying killer, identity of body not established in writing, family side rejects statement.

Second entry.

Phuljhari — reported relationship with Jagesar Sada; no clan consent; marriage rite disputed; subsequent lineage examination suspended.

In second entry, heavy ink passed again over words “Jagesar Sada.” Paper slightly scraped above them. Two lines beneath words “subsequent lineage.”

Submission of family side.

If such relationship remains permanently in genealogical register, marriage dealings of Shridhar’s other children will be obstructed. Daughter’s personal wish should not be entered as standing over other branches of family. If matter of crossing caste-boundary remains written, questions will arise in future alliances. Family side requests removal of old line.

Panjikar’s consideration.

The genealogical register is a record of lineage, village, lineage-origin, marriage-standing, and relationship. It is not a book of punishment.

Nevertheless, precedent is unclear regarding how a relationship not accepted within society’s recognized marriage-circle is to be entered. Daughter’s wish available. Man’s name available. Evidence of mutual relationship available. Clan consent absent. Disagreement concerning rite present.

If relationship is written as “marriage,” clan side objects. If written as “non-marriage,” daughter’s direct words are rejected. If only the name is written, a future reader will not understand the kind of relationship. If nothing is written, the event will remain outside the record.

Of these four alternatives, family side urges the last.

Subsequent decision.

Entry concerning Phuljhari’s relationship shall not be fixed in marriage-line.

Name of Jagesar Sada shall not remain on principal register page. Separate dispute-sheet concerning relationship shall be retained temporarily. Standing of Shridhar’s other children shall be regarded as unaffected.

At request of family, dispute-sheet shall not be shown to outside readers.

Proposal to make two copies of dispute-sheet rejected. One copy in principal chest, without entry in external index. Page-number separate from principal sequence. By this arrangement, fact of relationship will remain available but will not appear directly in ordinary lineage-reading.

Family side requests that dispute-sheet also be destroyed. Panjikar does not immediately agree. Written — “Separate sheet shall remain; principal line shall be purified.” A fine line later drawn beneath the word “purified.”

Third entry.

Shridhar Mishra’s daughter Phuljhari — relationship dispute; decision on separate sheet.

Third entry in small letters. First abrasion over word “Phuljhari.” Second abrasion over “relationship dispute.” Latter part of “decision on separate sheet” first crossed out in ink; then upper fibres of paper removed.

Two diagonal marks on left margin of line.

Work of purification.

At first attempt only upper portion of ink lightened. Letters still readable. At second attempt paper fibres in middle of line lifted. At third attempt shapes of

letters broke; not words but only black points and half-severed portions of strokes remained.

At place of word “Phuljhari,” paper slightly thinner than surrounding area. Where “Jagesar” had stood, ink had sunk deeper, so after surface abrasion partial forms of two letters remained. Further abrasion over those partial forms.

During erasure of entry the original page did not tear, but its surface ceased to be uniform. The line appears blank; to touch, the fibres differ.

Line rubbed again.

First abrasion removed tops of letters. Second removed their middles. Mark of third abrasion reaches paper fibres. Some points of ink remain sunk below. Line difficult to read, but sufficient to show that writing once stood here.

Phuljhari’s name illegible.

Jagesar Sada’s name not on principal page.

No mention of dispute-sheet.

After Shridhar’s name, subsequent space blank.

Final form.

Shridhar Mishra. Father — Vachaspati. Grandfather — Raghupati.

Next branch from separate page.

In the blank space no word “daughter,” “marriage,” “Jagesar,” “southern hamlet,” “dispute,” or “untoward event” survives. A reader seeing only the principal genealogical register will understand Shridhar’s line to end here naturally.

Copying instructions.

In next clean copy, Shridhar’s lineage-line shall be copied in present form of principal page. Earlier text of abraded line shall not be supplied by inference. No mention of dispute-sheet in principal copy. Thus the next copy will not state the cause of the blank; it will merely repeat the blank.

If a future panjikar does not see the original page and sees only the clean copy, he will not know that a line naming Phuljhari ever stood after Shridhar’s name. The copy will carry the original’s decision to erase onto new paper without carrying the mark of abrasion.

Instruction to copyist — “Copy only as much as is legible on principal page.”

Dispute-sheet separate. Oral family account not basis of copy.

Small writer’s mark at right margin. Year 1934.

Final letter of writer’s mark turns left. Lower curve of numeral 3 open.

Correction mark — two diagonal strokes on left margin.

Appendix, not to be entered on principal page.

“Statement concerning daughter’s wish capable of verification, but inconsistent with clan-standing. Writing man’s name will increase dispute. Statements concerning night of event mutually contradictory. Family reputation, marriages of other children, and village conduct to be considered. It is proper not to retain relationship in principal line.”

Below this appendix one line was begun — “What is not written...” — after which the ink stopped. The sentence is incomplete.

Writer’s mark below.

Date.

Two diagonal lines.

Later entry, in different ink.

“Dispute-sheet not available.”

No date. No writer’s mark. Ink of this line darker than principal ink of 1934.

Below it, blankness again.

What Was Not Written

The day I laid all four written accounts together, I began by writing no conclusion. The priest's testimony, Kamala Devi's testimony, Budhan Sada's testimony, and the genealogical-register page from 1934 each had a separate weight placed upon it so that the wind would not turn the pages. On one stood a small brass bowl, on another a strip of wood, on the third an empty inkpot, on the fourth an old manuscript weight. Between them lay a blank sheet of paper. On it I wrote the heading: "What Was Not Written."

The first point of agreement concerned not names but time. According to Kamala Devi, Phuljhari left the house before evening and returned after the lamp by the tulsi had been lit. The priest acknowledges her presence near the shrine, though he changes repeatedly the time at which he himself arrived. Budhan Sada says he saw Phuljhari and Jagesar behind the shrine in the evening light. The register page too separately records these two points: going out "before evening" and returning home "in the evening." None of the four papers fills the time between them completely. But they agree on this much: Phuljhari did not leave home before the close of day for some distant place.

The second agreement concerned an object: the small brass plate. In the priest's testimony, the plate is associated with what happened at the shrine. In Kamala Devi's, it came from the household kitchen and contained rice, two betel nuts, sindoor, a dried flower, and a piece of jaggery. Budhan Sada says he saw the plate in her hand but does not say what was inside. The register page says the plate was "found behind the shrine." The plate appears in all four accounts. Its meaning appears four different ways. The object is one.

Over a smaller object, two memories moved much farther apart: the red thread. The priest separates it from the possibility of a ritual vow, as though already answering the suspicion that someone might take it for a sign of marriage. Kamala Devi says Phuljhari had scraped her wrist and that she herself had tied a small pad of cotton over it with red thread. Budhan Sada does not mention the thread. The register page does not mention it. In one account the same object bears the possibility of religious meaning; in another it is treatment for a minor bodily wound. The thread itself writes no meaning upon itself.

The colour of the sari was much the same. In the priest's memory, yellow. In Kamala Devi's, white, appearing yellow because of an old turmeric stain, with an ochre border. Budhan Sada refuses to decide the colour: white, with a coloured border—that is all. The register page leaves colour out. Such minor contradictions neither prove nor disprove the main event, but they show how memory dresses objects according to its own work. I did not strike out one colour and replace it with another.

The third agreement concerned words. The priest says Phuljhari herself expressed her wish. Kamala Devi says that on the veranda Phuljhari said, "I will live with him." Budhan Sada says Phuljhari and Jagesar had resolved to live together. The first entry on the register page says: "Of her own will, accepted a household relationship with Jagesar Sada." The four papers do not agree on the rite of marriage, but there is very little disagreement over the existence of her wish.

Beside this point I wrote no religious term. Whether a mantra was recited, whether there was sacred fire or only a lamp, whether kanyadan occurred, whether there was standing in the genealogical register—these questions dominate the priest's testimony. Kamala Devi did not witness them directly. Budhan Sada does not regard them as the central question of the relationship. The panjikar first records the wish and then lists the objections concerning standing. The four papers do not agree on the meaning of a single word, but all four circle the fact that Phuljhari herself had spoken the decision in her mind.

There was less agreement over the name. The priest says he "does not remember" the young man's name, yet remembers his hamlet, his occupation, his father's occupation, and the peepal tree near his house. Kamala Devi appears to know the name but does not want it written. Budhan Sada says the name: Jagesar Sada. The same name is present in the first and second entries on the register page; in the final form it is absent. The name had not been absent at the beginning. It was removed later.

I searched for the word "caste" in all four papers. The priest never speaks the name directly; he says "one who has no standing in the genealogical register." Kamala Devi gives the hamlet and occupation but not the caste-name. Budhan Sada says Musahar hamlet and also says that when people begin to abandon names and speak caste instead, the night is no longer good. In the register page, the family's objection states the caste boundary openly. What the spoken accounts evade, the language of objection sets down plainly.

One further absence is shared by all four papers: there is nothing in Phuljhari's own hand. Her voice comes through the priest's memory, through Kamala Devi's memory, indirectly through Budhan Sada's account, and through the panjikar's formula. The alleged sentence "I will live with him" survives, but no letters written by Phuljhari do. Every piece of evidence concerning her decision reaches us through another person's mouth or another man's paper. I did not fill this absence. I gave her no letter, no diary, no final declaration. What was not on the paper seemed to me something that ought to remain equally blank when the story was made.

That Phuljhari returned home is blurred in the priest's testimony, directly witnessed in Kamala Devi's, and accepted on the register page. Budhan Sada did not witness the return. If only the priest's paper had survived, a reader might conclude that after the shrine Phuljhari went elsewhere. If only Kamala Devi's paper remained, what happened at the shrine would be unknown. If only Budhan Sada's survived, there would be no dispute on the veranda. If only the register

page remained, everything would shrink into brief formulas of dispute, objection, and decision.

The night on the veranda was the largest blank among the four papers.

Kamala Devi says the men of the household were angry. There was a bamboo walking stick, but she attaches no special meaning to it. Voices rose. Once something of brass fell. She took the children inside. When she came out later, the veranda was empty. She says, "Wait until dawn," and also that if the night had been allowed to pass, some harm might perhaps have been averted. Her words reach as far as apprehension, not event.

The priest says little about the anger of the elders. His account dwells much more on the bounds of dharma. He frames his own role in terms of performing or refusing to perform a rite. The concrete sequence of the later part of the night is absent from his paper.

Budhan Sada was not on the veranda. He says he went with men from the Musahar hamlet toward the old mango tree to the north. He saw blood. He saw a body on the ground. Blood by the head. He did not see the killer. He did not see a weapon. He would not name the body. He has one word: "murder." Beside that word are three blank spaces in the evidence—who, whom, with what.

The register page says of the night: "Untoward event toward southern hamlet." "One human body." "Identity not established in writing." It then records the decision not to enter the words death or murder in the principal record. The reasoning for that decision: no direct witness to the killer, identity of the body not established in writing, family side rejects the statement.

Among all four papers one thing never appears as a complete sentence: once Phuljhari stated her decision on the veranda, which person went with her to which place afterward. Kamala Devi did not see. The priest does not write it. Budhan Sada does not say whom he saw with whom before reaching the site. The register page stops at "men of the household present." There is no sequence of persons.

On the blank sheet I drew four lines. On the first: Phuljhari returned home. On the second: dispute on the veranda. On the third: movement of several men in the later part of the night. On the fourth: a bloodied body to the north. Between the first and fourth lines there was no direct witness. This was not a blank to be filled by writing a story into it.

The story of dawn formed differently. Kamala Devi did not see Phuljhari. Budhan Sada rejects the popular story that Jagesar "ran away." The priest's testimony contains no concrete account of dawn. The register page writes: "Dawn — daughter not in house. Jagesar not in his hamlet. After dawn — statement spreads that the two ran away." Between "not found" and "ran away" in that sequence, no witness is written.

None of the four papers says whose mouth first uttered the sentence "they ran away." None says who carried it from hamlet to hamlet. None says who added the direction of Nepal. None says who added the direction of the natal home. The

directions multiplied; the source disappeared. The farther an event travelled, the more place-names it acquired.

The four papers do not carry equal weight regarding the bloodied body either. The priest's testimony never reaches it. Kamala Devi saw the inner part of the night, not the outside place. Budhan Sada saw the body but withheld the name. The panjika recorded the body, then, because the identity was uncertain, removed the words death and murder from the principal record. Here "no one says" and "no one can say" are not the same thing. Budhan Sada knows something and deliberately withholds the name; the panjika writes something and deliberately removes it from the principal line. The causes of the two silences are different.

Another blank lay in the direction of Jagesar's house. Budhan Sada says his mother looked toward the road every evening for two months. No death rites were performed. Even "the body did not come home" is not written on his paper; only that there were no death rites. The register page contains no statement from Jagesar's family. The priest does not mention that household. Kamala Devi does not even speak the name. Jagesar stood outside the standing of the genealogical register; responsibility for recording his absence also settled nowhere.

Objects remained in Phuljhari's house—the bedding, saris, comb, spindle, bangles, bottle of oil. There was no bundle prepared for travel. Kamala Devi herself limits the meaning of these things: "The objects remained—that is the fact." The register page repeats the same list and writes only that these objects do not fit the account of a pre-planned departure to a distant place. But the objects do not say where Phuljhari went after the night.

One paper is filled with objects, one with rules, one with a body seen through fear, one with an abraded line. Reading the four together does not make the event larger. It makes many small blanks clearer.

I read the three register entries again.

In the first, both Phuljhari and Jagesar are named.

In the second, the relationship is disputed and lineage examination suspended.

In the third, only: "relationship dispute; decision on separate sheet."

Then abrasion.

The missing dispute-sheet is a different kind of blank from anything in the four testimonies. Human memory can forget, stop from fear, alter words under prejudice. But here the words "separate sheet" are written and the sheet is absent. That is a material absence. Whether the sheet was never made or was made and later removed, the principal page says only that an arrangement was recorded for making it. The later line in darker ink—"Dispute-sheet not available"—is a later witness to the absence, not to its cause.

The principal page mentions that a separate dispute-sheet was to remain outside it. The sheet itself is not available. Who removed it from the chest, when, by whose order—no paper says. The principal page bears the marks of abrasion;

the absence of the dispute-sheet bears no mark of abrasion. On one object the marks of erasure survive. The other object itself does not survive.

I compared again the shape of the writer's mark belonging to my grandfather's father: the final letter turning left, the open lower curve of the numeral three, the two diagonal correction marks. These things identify a hand. They do not identify the reasons of a mind. A hand can be recognized. Why the hand moved cannot be said by paper without inference.

In the appendix a sentence begins: "What is not written..." After that, the ink stops.

This incomplete sentence weighed more than the blank sheet I had laid among the four papers. I could have supplied what came next: "does not remain," "is false," "survives," "is erased." But none of those words stood on the original paper. I added none.

That day I sat down to make a summary of the four witnesses, but no summary emerged. To make a summary one account must be made principal and another secondary. Here each of the four papers preserved a different thing—the priest the limits of rite, Kamala Devi the order of the household, Budhan Sada the bloodied body and fear of naming it, the panjihar society's acceptance and the record's decision. Remove any one and the event changes.

So I wrote only a list of agreements and contradictions.

Agreement — Phuljhari spoke her wish.

Agreement — the account of a relationship with Jagesar was not imaginary.

Agreement — there is basis for both being present near the shrine.

Agreement — Phuljhari returned home.

Agreement — there was a dispute in the house.

Agreement — the sequence in the later part of the night is unclear.

Agreement — at dawn Phuljhari was not in the house.

Agreement — Jagesar was not in his hamlet.

Contradiction — whether a marriage occurred.

Contradiction — when the priest arrived.

Contradiction — colour of the sari.

Contradiction — meaning of the red thread.

Contradiction — who was present at the site of the night's event.

Blank — name of the bloodied body.

Blank — name of the killer.

Blank — Phuljhari's whereabouts in the later part of the night.

Blank — Jagesar's final whereabouts.

Blank — the dispute-sheet.

Blank — source of the first statement that "they ran away."

Beneath this list I left room for a conclusion.

I wrote nothing.

When I closed the manuscripts that night, I again kept all four papers separate. The blank sheet remained in the middle. It bore only its heading, the list of agreements and contradictions, and the final empty space. No name had

the word guilty beside it. No name had innocent beside it either. No death was proved. No flight was proved. No marriage was proved in full. No relationship was denied either.

What the papers said, remained. Where they did not speak, the space remained blank.

The shape of that blank was not the same in all four papers, but once the four were laid beside one another it became clear that sometimes the largest sentence in written history is the one whose words never reached the page.

The Flood of 1934

I kept the papers from a few months after the earthquake separately. Not beside the four testimonies. After them. For some traces of what could not be found in the night's blank appeared in the registers of the rainy season. Not traces of the offence; traces of the place. Where the Musahar hamlet stood, how many houses it contained, how far its dwellings reached along the field-ridges, and how the name of that place was written after the flood—things such as these.

I had three kinds of paper. First, a handwritten list of damage to houses after the earthquake. Second, a ledger of grain relief from the rainy season. Third, copies of revenue papers from the following year. In the three, the same hamlet appeared under three different names: Musahar Toli, Southern Hamlet, Settlement of Agricultural Labourers. The name changed according to the maker of the paper. The people remained the same.

The post-earthquake list recorded twenty-seven houses. Five were marked “completely collapsed,” nine “unfit for habitation”; the rest had cracked walls, fallen roofs, broken hearths, or leaning earthen walls. The list contained fewer owners' names than descriptions of houses: “thatch,” “earth,” “one room,” “two rooms,” “with veranda.” Jagesar Sada's name appeared nowhere. Nor did his mother's. But the name of Budhan Sada's father was there. From that I could identify the location of the hamlet.

At the bottom of the list was one line: “Earth subsided beside the southern channel.” Whether the writer had written the word for “channel” exactly so, or a form of “beside the channel,” the letters were worn. I did not enlarge their meaning. Other memories too agreed on this much: during the earthquake the earth split and sank in places. Whether the river's main current then ran there, the paper does not say.

The rainy-season ledger was of an entirely different kind. It did not record damaged houses but measures of rice: names, number of persons in a family, grain given. On the first two pages were eighteen families of the southern hamlet. On the third was written: “Remaining families on high ground to the north.” On the fourth, five names appeared again. Half of the fifth page had been destroyed by a water stain.

It was in this ledger that I first read the sentence: “Settlement washed away.” There was no official's signature above it, none below. Some clerk had added it in an empty space between entries. The ink was paler than the surrounding lines. No date. What boundary was meant by “settlement” was not stated.

The village elders did not repeat this event the way they repeated the earthquake. For the day of the earthquake everyone had some sound—the bell, the wall, the lota, a tree, an animal. For the flood there was one short sentence:

“That time the southern hamlet did not survive.” Then they moved on to something else.

Once in childhood I asked my grandfather where the southern hamlet had stood. He pointed beyond the fields. By then there was sand there. Two babul trees. Water during the rainy season. Grazing ground in winter.

“That way,” he said.

He did not give a name.

Another time I asked where the people settled afterward.

“Wherever they found land.”

That answer was not a place.

The old copies of revenue papers were more useful here. In descriptions of field boundaries before the flood, three names recurred: to the east, such-and-such field; to the west, dwellings of the Musahar hamlet; to the south, the old channel; to the north, the mango grove. In the post-flood copy, “dwellings of the Musahar hamlet” had disappeared. In its place was written: “sandy fallow.” One group of words replaced by another. No line had been scraped away. No name crossed out. In the next copy, the old habitation had become a category of land.

This change was different from the erased line in the genealogical register. There, the friction of a hand was visible. Here water altered the earth first, and paper afterward. The writer of the paper wrote what he saw: sand. But the next page did not say that beneath the sand had been the place of houses.

Budhan Sada had said in his testimony that the bloodied body was seen near the old mango tree. To identify that place I read three separate accounts by elders. One said northwest of the hamlet. Another, at the bend of the old channel. The third, below the mango grove. The revenue papers brought all three indications into approximately the same strip of ground. The post-flood name of that strip was: sandy fallow.

I did not make a map. The measurements of distance were insufficient. Drawing lines of inference does not turn paper into reality. I wrote the three indications on one sheet and left a blank space between them.

Accounts did not agree on when the monsoon water rose either. Some said at night. Some, after midday. Some, after three days of rain. One government ledger said “strong current.” Another paper said “erosion.” Villagers said “the river came back.” I never heard anyone state with certainty that the earthquake turned the river. People linked events: the earth shook, soil split, the rains came, the channel changed, the hamlet went. How much in that sequence was cause and how much coincidence, the papers do not say.

But one thing was certain. After the flood the Musahar hamlet was no longer on its old ground.

Descriptions of the settlement being washed away contain very few names. One old woman was put into a boat. Two children spent the night on a bamboo platform. Four goats were swept away. One bullock, still tied by its rope, became lodged in a tree. Three grain jars were destroyed. Hearths dissolved into earth. In

all these details there is no Phuljhari. No Jagesar. No bloodied body. It is as though that night did not belong to the papers of the rainy season.

That too was natural. A relief clerk distributing aid did not search for a dispute from three months earlier. His work was to count the living, distribute grain, arrange boats. But when in 2008 I read these ledgers together, I understood that the natural limit of an administrative purpose had become convenient for the later silence. The physical place of a question that was already unanswered no longer survived either.

In the sister-in-law's testimony, the objects from Phuljhari's room survived—the bedding, comb, spindle, bangles, bottle of oil. The post-flood list of damaged houses does not mention that house. The family's principal house stood on high ground in the village; it survived. The later fate of the objects is not on paper. The southern hamlet was washed away, but the principal house of Phuljhari's natal family was not. The flood therefore did not directly erase her own objects. It erased only the geography in which lay Jagesar's house, the old mango tree, the bend in the channel, and the probable place of the bloodied body.

The distinction mattered. The river did not wash away the entire history of the family. It washed away one side's place. The other side's house, ledgers, and genealogical register remained.

After the flood, the families of the southern hamlet were entered in relief lists under different village names. One at a maternal uncle's dwelling. One beside the threshing floor of a landowner. One near a raised bamboo platform. One on the high strip to the north. Because of this scattering, the old hamlet no longer appears as one unit in the next set of papers. The people survived, but the cluster of names broke apart.

The relief list also accounted for things distributed: rice, flattened rice, salt, oil, dry firewood, blankets for two families, bamboo for three, thatch for one. The paper counted quantities of objects, not human sorrow. That was not a fault; its purpose was precisely this. But among the quantities one fact became clear—the families of the southern hamlet were not resettled together. Wherever someone found a few days' shelter, there that person's name was entered.

In a paper from one year later, of those eighteen families seven names appeared under another village, four appeared with altered surnames, three could not be identified with certainty, and regarding the rest I reached no conclusion. Whether these changes came from death, migration, marriage, or merely a different writer, the paper does not distinguish. I put no question marks beside the names; I recorded only the source.

As the physical line of the southern hamlet broke, its social line scattered too. Families that had lived beside one another now settled on field edges, in relatives' courtyards, or behind a landlord's cattle shed. One elder's account contained the sentence: "Our hamlet survived then in people, not on the land." I wrote it on a separate sheet. It was not a measure of fact, but it was evidence of the experience of displacement.

Before the flood, directions through the village commonly ran: “past the southern hamlet to the mango grove.” In two recollections after the flood, the same route was called “across the strip of sand.” No order was needed to erase the place-name. Usage changed, language changed, and later the paper changed.

Searching for Jagesar’s mother’s name, I reached the ends of three lists. No identification was certain. Two women’s names were possible, but the husbands’ names beside them were unclear. Budhan Sada had said she looked toward the road at evening for two months. If the flood came within those two months, the site of her house may have been washed away. If it came later, she may already have gone elsewhere. There was no basis on which to settle the date. I recorded both possibilities separately.

Beside that paper I wrote one question: “When the house was gone, where did the waiting go?”

There was no answer.

Looking at the first marriage records after the flood, I noticed another change. In descriptions of people from the southern hamlet, the old place-name became less common. Names of new dwellings appeared: “temporarily in such-and-such village,” “resident in such-and-such hamlet,” “staying for labour.” Landless families came to be identified more by relatives or landlords than by land. In the world of the genealogical register, lineage-origin and village were treated as stable; in these government ledgers a village could be moved by water.

I thought: a society capable of erasing one person’s name from a line can watch the name of an entire hamlet disappear from paper after a river and regard it as an ordinary change. But I did not write the thought in my notes. In the notes I kept only the fact: before the flood, “dwellings of the Musahar hamlet”; after the flood, “sandy fallow.”

I opened again the pages of the four testimonies. Budhan Sada’s account contained one line: “The land too does not remember everything.” At first I had taken it as a figurative sentence. After reading the flood papers, its physical meaning became clear. The ground where houses had stood became sand. The site of the mango tree could not later be found. The bend of the old channel was not clearly marked on the next year’s map. The geography of evidence had changed.

Even so, not everything vanished. The old copy of the revenue paper survived. The list of damaged houses survived. The food-relief ledger survived. Two or four sentences in people’s mouths survived. And the abraded line in the genealogical register survived. A river erases earth, but not all paper at once. People erase paper, but cannot erase every mark.

Here I wrote no new conclusion about the role of my grandfather’s father. The flood is not evidence of what he did. It only makes later examination more difficult. What was erased from the principal line had its external geography altered by water a few months later—that is the sequence. It seemed improper to write the word “convenience,” because the river flows for no one’s convenience.

But people can make use of a change. There was no direct evidence of that, only the silence afterward.

I found one page of a village meeting held after the flood. Subject: land for new dwellings on higher ground. Five family names. Beside the third was written: "from the southern hamlet." No caste. No number of the former house. Beneath the proposal, two signatures and four thumbprints. Decision: "Permitted to reside temporarily." Nothing concerning permanent rights.

The back of that page was blank.

One more thing on the village-meeting page deserved notice. The word "temporary" had been written for five families, yet in later papers two of those temporary dwellings appear as permanent houses. No separate decision marked when "temporary" became permanent. The life of the administrative word was short on paper; the life of people's dwelling was longer. Because of that difference, reconstruction of the old hamlet passed by itself beyond the field of questions.

I looked at the blank back of the page for a long time. There was no scraping. No erased ink. Only the white surface of paper. Sometimes a blank is made. Sometimes a blank remains because no one sees any need to write further. To a later reader the results can look exactly alike.

At the beginning of the section, when I found no continuation after three names, I had assumed water damage. By now the meaning of the words water damage had grown larger. Water does not merely wash letters away. Water changes places. Once the place changes, the context of a name changes. Once the context changes, the next writer may omit the old line without knowing whose history he has shortened.

At the end of the papers on the flood of 1934, I wrote two lines.

First: "The southern Musahar hamlet was uprooted from its old site."

Second: "After the flood, the probable physical site of the night's event is difficult to identify."

I raised my pen to write a third line. The thought came: "Who benefited from this?"

I did not write it.

There was no evidence on paper for an answer to the question.

It was not raining outside. The waters of 2008 were not very far from the house, but my room was quiet that night. I gathered the old ledgers and placed them beside the bundle of genealogical papers. On one side, the abraded line of 1934. On the other, the sandy fallow of 1934. One, the work of a human hand. The other, the work of water. It would not have been right to combine them in a single sentence.

I kept them separate.

Part III — The Embankment (1954–1966)

The Agreement

In Baisakh of 1954 I was eighteen. The first news that reached the village about the Kosi was not on paper. Men returning from the market said that an agreement had been made between Nepal and India about holding back the waters of the Kosi. The next day the news had changed: a great dam would be built on the Kosi. On the third day it was said the river would be confined between two embankments. On the fourth, someone said the village would be moved. No one had a paper.

I was drying pages of the genealogical register beside my grandfather. Hearing the news, he asked only, “Who said it?”

Three names came in reply: the oilman from the market, the clerk at the post office, and the brother-in-law of a constable who had come from the police-station side.

“Three witnesses are not one witness,” my grandfather said.

At the time the sentence seemed to me only a rule of the register. Later I understood that the village’s new history began in precisely that form—three reports, three sources, no original paper.

Two weeks later an old copy of a newspaper arrived at the post office. One corner was torn. A short item in the middle contained the words Kathmandu, twenty-fifth of April, Government of India, Government of Nepal, Kosi Project, barrage, canal, flood control, and electricity. The post-office clerk read it aloud. Everyone stopped at the word “barrage.”

“What is a barrage?”

Someone said, “A dam.”

Someone said, “Gates.”

The clerk read the line again. The distinction was not clear to him either.

I took the newspaper and read the words again. On paper it said “flood control.” It said “irrigation.” It said “electricity.” It said “construction on Nepalese territory.” It did not name our village.

The village’s first question was about the name of the village.

“Where will our village fall?”

The newspaper did not answer.

My grandfather examined it. He said nothing about benefit or harm from the project. He wrote down only the date—25 April 1954. Not on a blank page of the genealogical register, but in a separate ledger of his own, used for household expenses, visitors, letters concerning marriage alliances, and brief notes on

unusual events. He wrote: "Received news of India-Nepal agreement concerning the Kosi."

"That is all?" I asked.

"For now, that is all the evidence."

At the beginning of Jyeshtha the first government paper arrived. It came to the headman's house. Four men gathered to read it; I was the fifth. The department's name stood at the top, Kosi Project below, and between them a notice of survey. River, bank, field, road, drain, elevation, soil, distance: all would be measured. Officials would enter where necessary. Equipment would be brought. Marks would be placed. Villagers were to cooperate.

The headman read the paper and said, "There is nothing here about demolishing houses."

An old farmer asked, "Is there anything about the houses being safe?"

The headman looked at the paper again. He gave no answer.

That evening, at the village gathering place, the word "agreement" ceased for the first time to be a word from the newspaper and became a village word. Someone said Delhi would straighten the river. Someone said Nepal would hold the water in the hills. Someone said once the canal came, rice yields would double. A cultivator said that if the river stayed between two embankments, the fields outside would be safe. An old man from the southern hamlet asked, "And what of those who remain between the two embankments?"

There was silence by way of answer.

I did not yet understand the meaning of the question. No one knew where the embankment lines would run. No map had reached the village.

Three days later two officials arrived. One was a local amin, the other a survey worker from outside. They carried a long chain, two red-and-white ranging rods, a tripod, a leather case, a tube of papers, a hammer, wooden pegs, and a small ledger. Two more boxes had come by bullock cart. Village children followed behind to see the instruments.

The survey worker first went to the headman's house. He showed a paper. The headman signed it. Then they moved toward the fields.

I went too. From curiosity, not work.

The first measurement was taken from the western corner of the pond. The amin stretched the chain. A boy stepped on it; the amin made him move. The survey worker opened the tripod and set the instrument upon it. He looked toward the distant rod. He wrote a number in his ledger. Then the rod moved to another place.

The villagers did not watch the numbers. They watched the pegs.

The first wooden peg was driven into a field boundary. The hammer struck three times. The owner of the field asked, "What line is this?"

"For now, only a survey mark," the amin said.

"The embankment?"

"Cannot be said yet."

"A canal?"

“Not yet.”

“Will they take the land?”

“I do not have that order.”

Four questions. Three times: not yet. Once: no order.

I remembered the sequence.

By noon five pegs had been driven. Two received a small dab of red paint. One field-owner spoke of wiping the paint away. His brother stopped him: meddling with a government mark would bring trouble. By evening the red marks had become the village’s chief subject of conversation.

My grandfather asked me, “What did you see?”

I named the things: chain, rods, tripod, ledger, pegs, red paint.

“What did they say?”

I repeated the four questions and answers.

“Write the objects separately. The statements separately.”

I had practised this rule in the genealogical register. That night I applied it for the first time to a government survey.

In a separate ledger I wrote:

Persons	arrived:	two.
Local	amin:	one.
Outside	survey	worker:
Equipment:	chain, rods, tripod	instrument, paper tube, hammer, pegs.
Pegs	driven:	at least
Red	marks:	two
Declared	purpose:	survey.
Final	line of	embankment:
Line	of	canal:

Land acquisition: not confirmed in statements made this day.

I did not write “the village will survive.”

I did not write “the village will drown” either.

The next day the survey party went into the northern fields. This time three labourers accompanied them. One carried a rod, one cut brush, one carried the pegs. The cleared strip was no more than an arm or two across. Even so, people began saying, “A line is being made.”

Whether the line existed on paper or in the field seemed a small distinction to them. Once a peg entered the ground, the line was taken as real.

A woman standing beside her field asked, “Will the canal come here?”

“Mother, for now it is only measurement,” the amin said.

“Even a measurement is for something.”

The amin remained silent.

That absence of an answer seemed clearer to me than the first newspaper report. The agreement had been written in Kathmandu. On paper its purposes occupied four or five words—flood control, irrigation, electricity, prevention of erosion. But in the village the agreement arrived in the form of pegs. Around

every peg driven into a field boundary came questions: this land? this house? this road? this pond? this cremation ground? this hamlet?

The survey workers did not answer every question. Their work was measurement.

On the fourth day the survey changed form. This time, instead of the chain, equipment for testing the soil arrived. Two labourers twisted an iron auger down into the ground. When the round tube came up, the earth inside showed layer upon layer—black at the top, grey below, then sand. The worker put samples into little paper packets and wrote marks upon them. A field-owner asked, “What do you learn from this soil?”

“The ground underneath.”

“What will you do after learning the ground underneath?”

“Test for construction.”

“Construction here?”

“The line is not final.”

That day people’s fear shifted from the pegs to the tubes of soil. One old man said that if officials had begun looking beneath the earth, something large was certainly coming. Another said government men tested soil when they meant to build a road. A third said the ground was tested for canals. No one offered evidence.

I saw the marks on the packets: not one, two, three, four, but combinations of letters and numbers. The same marks appeared in the worker’s ledger. I could see no field-owner’s name. Place was becoming number.

That evening I told my grandfather, “They do not write the names of fields. They write numbers.”

“Numbers must be enough for their work.”

“If names are not there, how will they know the place?”

“There will be a map.”

“What if the name on the map is wrong?”

He looked at me. “Then, when they ask, tell them the correct one.”

At the other end of the village, meanwhile, a different account was being kept. Which field received a peg, from which field soil was taken, on which boundary a red mark appeared—people were making lists in memory. No one put them on paper. By the fifth day one farmer had counted thirteen pegs. Another said sixteen. The children said nineteen. I had no right to see the amin’s ledger.

The count itself became news.

Thirteen pegs meant embankment.

Sixteen meant canal.

Nineteen meant half the village would become government land.

None of these meanings was written on the pegs. People supplied them.

That week a clerk arrived by bicycle carrying revenue papers from the tehsil. A copy of the revenue map was opened on the headman’s veranda. The survey map and revenue map were laid beside one another. The bend of the old channel was not the same on the two papers. The officials discussed it among themselves. I

stood too far away to hear the words clearly. Later the amin said that the old map was approximate in many places and that the new measurements would correct the line.

The word “correct” struck me as strange.

In the genealogical register, when we change a name, we write the reason. If a line on a map changes, where does the reason for the old line remain? I did not ask the question then.

That night I wrote in my separate ledger: “Difference seen between old revenue map and new survey line. Reason not heard.”

I did not write “old one incorrect.”

I did not write “new one correct” either.

A small village meeting was held. The headman said the work of the survey party was not to be obstructed. No one was to pull out marks placed on field boundaries. A farmer said a peg stood where his rice was to be transplanted. The amin said rice could be planted around it, but the peg must not be removed. A woman said the children might pull it out in play. Thorny branches were then planted around the peg.

Village thorns were set to guard a government mark.

At the meeting I heard the word “compensation” for the first time. A man asked, “If they take the land, will we receive its value?”

“The paper for taking land has not come yet,” the headman said.

“Later?”

“Later paper will come later.”

No one laughed at the answer.

My grandfather had not gone to the meeting. I told him when I returned.

“Was there a value written on the paper?” he asked.

“No.”

“Then do not write one in your ledger either.”

I gradually understood that for him, not writing an uncertain thing was not only impartiality. It was self-protection. A written word later becomes evidence. Once it becomes evidence, people seize the writer too.

On the third day they went beside the old channel. A strip of sand had formed there after the flood of 1934. The elders gave differing accounts of where the southern hamlet had once stood. The amin asked one old man, “How far did the old settlement extend?”

The old man pointed in two directions. He gave no exact boundary.

The amin asked another. The second man indicated a place roughly fifty cubits west of the first.

The survey worker wrote something in his ledger.

I stood at a distance. I did not then possess the collected memories of the elders that appear in Chapter 9; I gathered those much later. But here, for the first time, I saw that even while making a government map, human memory entered the measurement. The ranging rod may stand straight; the finger of the person answering does not necessarily point straight.

At noon the survey worker asked me, "Do you know the old village names?"
"Some."

He had heard from the headman that our house kept genealogical registers.

"Tomorrow we may need to see some papers."

"Which papers?"

"Village names, old hamlets, boundaries. Not lineage—place-names."

For the first time I understood that words from the genealogical register could enter the work of a government map.

When I returned home I told my grandfather. He was silent for a while. Then he asked, "Did they ask for the register?"

"No. They said they need to understand the names."

"Then tell them the names. Only as far as you are certain."

"The names of old hamlets?"

"If a name is in the register, look at the register. If it exists in people's mouths, say that it is people's account."

"If a name from the register goes onto a government map?"

"The form of a name changes when the paper changes. That is why the source must be stated."

I wrote the sentence down.

That night I laid three papers together: the newspaper containing the 1954 agreement, the headman's survey notice, and my own list of what I had seen. They were three different kinds of paper. The first said two governments had agreed. The second said a survey would be made. The third said what had appeared before my own eyes.

None of the three wrote the village's future.

Before extinguishing the lamp my grandfather said, "Tomorrow, if you read names, read the letters—not desire."

I did not yet understand the weight of the sentence.

At dawn the survey party returned. This time the tube of paper was already open in the outside worker's hand. Inside was a map: the outer line of the village, the river, the old channel, some roads, some names. Not every name was correct. Two village names were mispronounced in writing. One hamlet's name was missing.

He did not put the paper on the ground. He opened it on the headman's veranda, weighting the four corners with bricks.

I sat in front of it.

The survey worker placed a finger on one name.

"What village is this?"

I read it. Corrected the pronunciation.

A second name.

I read again.

Before the third name there was an empty space.

"And here?" he asked.

Before answering I remembered my grandfather's sentence: only as far as you are certain.

"The old name will have to be checked."

The worker stopped his pencil.

"We will see tomorrow."

At that moment my first government job had not begun. Only one word had been held back. But looking back from the chapters that followed, I see that it was that withheld word that led me toward the second register of my life.

That evening another wooden peg was driven into a field west of the village.

It was painted red.

There was no sentence written beside it.

CHAPTER 18

The Map

After dawn the map was opened again on the headman's veranda. Bricks held down all four corners. The night's damp had curled two corners of the paper slightly. The survey worker from outside brushed dust from its surface with a cloth. The local amin opened his ledger. There was a third man that day, new to us—a clerk from the revenue office. He carried a copy of the old map, one thick ledger, and a stack of thin sheets.

A low stool was placed for me at the edge of the veranda.

"What is your name?" the survey worker asked.

"Ramanugrah Mishra."

"Age?"

"Eighteen."

He looked toward the clerk. The clerk wrote something in his ledger. Then the worker said, "We will begin with the name we stopped at yesterday."

I looked at the map. Before the third name there was now a small pencil dot. Nothing had been there yesterday. It was not a question mark; no question mark had been drawn. It marked only the place where writing had been stopped.

I remembered my grandfather's words: read the letters, not desire.

I had not brought the original genealogical register from home. My grandfather had not allowed it. He had copied the necessary extracts onto three slips of paper. The first contained an old village-name and its two forms. The second, the name of the southern hamlet. The third, the name of a pond that appeared repeatedly as a boundary reference in old lineage entries. At the bottom of each he had written: "Original manuscript at home."

I opened the first slip.

"The older form here is 'Sonbarsa,'" I said. "Later lines also contain 'Sonbarisa.' In the village people now say 'Sonbarsa.'"

"We need one name," the clerk said.

"The present pronunciation is Sonbarsa."

He wrote "Sonbarsa." The second old form did not enter the government paper.

The worker put his finger on another name. On the map it was written "Kamalpur." On the slip it was "Kamalpura." People in the village said "Kamalpura." The amin too said "Kamalpura." The clerk crossed out the old entry and wrote "Kamalpura."

The third place was difficult. The map had no name there, only a line. The slip said: "Southern hamlet, Musahar settlement, east of the old channel."

"Is there a settlement there now?" the worker asked.

"Not on that spot."

"Then why give it a name now?"

I did not answer. The question lay at the boundary of my work. The slip spoke only of the old record.

"After the earthquake the channel shifted," the amin said. "The hamlet moved."

"Where did the people go?" the clerk asked.

The amin shrugged. "Some west, some away, some unknown."

"The map needs the present place," the worker said. "The old settlement can remain in a note."

On a thin sheet the clerk wrote: "old settlement." He did not write caste or the name of the hamlet.

"Will you not write the name?" I asked.

"If there is no village there now, not on the main map."

"The name is in the genealogical register."

"The genealogical register is a lineage document. This is work for the land record."

The sentence stayed with me. For the first time someone had drawn, in front of me, a line between the genealogical register and the land record.

The worker opened another sheet. The old course of the river was in blue pencil, field boundaries in black, new survey points in red. Individual houses inside the village were not shown. Only some roads, ponds, the temple, bamboo groves, and large field blocks.

"Do you know the old name of this pond?" he asked.

I looked at the slip. "Harin Pokhari."

The clerk wrote "Hareen Pokhar."

"Harin," I said. "With the retroflex n."

He looked at me. "Pronunciation?"

"Harin."

The amin did not laugh. He only said, "People here do say Harin."

The clerk struck it out and wrote again. This time: "Harin Pokhari."

I looked at the letters. Correcting one letter was a small thing. Yet something in me settled. In a panjika's house, a letter is not merely sound; it is a path into lineage. On a map, a letter was becoming a path into place.

By noon I had read eleven names. Five were already on the map. The spellings of three were changed. Two were added for the first time. One name—the southern hamlet—did not enter the main map; on a thin auxiliary sheet it was becoming "old settlement."

For those eleven names the clerk made a separate name-sheet. I copied it into my small notebook. The sequence that day was as follows:

Sonbarsa — two forms in genealogical register — present village pronunciation: Sonbarsa — on map: Sonbarsa.
Kamalapura — old map: Kamalpur — local pronunciation: Kamalapura — on map: Kamalapura.

Harin Pokhari — old map: Hareen Pokhar — genealogical register and local pronunciation agree — on map: Harin Pokhari.

Southern Hamlet — clear in genealogical register — no present settlement on that site — on main map: no — on auxiliary sheet: old settlement. Chandrahi — name used as boundary marker in genealogical register — same pronunciation among cultivators — on map: Chandrahi. Old Kosi — genealogical register: Kaushiki channel — current local name: Old Kosi — on map: Old Kosi.

The greatest difference in this list was not one of letters but of place. Some names entered the main map, some the auxiliary sheet, some remained only on my slips. For the first time I understood that it was not enough for a name to be written on paper; the paper on which it was written would also decide its future life. The main map would remain before the next official. The auxiliary sheet might go into a bundle in an office. My slip would go into a chest at home. The future of the same name was not equal in all three places.

“What does not fit on the main map,” the clerk told me, “we will put in the notes.”

“Will the notes remain with the map afterward?” I asked.

“According to office rules, they should.”

I remembered the word “should” separately. It was not evidence.

From time to time the clerk asked, “Is this the government name or the people’s?”

I would answer, “This is the form in the genealogical register,” or “This is what people in the village say,” or “The two agree.”

Where I was uncertain, I said, “Needs verification.”

“Needs verification” was written three times.

At midday the worker opened his food box. The amin went home. The clerk ate flattened rice and jaggery. I was about to rise and go home when the worker said, “There is more work after noon. We could keep you to read names. Seven days. The office will pay you.”

At first I did not understand that the proposal was for me.

“Me?”

“Yes. You know the old names of the village. You read the letters clearly. Stay seven days.”

“I will ask my grandfather and tell you.”

“I can write your name now,” the clerk said. “If you do not stay, we will strike it out.”

“I will ask first.”

He stopped his pencil.

At home I told my grandfather. He examined the slips again.

“Will they ask for the original manuscripts?”

“Not yet.”

“What will you have to do?”

“Read names. Explain old places. Sometimes consult the genealogical register.”

“Will you draw the lines on the map?”

“No.”

“Will you decide land boundaries?”

“No.”

“Then say only as much as you know. Where you do not know, do not speak. Do not add inference because they are paying you.”

I agreed.

That day my grandfather gave me a small cloth pouch. Inside were three slips, a pencil, and a little paper notebook. The original genealogical register remained at home.

I returned after noon. The worker entered my name on the list of assistants for seven days. I had never heard the title of the post before. The clerk said, “Shall I write ‘local name assistant?’”

“Write it.”

Thus the title of my first paid work became: Local Name Assistant.

I received no appointment letter that day. There was only my name on a seven-day list, my signature at the end of each day, and later a payment slip. But I regarded it as a job. For the first time someone would pay government money for the letters I knew how to read at home.

After noon the party went toward the eastern boundary of the village. An old revenue map was pinned to a bamboo board. The paper with the new measurements was separate. The old map showed field-block numbers. In some places, owners’ names appeared in a separate ledger. In the genealogical register, a family spread across three or four generations; in the revenue ledger it was identified through pieces of land.

At one field the clerk asked, “Old name of this block?”

“Chandrahi.”

“In the genealogical register?”

“It appears as a boundary in two marriage entries.”

“Owner?”

“The genealogical register does not state who owns land.”

He looked in the old revenue ledger. There were three owners’ names. Two were dead; the son of one cultivated the field. The clerk said something to the amin about striking out names and entering new ones. I remained silent there. It was not my work.

Then it became clear to me that the genealogical register and the revenue ledger recognized the same human being in different ways. In the register he was a man of such-and-such lineage-origin, such-and-such village, son of such-and-such father, connected by such-and-such marriage. In the revenue ledger he was holder of such-and-such plot. On the map he did not even have a name; only a number.

One person, three forms on three papers.

I wrote no conclusion from this. I put only an example into my small notebook.

The next day the survey party went beside the old river course. At one place the amin stopped me and asked, "What is the name of this channel?"

"People now call it 'Old Kosi.' In an old line of the genealogical register it appears as 'Kaushiki channel.'"

"What shall we write on the map?" the worker asked.

I remembered my grandfather's rule. "The present name is Old Kosi. The other form is historical."

The worker wrote "Old Kosi."

"Kaushiki" remained on my slip.

On the third day I understood that making a map does not mean drawing lines alone. It also means choosing names. Of two names, one is selected. Of three forms, one spelling is written. A place no longer inhabited may lose its name from the principal paper. A road that people have always called one thing may have another official name.

I had a role in this choosing of names. A small one, but a role.

At one place that role made me uncomfortable. People called a group of fields to the west "Phulwari." On the old map it was "Phulwaria." In one line of the genealogical register it was "Phulbari." Whether all three words referred to the same place or to three neighbouring places was uncertain.

"Choose one," the worker said.

"I cannot choose yet."

The clerk grew impatient. "Leave the map blank?"

"It can be checked."

"With whom?"

"There are two elders. One man cultivates the fields. There are two more lines in the genealogical register."

The worker accepted this. He drew a pencil circle around the spot. By evening three people had been asked. Two said "Phulwari," one "Phulwaria." A later line in the genealogical register had "Phulwari." "Phulwari" went onto the map.

That day I had felt proud of my work. Thinking of it now, fear attaches itself to the pride. Once a name enters a map, the next official treats it as a source. If that day I had guessed and said "Phulwaria," perhaps later papers would have continued the same form.

On the fifth day the revenue clerk allowed me to see an old ledger. The paper was thick; insects had eaten the edges of some pages. Names of households, field numbers, areas, old revenue figures, corrections in red ink.

"How old is this ledger?" I asked.

He named a year. I do not remember it.

Turning the pages I saw a familiar village-name. In the genealogical register, four lineage-origins were associated with that village. In the revenue ledger there was no place for lineage-origin. Only village, plot, holder.

"Why is lineage-origin not in this ledger?" I asked.

"It has no purpose in a land record."

The answer was clear. I did not ask again.

On the sixth day a new copy of the map began to be made. One clerk looked at the old lines, checked the survey worker's numbers, and transferred new lines in pencil. I was called only where names were concerned. That day I saw for the first time how many things from one paper do not reach the next. Some local field-names were omitted. The old settlement remained on the notes sheet. Of two alternative spellings in the genealogical register, only one went forward.

The paper was not small. The information had been selected.

In my notebook I wrote: "A map does not write everything."

Later I added another line: "Neither does a genealogical register."

On the seventh day the account of payment was prepared. I signed. The money was to come later. As the work ended, the survey worker said to me, "You have an eye for letters. Continue your studies."

I did not say thank you. I only lowered my head.

At home I showed my small notebook to my grandfather. He did not read every page. He read three lines: "old settlement" beside the southern hamlet, the name Old Kosi, and the final note: "A map does not write everything; neither does a genealogical register."

"The name of the southern hamlet did not go onto the main map?" he asked.

"No. Because there is no settlement there now."

He was silent for a while. Then he said, "The place that no longer exists carries an even greater claim on paper to keep its name."

At the time I understood the sentence only in relation to old village-names.

That night I opened the genealogical register. I placed before me the lineage page on which the line after Shridhar had been erased. In the register, the erased place could be seen—the rubbed fibres of paper, the shadow of ink, the blank. The absence of the southern hamlet on the map was not like that. The paper there was clean. A name never written leaves no mark of erasure.

That night I did not treat these two kinds of absence as one. I merely looked at them separately.

I closed the register page.

I did not possess a copy of the map.

I had three slips, a small seven-day notebook, and the expectation of payment.

My first professional work was over.

For seven days I had read village names for the state's map.

In those seven days many things in the genealogical register did not enter the map.

And many things on the map were never going to enter the genealogical register.

CHAPTER 19
Kosi — 3

I am flowing now and beside me human beings draw lines a straight line on paper a line of pegs upon the earth a line of soil through the fields and later more earth rises over that line and it is called an embankment I do not understand the word line I understand high and low I understand slope I understand pressure I understand the smell of the earth cut from distant fields and brought to my side and beaten down firm I understand the shadow of bamboo driven beside a measuring rod I see the red cloth fluttering where it becomes a survey mark I understand the weight of the feet that walk from field to field beside the amin asking names and the name that enters paper takes one form and the name that does not enter remains in people's mouths and as mouths change the name changes with them but my water keeps no account of names I spread wherever I find room I lean toward what lies low I cut the edge where the earth is less and when before me a high wall of soil stands I do not understand it in the meaning of wall I understand only the difference between the height of my water and the weight of that earth people make plans to keep me on one side and their houses on the other but I do not read plans I read the moisture inside the soil I read the fine layers of sand I read the roots of a tree that yesterday stood in dry earth and today are half wet I read the colour of grass growing over newly filled ground I read the water gathering in a hole from which earthworms emerge and sand softens and people add another basket of earth there then another basket then sacks then stone then bamboo then order then signature then inspection and among all of these I go on flowing the line raised beside me becomes also a line of trust and a new reckoning begins within the village who is outside who is inside who lies east of the line who west whose path to the field has changed whose pond now lies beside the embankment whose hand-pump is farther away whose cattle shed has new earth heaped behind it whose wedding procession can no longer descend by the old ghat whose dead are harder to carry to the old cremation ground and none of these things fits within a straight line on paper yet they fit within the body of a village and people measure them with their feet one says this is protection another says it is confinement another says it is the work of the state another says it is a war with the river I do not understand the word war because I desire neither victory nor defeat I move only with gravity and slope but human beings place upon me words of enemy and friend and according to them turn the doors of their houses change the seed of their rice lengthen the ropes of their boats forbid their children to go behind the embankment and the children go nevertheless because from the high earth one can see far and from there my water appears like a shining strip but beneath the shine sand moves silt moves fine soil along the edge moves and the memory of the old channel moves people forget the old channel's name but the earth keeps that low place where

rain lingers and rain searches for a path toward me when a survey peg is driven the soil settles around it when the peg is pulled out a small hollow remains when water fills the hollow frogs come when frogs come a child bends to catch them and the child's footprint remains beside that hollow in this way a mark of the state becomes a mark of play and a mark of play is erased by rainwater but the line remains on paper and upon the basis of that line earth rises later I do not see paper but I see the consequence of paper in the shape of earth I do not read orders but I receive the weight of an order as a thousand baskets of soil I do not hear the language of boundaries but after the boundary is made I see the course of boats change and understand its meaning and the village that yesterday lay open beside another is today said to be on this side of the embankment or that side and people identify their place with new words inside outside above below erosion side safe side old channel new channel and among these words my water has no word of its own I flow and pressure gathers beneath the earth raised beside me and water that cannot find a path outward remains trapped within and rain falling from above searches for drainage and a small stream that once joined me is sometimes cut off by a wall of soil and in that separation a new difficulty is born for the village but on the paper of those who drew the line the line remains straight and a straight line possesses its own beauty it has a beginning it has an end its distance can be measured its cost can be written its progress can be recorded but my current has no single beginning no single end I come from melting snow I swell with rain I receive little streams I lay down sand then lift sand again I make a bank then cut the bank and those who desire to hold me in one course add earth to that desire I neither honour nor insult their earth I do not test it either I merely share with that earth as much force as my water carries at that hour and the result of this shared force is sometimes a quiet surface sometimes seeping dampness sometimes a small erosion sometimes a great breach but now the people of the village look at the new line and climb upon it and cast their eyes far away and within those eyes grows a trust that from now on the river will remain in one place and I neither break nor preserve that trust I only flow and on both sides of the line the earth goes on getting wet

The Villages Inside

Before the rains began in 1958, the embankment line appeared fixed upon the earth in many places. On some stretches earth was still being raised; on others bullock carts had begun to travel along the top; elsewhere people had already begun to use it as a road. On the map there were two lines, one on either side of the river. Of the villages outside the lines it was said that they were becoming safe. For the villages left between the lines there was no single official term.

People themselves began to call them the villages inside.

The phrase was geography, not an administrative category. Government papers had village names, police-station names, revenue circles, field numbers, slips for resettlement sites. “Inside” often did not appear on paper. But the boatmen understood it. The cattle-grazers understood it. As soon as the rains began, everyone understood it.

I was twenty-two then. Four years had passed since my seven days as Local Name Assistant. In the meantime I had continued the work of the genealogical register with my grandfather. Government maps had not become my profession. But villagers had come to think I could read government papers. That was why, one day, seven men from five villages came to our house.

My grandfather was on the veranda. I had a manuscript open.

At their head was Ramcharit Yadav. His village had fallen inside the embankments. With him were a Mahato, a Kahar, two boatmen, an elderly Brahmin, and a Musahar agricultural labourer. The seven men did not come from seven villages; they represented five.

“We need an application written,” Ramcharit said.

I closed the manuscript.

“What about?”

They looked at one another. The answer did not fit into a single sentence.

The first matter was boats. In the rainy season a channel formed between field and house. The resettlement site had been given outside the embankment; the fields remained inside. A family that built a house outside had to come inside to cultivate. A family that did not leave the old village had to go outside for the market, medicine, school, and offices.

The second matter was cattle. Once the water rose, there was no high ground for the cattle shed.

The third was grain storage. Household platforms were raised each year, but the sacks of rice did not always survive.

The fourth was a brick-and-stone road. At the words “brick-and-stone road” the boatmen did not laugh; they merely shook their heads. They knew what a permanent road inside would mean. Even so, the question of a road had to be written in the application.

The fifth matter was resettlement.

At this everyone began speaking together. I raised a hand and stopped them.

"One matter at a time. Whatever I write, I must know whose statement it is."

My grandfather looked at me and said nothing.

Ramcharit took four slips from his bag. Two were allotments for house-sites. One was a receipt for a house-building grant. One was an old revenue slip for his fields.

"House outside, field inside," he said.

I examined the slips.

"You built the house outside?"

"Half."

"Half a house?"

"Half the family."

It took me a moment to understand. Some members of the family lived at the resettlement site, some in the old village. When the rains rose everyone went outside; when the water fell, they came back inside for cultivation. The cattle were usually inside. The rice was inside. The old place of worship was inside. The school was outside. A sick person had to be taken outside.

I wrote the first line of the application:

"We, the undersigned residents of five villages, respectfully submit the difficulties concerning movement between our old settlements situated inside the embankments and the resettlement sites provided outside the embankments, and concerning boats, elevated places of refuge, and the safety of stored grain."

"Write cultivation," the Mahato said.

I added: "Because the greater part of the cultivated land remains inside."

The Musahar labourer, whose name was Budhan Sada, spoke for the first time. "Where is my field?"

His question concerned the language of the application. The cultivated land belonged to landowners; Budhan owned no field. His work lay in the fields inside, his house too was inside, and no resettlement slip stood in his name.

I stopped the line.

"What difficulty shall I write for you?"

"When the water comes, the work stops. If I go outside, they say my name is not on the list. If I stay inside, I have to pay boat fare."

Ramcharit began to say something, then fell silent.

I added another line to the application: "Arrangements shall be made for the movement of landless labouring families and for the inclusion of their names in relief lists."

The word "ensured" felt official to me. But its meaning was clear. I left it there.

By the time the application was finished it ran to two pages. All seven signed or placed thumbprints. Ramcharit said they would go to the subdivision office the next day.

"Will you go?" my grandfather asked.

"They want me to come to read the paper."

"And the register work?"

"We will do it the day after tomorrow."

He agreed. Then he looked at the application. "Everything you have written—is it their statement?"

"Yes."

"What you have not seen, do not turn into your own fact."

The rule belonged to the genealogical register. I applied it to the application as well.

The next day we reached the office. The veranda was already crowded: someone with a land dispute, someone with a certificate, someone with an irrigation drain, someone with a ration matter. A clerk read our application first. He wrote something in pencil above the heading and asked, "Have you received resettlement?"

"Some families have," Ramcharit said.

"Then why do you remain inside?"

Ramcharit placed the field slip before him.

The clerk examined it, then the application.

"This is also a matter for the irrigation department."

"The boats?"

"Local arrangement."

"Relief?"

"Revenue circle."

"Resettlement?"

"Revenue."

"The embankment?"

"Irrigation."

He spoke four words and wrote a number at the top of the application. It seemed to me that the difficulties of five villages could be divided among four offices.

"Will one application go to four places?" I asked.

The clerk looked at me.

"A file will be made."

A file was made.

My application was the first paper. Behind it went copies of the resettlement slips. A copy of the field record. A list of the five village names. One note: "Report may be called for from the concerned revenue circle." Another: "Opinion of irrigation department may be obtained regarding facilities for movement."

"When will the answer come?" Ramcharit asked.

"After the reports arrive."

That was not a date.

We returned.

The rains began.

With the first large rise of water, boats began running at two points on the routes inside. Budhan Sada spent three nights with his family on a bamboo platform. Half of Ramcharit's family was at the resettlement site; he himself remained inside to watch the transplanting of rice. The people of the five villages waited for the answer to the application.

A month later men from the revenue circle arrived. They counted houses.

The difficulty began with the question of where a "house" should be counted.

Ramcharit's name was on the resettlement list. On the day of inspection he was inside. His wife and two children were in the outside house. In the old house inside were Ramcharit, his father, and the cattle.

On paper, one family.

On the ground, two places.

Budhan's name was on the house list of the old village, not on the resettlement list. The inspector asked, "No allotment?"

"No."

"Did you submit an application?"

"My name is in this application."

He showed a copy of the paper I had written.

The inspector read the name and wrote something. I did not see his paper.

Two months later the first reply came from the office. Ramcharit brought it to our house.

Its substance was this: the house-sites available for resettlement should be used; families residing inside the embankments should exercise caution during the rains; arrangements concerning boats should be made locally; relief lists should be verified by the revenue circle; proposals for permanent construction could not be approved without separate technical examination.

I read the reply three times.

"Does it answer our questions?" Ramcharit asked.

"Some. Not others."

"The boats?"

"Local level."

"Who is the local level?"

The paper gave no name.

"High refuge?"

"Technical examination."

"Who will examine it?"

The paper gave no name.

"Budhan's list?"

"The revenue circle will verify it."

"When?"

There was no date.

Beneath the reply, in my small notebook, I wrote only four lines:

Application:	five	villages.
Reply:	four	subjects.

Boats:	local.
Refuge:	examination.
Relief:	verification.
Time: not written.	

The next week a delegation formed again. This time there were eleven people, not seven. One was a woman—Sita Devi. Her husband worked away from home. The resettlement slip was in his name. In the house inside lived Sita Devi, her mother-in-law, three children, and two cows.

“The paper says live outside,” she said. “The field is inside. The cows are inside. He is in Calcutta. Where am I to live?”

I did not copy that sentence verbatim into the application. In office language I wrote: “Because the family’s livelihood and residence have been divided between two places, movement by women, the elderly, and children is difficult.”

Sita Devi could not read. I read the line aloud to her.

“Did you write the cows?”

I added: “Lack of a safe place for livestock.”

The second application was shorter than the first. I wrote the number of the previous file at the top. At the office the clerk searched for the old file. At first he could not find it. Half an hour later it was found in another cupboard.

My first application was inside. Three new papers had been added above it: a report from the revenue circle, a note from the irrigation office, and an internal letter.

I did not ask to read the whole file. I saw only what was opened before me.

The revenue-circle report said that some families, even after accepting resettlement sites, continued to live partly in the old settlements because of cultivation.

The sentence stood close to the fact.

The irrigation-office note said that because of the river’s flow and shifting channels inside the embankments, the feasibility of permanent roads was limited.

That too stood close to the fact.

But two sentences close to fact did not combine into a solution.

The second application was added to the file. Another note followed: “Necessary local arrangement in light of previous report.”

“Local arrangement again?” Ramcharit asked me.

“Yes.”

“Who is local?” Sita Devi asked.

I gave no answer.

That year the water rose high twice. The first time people climbed onto raised platforms. The second time some families moved toward the resettlement sites. When the water fell they returned inside for cultivation. The roof tiles of some households remained outside, their bamboo inside. Some families had ration slips for the outside site and grain in the inside house. Some children stayed outside during school months and inside between transplanting and harvest.

The government file remained in one place.

The village began to live in two.

At the beginning of winter there was no third delegation. Only Ramcharit and Budhan came. There was debt on the boats. The boatmen said they could not ferry without fares. People said a government arrangement would come. The official reply said “local arrangement.”

“Shall we write another application?” Ramcharit asked.

I took out copies of the previous two.

Five requests in the first.
Three in the second.

What was I to write in the third?

“This time write that we are here,” Budhan said.

I looked at him.

He said again, “Whatever the paper says, we are here.”

I straightened the sheet.

The first line of the third application was:

“In continuation of our previous applications, we respectfully submit that families continue to reside in the villages situated inside the embankments, and that because of livelihood, cultivation, livestock, and old homes, it is not proving possible even during the rains to remain wholly separated from these places.”

“Leave it like that,” Ramcharit said.

Budhan listened to the line. After a while he asked, “Will my name remain?”

At the end of the application I wrote the representatives’ names. Budhan Sada—thumb impression.

The third application went.

The reply came in Phagun.

This time the paper was short. It referred to the previous letter. It referred to the revenue-circle report. It mentioned that resettlement facilities had been made available. It said the local administration had been alerted to provide necessary assistance during the rains.

No permanent boat arrangement.
No approval for elevated refuge.
No separate list of landless families.
No place for livestock.

The last line said that the concerned officers had already been informed for necessary action in the matter.

Ramcharit folded the paper.

“Now?”

“There is no date in this letter by which another answer is to be given.”

“File closed?”

“I do not know.”

A few months later I went to the office and, finding an opportunity, asked about the file number. The clerk checked an old register. He found the number.

“The letter has been issued,” he said. “Consider the work finished now.”

I said nothing.

On the way home I climbed the embankment and looked inward. In the distance lay the direction of the five villages. Between them, the shining old channel, sand, fields, bamboo thickets, a few roofs. Outside, the new row of resettlement houses. Between the two, the high line of earth.

The office file had gone out.

The village remained inside.

Two Mithilas

During the years when the barrage was being built, the road toward Bhimnagar ceased to be merely the old road from village to village. Heaps of earth, iron rods, trucks of stone chips, engineers' jeeps, guard posts, gates, and inspections of papers all increased together. People did not stop moving, but the question of what was moving with whom grew larger.

That year, in Aghan, the marriage of Shyamanand Jha of our village was settled in a village of Saptari. I knew the bride's grandfather's family. In the genealogical register, the lineage-origin, village, standing, and marriage eligibility of both sides had already been matched. By the reckoning of the register, there was no difficulty.

On the morning the wedding party left, I carried the marriage genealogical paper, two copies, a cloth pouch, and my small box. Shyamanand's uncle told me that questions about papers might arise near the border, so I should keep the genealogical document with me. Until then I had thought the questions would concern names and kinship.

The wedding party consisted of two bullock carts, one motorcar, seven bicycles, and people on foot. There were four musicians: a harmonium, two dholaks, a pair of cymbals, and a kettledrum. Three trunks were loaded in the rear of the groom's car. The first held the groom's clothes. The second, clothes for the bride's household. The third, brass utensils.

The rest of the goods ran as follows: twelve dhotis, six kurtas, sixteen saris, eight shawls, twenty gamchas, six brass plates, six lotas, twelve bowls, five seers of betel nut, eight seers of makhana, four seers of batasha, two seers of crystallized sugar, two tins of oil, four bottles of perfume, six boxes of sindoor, twelve coconuts, betel leaves in a separate basket, one radio, one sewing machine.

Many of these things had come from different households. Some had been bought. Some were old. Some were for the bride's mother, some for her sister, some for the priest, some for use in the wedding rites. There was no single bill.

Near Bhimnagar we first saw the labour camp. Then the construction gate. There were project guards there. Beyond it was the border-check point. People were crossing on foot. Bicycles too were going through. Our motorcar was stopped. So were the bullock carts.

"Where to?" the guard asked.

"To a wedding," Shyamanand's uncle said.

"Which country?"

The uncle was silent for a moment. "Our in-laws' place is in Saptari."

The guard asked again, "Indian or Nepali?"

"We are from India. The in-laws are in Nepal."

The road was open to people. For goods the questions were different. An officer told us to open the trunks. The first was opened. Clothes came out. Their number was asked. The second: saris, shawls, gamchas. The third: utensils. The radio was taken out separately. The sewing machine was on the bullock cart.

"These are not goods for trade?" the officer asked.

"They are wedding gifts," the uncle said.

"Proof?"

The uncle looked at me.

I took out the genealogical marriage paper. It contained the groom's name, his father's name, lineage-origin, village, the bride's lineage, and approval of the marriage. The officer read it, then said, "This is a paper for the marriage. Not for the goods."

"The goods are for the marriage," I said.

"Then make a list. Write the quantity and estimated value."

"How do we write the value of all this?" the uncle said. "Half of it has come from people's homes."

"Anything that crosses the border requires particulars."

Right there I took a sheet and began making a list. In the genealogical register I wrote the order of names. Here I wrote the order of objects. Twelve dhotis. Six kurtas. Sixteen saris. Eight shawls. Twenty gamchas. Six plates. Six lotas. Twelve bowls. Five seers of betel nut. Eight seers of makhana.

The difficulty came at the value. What was the value of an old brass plate? The value of a shawl already in the house? Where was the paper for a sari given by a maternal uncle? The radio had been bought, but its receipt was at home. The sewing-machine receipt bore the name of Shyamanand's sister, not the bride; the decision to give the machine to the bride's mother had been made later.

The officer said the people could cross. The goods could not go without particulars.

The wedding party split in two. Some said take the groom and go ahead. Others said how could a wedding party go without music and gifts. The musicians asked whether the harmonium too would be counted as goods, or regarded as their own instrument.

Again, a paper had to be consulted for the answer.

Time passed. Two people from the bride's house arrived by bicycle. One was the bride's maternal uncle. He recognized me. His first question was not about the auspicious hour.

"What is stuck in the papers?"

I showed him the list.

"People can cross the border," he said, "but the wedding trunks are stopped at it."

The officer asked him too, "Are you a citizen of Nepal?"

"Yes."

"These goods are going to your house?"

"My sister's daughter is being married."

“Then write the name of the recipient.”

The bride’s uncle’s name was added to the list. His father, village, and district were written as well. In the genealogical register I knew the same man in another form. There his lineage-origin and descent mattered. On this paper his citizenship, place, and identity as recipient mattered.

I placed the two papers beside each other. The genealogical marriage paper did not contain the word border. The border declaration did not contain the word lineage-origin.

Meanwhile the driver of the groom’s car said the project gate might close at a fixed time in the evening. The bullock carts would move slowly. There was still more road to the bride’s house.

Shyamanand’s uncle decided that the groom and the necessary people would cross on foot. The wedding rite would not be delayed. The trunks and bullock carts would remain if the papers could not be made.

Shyamanand got out of the car. He wore a paag on his head and a shawl over his shoulder. For a stretch he carried his shoes in his hand because of the mud. With him went his father, his uncle, the priest, myself, five wedding guests, and two musicians. The harmonium was stopped, so the musicians took only a small pair of cymbals and one dholak; the guard said the dholak could be carried by hand.

Everyone else remained near the gate. So did the trunks.

No mantra was recited while we crossed the border. No genealogical register was consulted. We were asked our names. Our villages. Whom we were going to see. I did not need to show the marriage paper.

On the Nepal side the bride’s uncle was already waiting. He walked beside the groom, pushing his bicycle. About two kos farther on, more people from the bride’s house met us. The wedding welcome began there.

At the bride’s house the first question was: where are the rest of the wedding guests?

“The accounting for the goods is being made at the border,” Shyamanand’s father said.

The bride’s father was silent for a while. Then he said, “The people have arrived. That is the larger thing.”

But the household arrangements had been made for both people and things. Some of the sixteen saris were for ritual use. Two of the brass plates were needed for the priest and the bride and groom. Some of the betel nut, makhana, batasha, and coconuts were meant to travel with the wedding party. All were at the border.

The bride’s household opened its own stores. Plates came from neighbouring houses. Betel leaf and betel nut were gathered. A shawl came. The rites did not stop. Other objects took the place of those left at the border.

Late at night the first bullock cart arrived. Shyamanand’s uncle was with it. A signed list, the recipient’s name, and a written declaration that the articles were

for personal wedding use had been given. The radio and sewing machine were detained until the next day. Weariness showed on the uncle's face.

He handed me the paper. "Keep it."

I read it. Place-name at the top. Date. List of goods. Name of sender. Name of recipient. Purpose—wedding. At the end it said that the articles were not for sale.

In that one line, the relationship of in-laws had been distinguished from trade.

The wedding took place at night. The necessary part of the genealogical document was read. The groom's lineage, the bride's lineage, lineage-origins, villages, prohibitions of relationship, standing—all as before. Within the rite, the words India and Nepal were not spoken once.

At dawn I made the marriage entry. Groom—Shyamanand Jha. Father—. Village—. Lineage-origin—. Bride—. Father—. Village—in Saptari. Date—. Witnesses—.

There was no box for country.

That afternoon people went back toward the border regarding the radio and sewing machine. I did not go. I had to complete the marriage record.

The next day, when the bride departed, new goods gathered for the reverse direction. The bride's household gave two blankets, one brass water vessel, two bamboo baskets, one sack of paddy, four jars of homemade pickle, two bundles of cloth, and one wooden chest to travel with the groom. All of these would go toward India.

The bride's uncle attempted a laugh. "Yesterday it was your list. Today mine."

No one answered.

After the farewell, at the border the same questions came again: whose object, for whom, where made, how many. The origin of the homemade pickle was easy to state. The bride's mother said the blankets had been bought at the local market. The chest had been made by the village carpenter. No one was certain about the brass vessel.

The bride herself could walk forward. Her chest could be stopped. No one argued about the distinction. Everyone was tired.

I made another list. Yesterday, India to Nepal; today, Nepal to India. Yesterday the recipient was the bride's father; today, the groom's father. The relationship remained the same. The direction changed.

The bride's name appeared nowhere on either list, although the wedding was hers. On the first list the goods were "for wedding purposes." On the second they were "farewell articles."

I opened the genealogical marriage paper. There the bride's name appeared. Her father, village, lineage-origin, marriage relationship. There was no place there for blankets, brass vessels, radio, or sewing machine.

The border list held objects. The genealogical register held people. Together they wrote separate parts of the same wedding.

A few months later Shyamanand's uncle told me that now, whenever he went to the in-laws in Nepal, he counted beforehand what was inside his trunk. He did not laugh. He merely spoke the number.

I read the line of that marriage in my register again. After the village-name there was no border.

But from that day at the Bhimnagar gate I understood that kinship may cross, people may cross, yet when the objects travelling with people descend onto paper, kinship acquires another identity.

In the genealogical register I asked: whose lineage?

At the border the questions were: which country, whose object, for whom?

Both questions were written. Both were true within their own papers.

Neither paper understood the other.

Marriage

The matter of my marriage was first raised at home when I was twenty-four. My work with the genealogical register had become regular. Villagers who saw me sitting beside my grandfather would open their lineage papers before me, but in the matter of my own marriage I was a client. No manuscript kept an account of that difference.

My grandfather was explicit on the first day. “You will not examine your own line.” His rule was that whenever a panjikar himself was a party, another panjikar with authority would carry out the matching. I could open the books of our own house, but I would not make the final comparison of the bride’s line and the prohibited relationships.

The bride’s name was Sharda. Her father was Dayanath Jha. Village: Basbitti. That was all in the first letter. The second added her father’s and grandfather’s names, lineage-origin, gotra, and two lines concerning the maternal side. The third paper was not a marriage proposal but answers to questions required for verification.

I kept all three in a separate cloth wrapping, as we kept other marriage papers in the house. My grandfather asked, “How many times have you read the girl’s name?”

“Three.”

“Reading a name and marrying are two different acts.”

For the examination, Harishankar Babu, the panjikar of a neighbouring jurisdiction, came. He had known me since childhood. That day he seated me not as an acquaintance but as a party to the matter. First he read my paternal line. Father: Janardan Mishra. Grandfather: Shivnarayan Mishra. Great-grandfather: Harinarayan Mishra. Then he asked about my maternal side. I answered. He checked those answers against his own papers.

At the name Harinarayan I looked once toward my grandfather. He said nothing. At that time I knew nothing of Phuljhari’s erased line. To me Harinarayan was merely the name of an old panjikar whose handwriting I had seen in the books at home.

The bride’s line arrived the next day. Sharda. Father Dayanath. Grandfather Vinodanand. Gotra Bharadwaj. Lineage-origin Bhelahi. Village Basbitti. Maternal village and lineage-origin in a separate line. Harishankar Babu opened two old marriage entries to check prohibitions arising from close kinship. The ink on one page was faint; he read it under slanting light.

No prohibition was found.

“Now the people of the households will discuss the marriage,” my grandfather said.

The book was closed. Only then were things said about Sharda that were not in the genealogical register: she could read, she knew sewing, she did not speak much, and she did not like milk. Why the last fact was mentioned I do not know. The women of the house discussed it for some time.

The wedding was fixed for Phagun. The priest gave a slip with the date; I kept one copy in my diary. A separate account book was opened for household expenses. Rice, lentils, ghee, salt, oil, betel nut, betel leaf, makhana, cloth, bamboo, leaf-plates, fuel, bullock carts, musicians—beside each was written a quantity or amount due. For me the preparation for marriage became first of all a list.

Three days before the wedding my grandfather said that I would not write the genealogical entry for my own marriage. Harishankar Babu would write it; I would only read it. The rule seemed right to me. For a day in which a person is himself a party, the record should be made by another hand.

That day Harishankar Babu also looked at the entry of my birth in our family register. Year of birth: 1936. My father's name after mine. Then my grandfather's. Below that line there were several blank spaces.

"After the marriage," he said, "this blank will no longer be blank."

I looked at the line. For years I had filled the blanks of other people. For the first time, the blank in my own line looked different.

A small siddhanta paper came from the bride's side. The paper was not thick. A red-ink mark at the top, black ink below. Two witness names. One line concerning maternal kinship. Harishankar Babu used it to compare three old marriages. One was nearly forty years old. The edge of that page was split, but the name remained legible. The conclusion of the examination was unchanged: no close prohibition.

Meanwhile another kind of work continued in the house. Paddy was pounded at one end of the veranda. Spices were ground. Bamboo was split. A new earthen hearth was made. Leaf-plates were counted. Five cots brought from outside were set apart. Blankets, pillowcases, and lotas for the wedding guests were counted. None of these had a place in the genealogical register, yet the wedding could not be completed without them.

I opened the expense ledger and wrote objects instead of names: rice, lentils, ghee, oil, salt, betel nut, betel leaf, makhana. My grandfather looked at the ledger once and asked, "Where is your lineage-origin here?"

"Here there is price."

He handed the ledger back. A wedding had two accounts—one of lineage, one of expense. Both concerned the same event, yet the two barely recognized one another.

When the wedding party left, I carried no genealogical manuscript. The necessary copies were in Harishankar Babu's bag. In my hand I had only a small cloth purse, a towel, and betel nut given from home. On the road people sang. I was not writing down the words of the songs.

At the bride's house the doorway rites took place. The crowd, lotas of water, aripan designs, two lamps, betel leaves, a plate of makhana, the priest's seat, a place for the groom to change clothes—I remember the order of these things. I did not look at anyone's face for long. I did what I was told to do.

I saw Sharda clearly for the first time that night near the wedding pavilion. There was a mark of rice paste on her forehead. Her eyes were lowered. Two women sat beside her. Once, when a vessel of water was extended, she moved it with her right hand. I saw no more than that at the time.

Mantras were recited. The fire was kept. Members of the families sat in order. My grandfather's place was beside Harishankar Babu. After the rites were completed, the two of them compared the papers. It was toward the final watch of the night. Then Harishankar Babu sat at a low table and wrote the marriage record.

I reproduce that entry here as it stands. It is the record of my own marriage; for that reason it would not be proper to add or subtract words.

Marriage Register — Household Copy

Time — Year 1960, month of Phagun.

Groom — Ramanugrah Mishra.

Father — Janardan Mishra.

Grandfather — Shivnarayan Mishra.

Great-grandfather — Harinarayan Mishra, panjikaar.

Gotra — Kashyap.

Lineage-origin — Kakraul.

Village — Kariyapatti.

Standing — certified according to household genealogical register.

Bride — Sharda Jha.

Father — Dayanath Jha.

Grandfather — Vinodanand Jha.

Gotra — Bharadwaj.

Lineage-origin — Bhelahi.

Village — Basbitti.

Maternal relationship — examined according to separate verification paper.

Prohibition of close relationship — none found.

Marriage-standing — accepted on both sides.

Rite — completed in the presence of family and priest.

Witnesses — Shivnarayan Mishra; Dayanath Jha; Harishankar, panjikaar; senior members of both families present.

Writer — Harishankar, authorized panjikaar.

Subsequent entry — to be added upon birth of first child or other change in lineage.

Harishankar Babu set down his pen after writing the final line. I read the whole entry once. My name was at the top; Sharda's in the middle. Between the two names stood father, grandfather, gotra, lineage-origin, village, prohibition, standing. On paper, marriage was an order of so many things.

My grandfather asked, "Any doubt?"

"No."

He placed his witness mark on Harishankar Babu's entry. Dayanath Jha signed too. The paper was not folded; it was left flat until the ink dried.

Before dawn the women of the house took Sharda inside. I was sent to a separate room. There was a cot, a mattress, two pillows, a brass lota, a glass, and a mustard-oil lamp. For a while women's voices remained outside the door. Later they went away.

At night I entered the room.

Sharda was sitting at one end of the cot.

I asked if she wanted water. She said, "No."

The lamp went out; after that we both remained silent.

The Famine of 1966

I remember the year 1966 first not by its rainfall but by the household ledger. One could understand that the rains had failed simply by looking at the fields, but at home the first sign of famine was not the clouds; it was the shopping list. Things that had been bought together at the first market of Ashadh came, by Sawan, in half quantities. By Bhadon, some names had disappeared from the list altogether.

At the time I was doing the work of the genealogical register and also keeping the household expense book. Two pages of that ledger are still with me. On one are written rice, lentils, salt, oil, jaggery, spices, soap, cloth, kerosene. On the other, the quantities beside the same names have diminished. Beside some names there is a zero. Zero did not mean that the thing had vanished from the world; it meant only that our house had not bought it that month.

Ghee stopped first. Little ghee came into the house even before then, but that year, except for weddings and ceremonies, regular buying ceased. Then the quantity of arhar dal was reduced. Mustard oil was measured out carefully. Half as much oil went into vegetables as before. Jaggery was kept only for tea or guests. The betel-nut box went unopened for a month. The old people of the house bought betel leaves with their own money.

Salt could not be stopped. For that reason I watched the price of salt more closely than anything else. In the market, the shopkeeper wrote prices in chalk on a wooden board. Earlier the line for salt would not change from month to month; that year it was repeatedly wiped clean and a new figure written. In my ledger, beside salt, one month's price is written; the next month that figure is struck out and another written in its place. After that I stopped writing the figure and wrote only, "one seer." If salt ran short, the meal did not cease, but the taste of every dish changed at once.

The reductions were not the same in every household of the village. Those who had paddy left had less need of the market. Fields lying low inside the embankment yielded something even with scant rain. In fields on higher land, cracks opened after transplantation. Our area was not the worst afflicted part of the state. News from districts to the south and west was harsher. But market prices did not observe district boundaries. The news of grain scarcity might be distant; its effect in the market was close at hand.

Coarsely ground maize began to be cooked more often in place of rice. Barley and madua, once dismissed as food for poor households, regained respect in the market. Sattu was stirred into water with salt. The evening rice was cooked in a smaller pot. Water was poured over the rice left from midday and it was eaten the next day with salt and greens. Milk was kept for children and old people; the young began drinking tea without milk.

The women of the house made no announcement of these changes. They simply altered quantities. The large brass vessels were put away above the grain store. The small cooking pot remained below. Water in which rice had been washed, once thrown away, was now used to wet the cattle bran. The grinding stone for spices was used every other day. No rule was written down, but a new arithmetic was at work in the kitchen.

Talk of government grain increased in the market. Queues formed at the fair-price shop. Name, number of family members, ration card, quantity—everything was written down. On paper the rates for rice and wheat were lower than in the ordinary market, but distribution was not always even. Sometimes wheat arrived and rice did not. Sometimes the quantity was cut. People sat for an hour holding their ration cards, only to be told that the grain had not yet arrived. The next day the same ration card was again in their hands.

One day I helped prepare a distribution list. This time the names in the genealogical register were of no use. The list did not count fathers and grandfathers; it counted mouths in a family. Five mouths, seven mouths, three mouths. A widow came with her two children. The clerk first looked for the name of her husband's village and did not find it. She gave the name of her natal village. The clerk opened another page. Inside the paper, the family changed places again. That day I understood once more that the living relations of a family and the boxes on a form are not the same thing.

The debt ledger grew thicker. At the shopkeeper's, the money due beside each name increased while the quantities bought decreased. People asked for half a seer instead of a seer. Those who had once paid cash said they would pay when the crop came home. The shopkeeper wrote the date. Beside some names he made a mark in red ink. I did not ask what the red mark meant. Its meaning was evident.

The buying of cloth almost ceased. When a child's old kurta became too small, its sleeves were cut off. The sound cloth in the middle of a torn dhoti was cut out and made into a gamchha. When a woman's sari tore, the border was turned and stitched. Old footwear, once split, was patched and sewn and made to last. The old sequence in which new things were bought for a new generation became, for one year, a sequence of putting old things to use again.

Kerosene was conserved. The lamp was lit later in the evening. I tried to finish the work of reading the genealogical register in daylight. If a client arrived after dusk, we lit one wick, not two. Shadows fell across the pages of the books. Handwriting was harder to read in such light, so I would ask the client to return the next day. I had never thought that a shortage of food could also diminish the light by which the letters of a genealogical book were read.

The behaviour of the village children changed. They watched what was in the bags of people returning from the market. If they saw jaggery, they asked. If they saw roasted gram, they drew near. What had once been thought shameful became, that year, a question: "Is there anything to eat?" The elders did not scold them for asking. They answered, or they remained silent.

By Kartik, fodder too had become something to be counted. There was less paddy straw than expected. Chaff ran short in the cattle trough. Less oilcake was bought. People in the house first reduced the grain on their own plates and then looked to the cattle's share. The bullock was an instrument of the field; to let it weaken was to weaken the next harvest. Thus the grain of the household and the fodder of the animals were no longer two separate stores, but two lines in the same account of expenditure.

By Kartik, lists for relief work had reached the village. Cutting earth, raising a short stretch of road, clearing silt from the edge of a pond—such work was entered by name. Those who could find no work in the fields put their names down. Wages were discussed as much as food. For how many days would work be available, how many days' pay would be given at once, had one's name been entered on the right page—meetings turned on these questions.

Festivals too appeared in altered form in the expense book. The line for new clothes was struck out. Oil was set aside for lamps, but fewer lamps were lit. A guest's plate, which once held five things, held three. No one announced these changes as poverty. The people of the house said, "This much will do this time. Next time we shall see."

Cuts reached a child's plate last. First the old reduced their portions, then the young. There was no written rule for this order. But if there was one bowl of milk, Mohan's share was taken out first. He was four years old then. Sharda would set aside his bowl, and only afterward was tea made for the others.

News from across the state came over the radio. Crops had failed badly in many districts of Bihar; relief works were being expanded; grain was to be brought from outside. In our village people did not speak in statistics. They said: so-and-so's field did not fill; so-and-so sold his bullock; no one in that household has bought dal for two months. The government counted the crisis in numbers; the village counted it in the absence of things.

One day Mohan, four years old then, knocked the salt box from his hand. The lid came off and the salt scattered over the earthen floor. Sharda did not fetch the broom at once. First she gathered by hand the salt from the top that had not touched the dirt and put it in a brass bowl. Only then did she sweep. At another time salt that had touched the floor would have been thrown away. That day five minutes were spent separating earth from salt.

I did not write this incident in the ledger. The expense book said only, "salt — one seer." Yet the truest record of the famine may have been those five minutes. The value of a thing changes not only when its price rises, but also when one's right to throw it away diminishes. I am not recording sentiment here. The fact is only this: that day the salt that fell on the ground was gathered up, not discarded.

When Aghan came, some paddy reached the house from the fields, but the earlier scarcity was not filled at once. Debts had to be paid. Seed had to be saved. There was the worry of the next transplantation. The household vessels did not become large again. Some rules of reduction remained even after the year

changed: measuring out oil, not throwing away leftover rice, not replacing cloth at once, opening the grain store in the middle of the month to check the quantity. These habits continued into later years.

In the genealogical register, the year 1966 bears no special mark. Marriages took place, children were born, people died; the entries that were expected were made. Famine did not break the line of descent. For that reason the genealogical register scarcely sees it. The expense book sees it. The ration card sees it. The shopkeeper's credit ledger sees it. The small cooking pot sees it. The salt box sees it.

For me, the memory of 1966 survives in four things: ghee was not bought; the rice pot became smaller; the figure for the price of salt was struck out and another written in its place; and salt that fell on the ground was not thrown away.

Engineer Babu

On the day Mohan was born in 1962, two kinds of paper came into our house. The first was a small slip carried by the man sent for the midwife, listing medicines, cotton wool, oil, hot water and clean cloth. The second was a printed notice from the Water Resources office, inviting tenders for protection and repair work on a stretch of embankment. Both papers lay on my table on the same day. One was preparation for saving a body. The other, for saving a raised line of earth.

Sharda's time was near. For the previous three days a room in the house had been cleared. The old bedding had been dried in the sun. The brass lota had been scoured. A large pot had been set aside for hot water. Word had been sent to the midwife. My mother was no longer alive; the elder women of the household oversaw the arrangements. I was of little use in such matters. I did whatever I was told—bring firewood, fill water, fetch cotton wool from the market, read the medicine slip.

That morning a messenger from the office came. I knew him. From time to time people from his household came to me on business concerning the genealogical register. He asked me to read out a paper from the Irrigation Department; he had difficulty understanding its English heading. I took the paper. At the top was the department's name. Below were columns for the embankment kilometre, duration of work, earth, bamboo, boulders, latticework, labourers, carriage and estimated cost. At the end was the date by which the tender had to be submitted.

I read the heading and the main particulars aloud to him. He asked, "Will this be a big job?"

I said, "The paper is large. How large the work is will be understood after the site is seen."

He did not laugh. He folded the paper, put it into his bag and left.

After the embankment had been built, I saw that building it was not a one-time task. As soon as the rains came, grass would be torn from the slope; water would seep somewhere, rat holes appear somewhere, the current eat into an edge somewhere, sacks be laid somewhere. The word I had heard during construction—"finished"—did not remain stable in practice. The body of earth had to be watched year after year. The work acquired new names—protection, strengthening, erosion control, refilling, repair.

I had no special knowledge of these matters. I was not an engineer. But because of my old work of reading names, some people in the department knew me. At times they would ask about the name of a village, an old field boundary, or the identification of a hamlet. For that reason their papers kept coming before my eyes. I watched the line of earth built beside the river create an archival world

of its own. In the genealogical register there were fathers and grandfathers; in the department's books there were kilometres, spurs, slopes, cubic feet of earth and expenditure.

By noon Sharda's pains had grown stronger. The midwife arrived. The men of the household were kept outside the veranda. I sat on the other side of the courtyard. I had nothing to do, so in my mind I kept repeating the words from the departmental notice that had come earlier. Kilometre. Repair. Protection. Time limit. Security deposit. Labourers.

From time to time women's voices came from inside. Sometimes water was asked for. Sometimes cloth. Sometimes the silence lasted so long that I would rise, look towards the doorway, then sit down again. My grandfather was still alive then. Once he said to me, "Staring at the door will not make time pass faster." I said nothing.

In the afternoon two departmental employees came to the village on bicycles. They needed to ask the names of old paths beside the embankment. Seeing the state of the house, they did not come in. From outside the veranda, one of them unfolded a paper. There were three names—the old channel, the bend with the bamboo thicket, and a small settlement that appeared under a different name on the government map. I told them the names people actually used. He marked corrections on the paper in red pencil.

The other employee said, "The repair work is large this time. It has to be done before the rains."

I asked, "Up to where?"

He gave the kilometre. I placed the location in my mind. Beside that stretch, during the previous year's rains, the water had risen as far as the slope. People from the village had filled sacks and laid them there. Departmental people had come later. This time the work would be done before the rains—the paper said no more than that.

They left. The small red-pencil mark stayed in my mind. A name on a government map could be changed. A slope of earth could also be filled again. An erased line in a genealogical register was not so easily written back. But that day I was in no condition to think much about old lines.

By evening a baby's cry came from inside. The sound was small at first, then louder the second time. The men sitting on the veranda looked at one another. Grandfather stood up. No one called me inside. After a while the eldest woman came out and said, "It is a son."

I first asked after Sharda. The answer came—she is well. Then I asked about the child. The answer—he is well.

He was not named that day. The time of birth was written down. The midwife said it was a little before sunset. Grandfather looked at his watch. I had no watch. Time took two forms—the midwife's estimate and Grandfather's watch. Later, the time from the watch was entered in the genealogical register.

That night I wrote only the date in the small diary. Beneath it—"birth of a son." I left the place for the name blank. Sharda was exhausted. The child lay

beside her, wrapped in cloth. I looked from a distance. A thin layer of black hair lay on his head. His eyes were closed. The thumb of his right hand was folded inward. Those were the only facts I could see that were fit to be written down.

The next day the name was discussed. Many names were proposed in the family. Grandfather favoured opening the old list of names. Sharda said the name should be short. In the end there was agreement on “Mohan.” The genealogical register recorded: Mohan Mishra. Father: Ramanugrah Mishra. Mother: Sharda. Born: 1962. Village: Kariyapatti.

Below that entry Grandfather told me to write: “Date of birth cross-checked against the family’s oral testimony and the household diary.” I wrote it. Grandfather read it. He changed nothing.

Three days later the departmental notice came up in conversation again. This time, at the market, the clerks of two contractors were talking to one another. Who had how many bullock carts, who had the means to bring boulders, where labourers could be found, how much the security deposit was, when payment would be made—these were the things they discussed. The embankment was no longer only earth; around it was gathering a new world of wages, carriage, supplies, measurement books and payments.

I had gone to the market to buy salt and oil. I had no reason to listen to the clerks’ conversation. But the words “measurement book” caught in my ear. For a panjikar, measurement meant something else—the distance between generations, prohibitions of relationship, branches of a lineage-origin. For the department, measurement meant feet, cubic feet, kilometres and slopes. In both kinds of work, without a written record neither payment nor marriage was approved. But an error in the two kinds of record had different consequences.

A few weeks later the work order was issued. This was not the first repair work in the state, nor in the Kosi project as a whole; but in the division familiar to me, I had never before seen protection work on so large a scale. For that reason people in the village called it the “big contract.” The paper used no such phrase. Instead it gave the work in full detail—refilling the slope from such-and-such kilometre to such-and-such kilometre, boulders at selected places, bamboo latticework, compacting earth, labour-days, inspection and measurement.

One day an office employee showed me a copy of the work order. Again he wanted to ask the spelling of an old settlement name. I gave him the name. At the bottom of the paper was the contractor’s name. Above it, the engineer’s signature. The date was eighteen days after the date of Mohan’s birth.

I did not take that coincidence as a sign. There was no causal relation between the birth of a child and the work order for repair. One was an event in a household, the other in a department. Only the time was shared. In my diary the two dates fell on two sides of the same page.

In the months after Mohan’s birth, Sharda woke again and again in the night. The child’s crying, milk, cloth, fear of fever, oil massage—the household’s time was divided into small intervals. The work on the embankment too was divided into small measurements. Earth had slipped somewhere, been filled

somewhere; sacks somewhere, bamboo somewhere, boulders somewhere. On inspection days measurements were taken. Work that did not enter the measurement did not enter the payment.

One day Sharda said, "This child keeps me awake all night."

I said, "He sleeps during the day."

Sharda said, "You do not need to write that down."

I closed the diary.

When Mohan was two months old, the first subsequent note was added beneath his birth entry—naming ceremony completed. Nothing more. How much he cried, in whose lap he grew quiet, how long he slept after drinking milk—the genealogical register had no authority over any of that. Its limits were clear to me.

The departmental book had its limits too. The measurement book said how much earth had been filled, how many boulders had been laid, how much labour had accrued. It did not say past whose field the bullock carts had gone to fetch earth, whose courtyard had filled with dust, who received wages on time and who received them two weeks later. If such things were written, they were written in a separate complaint. The main book measured the work, not life.

When the first high water of the rains came, some people from the village went to look at the embankment. I did not go. Mohan had a fever at home. Later I heard that the repaired stretch was holding. At one place the new earth on the slope had washed away, and sacks were laid there again. Departmental employees called it routine maintenance. People in the village said, "The embankment is holding." Both statements were true in their own way.

Grandfather rarely took Mohan in his lap. His hands trembled. But one day he carried him into the room of the genealogical registers. The child was not yet at an age to see anything. Looking towards the cupboard of books, Grandfather said, "Your name has entered these now."

I said, "He does not understand."

Grandfather said, "A genealogical register is not kept so that one may understand it now. It is kept so that one may be identified later."

I wrote that sentence in the diary.

No one knew that day that, long afterwards, Mohan himself would become an engineer. At the time he was only a child whose line of name had been written in fresh ink. The embankment too was not yet, in my eyes, a great question of an engineering institution, but a long rise of earth that had to be looked at again and again before the rains.

Even today, on that page from 1962, I see two entries together. Above—the birth of Mohan. Below—the date of the work order for protection and repair of a stretch of embankment.

At the time I did not call both of them births.

Now I understand that in that year a child was born in the house, and beside the river a new professional world also began to take shape—a world of

measurement, work orders, contracts, inspection, payment and repair—within which, long afterwards, Mohan would choose the work of his life.

Silence

Before the light of dawn reaches all the way inside, the earth floor of the room is cold. The cold feels stronger along the right side of her body, where the edge of the mat pressed against her through the night. When she raises her arm, a fine chequered imprint shows on the skin. A pass of the palm blurs it. At the roots of her hair, the night's sweat has dried, leaving a salty grittiness. The smell of oil still clings behind her ear. Outside, the darkness has not wholly lifted; inside, the light is the colour of hearth-ash.

As her feet touch the floor, the first sensation is not dust but fine grains of sand. Since the earthquake, particles have fallen all night from the slanting crack in the wall and gathered in a corner of the room. When she touches the wall with a finger, she feels not lime but the roughness of raw earth. At one place the edge of the crack is so sharp that grit works its way beneath her nail. She rubs the nail clean against her sari. She does not like that grittiness.

The first dip into the courtyard water cools the heat of her palm. The brass lota is cold. As she pours water up to her wrist, the fine hairs on her skin rise. While she washes her face, tiny particles of ash sting the corner of her eye. Even after she rinses it twice, the stinging remains. She does not rub the eye hard; she touches it slowly with the corner of her wet anchal. The water has a faint taste of earth. For a few days after an earthquake, well water tastes like this.

She cannot bear the smoke from the hearth. Half-wet wood smoulders inside the clay stove, and the smoke rises to her eyes. She turns her face away. Her eyes fill with water; a sharpness settles inside her nose. When the water in which the rice was washed is poured into the cooking pot, moist steam rises above the smoke. The sound of the boiling water is monotonous. The lid trembles. She places a small clod of earth at its edge so that the noise will lessen.

The smell of cooked rice reaches her awareness before hunger does. There is no dal with the rice today, only salt and chilli and a small slice of green mango. She likes green mango. The sourness draws in both sides of her tongue at once. An old pain in one tooth wakes at the sour taste, but she does not give up the slice of mango. A grain of salt clings to the tip of her finger. She places it on her tongue; then she bites into the mango.

The sari is of coarse cotton. When its wet edge clings to her calf, the roughness of the cloth is more palpable. Below the left knee is the line of an old scratch. When the sari rubs against it, a faint itch rises. She does not use her nails; she presses it once with her palm. The skin of her heel is cracked. When she rubs

in two drops of mustard oil, the fissures sting slightly. She likes the smell of the oil, especially after the smell of smoke.

Noon light enters through the crack in the wall like a blade. In that light, motes of dust can be seen drifting up and down. The rest of the room is dark. Clothes lie in a bamboo basket: on top, a sari with a red border; beneath it, two ordinary saris, an old shawl, and a small packet of glass bangles wrapped in cloth. The red-bordered sari feels heavy to her. She takes out the lighter sari. The packet of glass bangles gives a little chime; she presses it back inside.

From far away comes the thud-thud of earth being cut. Now and then, the creak of bullock-cart wheels. Someone coughing. The thin call of a calf. A dog barking twice. Then a long silence. In this silence the ear hears the sounds of its own body—the breath leaving the nose, the slight movement of swallowed water, the rub of cloth, the faint knock of bangles at the wrist. She takes off the bangles. Her bare wrist feels light.

As she crosses the courtyard, the sunlight burns the tops of her feet. Reaching the shade, she stops. Beneath the mango tree, the earth smells of green mango. One fruit lies split halfway open, ants moving all around it. She does not pick it up. She rests her palm against the bark of the tree. The bark's roughness is different from the coolness inside. Leaves move overhead. Light falls between them in small patches upon her body.

The river cannot be seen from here, but the wind brings its smell. A mingled smell of wet sand, rotting leaves, moss and distant water. Since the earthquake there is something new in it—the smell of an exposed layer of raw earth. She draws the smell deep into her nose, then lets it out slowly. She does not like very strong fragrances. Jasmine oil makes her head feel heavy. Mustard, green mango, wet earth—among these three smells she is at ease.

A small brass earring sits in the pierced lobe of her left ear. In the heat, sweat gathers there and turns sticky. She removes the earring and rolls it between her fingers. The coolness of the metal slowly takes on the warmth of her body. A fine black grime has gathered around the piercing; when she wipes it with a wet cloth, it stings a little. She does not put the earring back at once. When the air touches the empty hole in her earlobe, the sensation is different. As she bends her head, her hair brushes the place and feels like a tickle.

She does not like the thick crust that forms on top of the rice. She leaves the rough part at the bottom of the cooking pot for someone else. But she likes the crisp sound of rice dried on the siki. Pressing a small handful between her fingers, she listens to the grains crack. In her mouth the dry grain is hard at first, then softens in saliva. She perceives this small difference clearly. She does not take much at once; two or three grains, then water.

As the afternoon declines, her body grows tired. There is a dull pain on the right side of her waist. She sits with her back against a pillar of the veranda. The clay of the pillar is warm from the sun. The cloth across her back holds that warmth. When she closes her eyes, she sees red light: red behind the eyelids, with a black slanting speck in the middle. When she opens them, the courtyard is

grey-yellow again. No voice calls to her. Only the sound of a vessel being moved comes from inside the house.

Before evening she lets down her hair. As she loosens the knot, the skin of her scalp pulls tight. Two teeth of the comb are broken; her hair catches at the broken place. She does not tug the caught strands free. She separates them with her fingers. Three white hairs remain in the comb. She lays them on her palm and looks at them for a few moments, then lets them fall into the dust of the courtyard. The wind turns the thin hairs once, then lays them against the earth.

As evening falls, the mosquitoes increase. Needle-pricks on the calves, the toes, the soft inner flesh of the arms. Dry leaves are set smouldering to make smoke. The smoke gets into her eyes again. She moves away from it. The inside of her nose already holds the day's smoke. She breathes through her mouth. Her tongue grows dry. As she drinks water from the lota, the brass rim touches her teeth. Cold water goes down her throat.

As the night deepens, all the day's small sensations wake again upon her body—the wrist without its chime, the itch below the knee, the oil on the heel, smoke in the eyes, the sour ache in the tooth, the dull pain at the waist. She turns onto her side. The reeds of the mat press into her back. Outside, crickets sound without pause. Somewhere far away is the faint sound of moving water. Once, in the midst of it all, there seems to be something like the lightest tremor from within the earth—or perhaps it is her own heartbeat; the difference is not clear. She places her palm on the ground. The earth is still.

She does not lift her palm. Her fingertips hold the coldness of the earth. Fine dust fills the lines at the centre of her hand. No shape is clear in the darkness outside. At the edge of the courtyard, a brass lota catches the faint light and gleams at a single point. Then a cloud covers the moon, and that gleam too is erased. In the room there remain only the passage of breath, the roughness of the mat, the coldness of the earth, and the sound of distant water.

Kosi — 4

I am flowing and the earth dissolves into me and whatever lies buried within the earth never becomes a story for me it becomes only weight and weight has colour has smell has grain is lime is ash is the white grit of bone is the slickness of red earth and I give none of these separate names because human beings write names and I read slope I read pressure I read the breaking of banks I read the turning of grains of sand and where yesterday there was grass today there is water and where today there is water tomorrow sand rises again and human beings draw a line on their paper and say this is a village this is a hamlet this is a field this is caste this is a house this is ancestry this is standing but for me a line lasts only as long as the movement within the earth and when the earth shifts the bricks of an old courtyard rise to the surface the soot of a hearth rises to the surface fish bones rise to the surface fragments of earthen pots rise to the surface and sometimes something rises whose sight makes human beings turn their eyes away because that thing does not agree with the page they have written and I see that the body becomes earth but the earth does not at once surrender every mark of the body and the round bone of a wrist remains round for a long time the hardness of teeth remains hard for a long time the sutures of a skull make separate lines as the earth falls away and in all this I see no crime I see no innocence I see only matter that travels with water or remains caught within the earth and human beings look at it and reckon time reckon age reckon sex reckon injury and ask who was this and I have no answer because I do not keep names I only change places but the human hunger for names is stronger than my current they want to read again an abraded line they search for letters in a blank space they lift a fragment from within the earth and search for an ancestor they cross the threshold of their house and go as far as a place they never before had reason to visit and I shift the sand of that place again because rain is falling upstream mountain water is coming down the bank is weak the inner current is strong and among all these causes human beings search for their own cause and when a fragment of bone like a heel gleams out of the sand someone first takes it for wood then someone takes it for stone then a hand reaches to touch it then the hand stops and old words rise within every body but I do not hear words I feel only the pressure of feet that suddenly gathers in one place and then moves away and then people return they bring rope they bring cloth they bring bamboo they inform government officials and marks are set all around the place and the earth that once was a field ridge becomes a place of examination and the sand where

children used to play suddenly becomes a restricted area and human beings open paper again and write the date write the time write the place write an estimate but I do not acknowledge dates because in one place earth from many years lies together the upper layer is new the lower layer is old between them is the fine silt of flood somewhere an earthquake fissure has filled somewhere there is hearth ash somewhere a rotted layer of dung and all of these cling to one another as the stories of a human household cling to one another but paper wants them in separate lines and I see that while a line is being made something remains outside it and what has remained outside comes back again to my side and I do not lift it I do not hide it I only pass water over it and when the water falls what is heavy remains where it is what is light travels onward and within this simple distinction human beings see fear see fate see punishment see omen but for me it is density it is shape it is velocity it is the grip of earth and one day the hand that abrades a name on the page of a panji has its bones too enter this density shape velocity and grip and one day the bones of the body whose name is never written enter it too and both may lie in the same earth without knowing what name anyone above has given to whom and I am flowing and I do not hear but the blow of water against a bridge pier returns within me the pressure upon the body of an embankment returns within me the bottom of a boat rubs against me a bamboo pole cleaves me and people standing on the bank lower their voices because for them a piece of earth is no longer only earth and they say nothing but the stilling of their feet says there is something here that is not in the paper and an old hand watches from a distance and comes nearer and then stops because its memory joins the blank on the page and the blank joins the white fragment in the earth and in that joining no one finds a complete story only two or three signs and I touch it again a light current moves the sand away then lays it down again and what was white shows half and is covered half as human writing survives half and is erased half but that simile belongs to human beings not to me for me a thing half visible is only a thing half exposed and when the evening shadows lengthen its colour changes and night falls and the watchman hangs a lantern and the lantern light trembles upon the water and I flow again without knowing whom they will call in the morning whom they will question whose old lineage will be opened again and whose silence will be written for the first time because my work is only to flow and flowing I come again beside the earth where body and record both lie in their own incompleteness

Anuradha's Voice Message One

[2:17 a.m. · Delhi · night duty · voice-note transcript]

Baba [pause] I didn't call because there have already been two emergencies in the ward [pause] I have five minutes in the staff room now so I'm sending this voice note [inaudible] you'll listen to it [pause] if you don't reply now that's all right too

First tell me you're well [pause] Mohan Babu said you've been going back and forth to the camp [pause] I don't like you going out so often [pause] you're eighty now why won't you accept that [pause] yes I know you'll say eighty is only a number [pause] but BP is a number too and we still take that seriously

Night duty is different from day duty here [pause] by day people talk more at night the machines sound louder [pause] the little beep of the monitor [pause] the whisper of oxygen [pause] trolley wheels [pause] and if someone's family is sleeping outside in the corridor the scrape of their slippers [pause] all these are clearer at night

An old woman came in today [pause] her age is written as seventy-two but her son said close to eighty [pause] the birth year on the paper is different [pause] I asked which one we should accept [pause] the doctor said an approximate age is enough for treatment [pause] then I thought of your genealogical books [pause] if you were here you'd ask for three witnesses to the birth year [pause] one oral [pause] one written [pause] one matched against circumstances

The old woman was holding my hand at first [pause] after the IV went in she let go [pause] she asked my name twice [pause] the first time I said Anuradha [pause] the second time she heard "Radha" [pause] I didn't correct her [pause] sometimes in a hospital names become smaller [pause] bed numbers become bigger [pause] you wouldn't like that [pause] I know

[inaudible] [pause] names are written differently here Baba [pause] nobody cares whether the surname comes first or last in the register [pause] but if the spelling is wrong the medicine file can go somewhere else [pause] so I check again [pause] I think that habit came from you [pause] though I'm not certain [pause] saying it like that makes it sound as if I'm hiding something [pause] perhaps that is accurate enough

Mohan Babu said the genealogical books at home got wet [pause] how much damage was there [pause] he wasn't clear about that [pause] he said you're drying them [pause] separating the pages [pause] not in the sun [pause] in the shade

[pause] how does he know all this [pause] you tell him so much on the phone and not me [pause] this isn't a complaint [pause] I'm only asking

What they show on the news doesn't look like my village [pause] helicopter [pause] roofs in water [pause] people in lines [pause] but I remember that corner of our veranda where you open the genealogical books [pause] then I understand how difficult it must have been to save the papers if the water reached there [pause] then I think it's wrong to worry about paper when people are leaving their homes [pause] then I think if people's names aren't saved on paper there are difficulties in the relief lists too [pause] here in the hospital as well without a file a person's body becomes incomplete information

On the handover sheet today I wrote three things again [pause] bed number [pause] allergy [pause] and the family's phone number [pause] while writing the third I understood that if even one digit is wrong the person called in a night emergency may change [pause] paper isn't a substitute for the body here [pause] but without paper some necessary facts about the body don't reach the next duty shift [pause] part of what you say about the genealogical register makes sense to me after coming here [pause] part of it still doesn't

The family of one patient is sitting outside now [pause] two of them are from a village [pause] on the Supaul side [pause] hearing my language they asked where I'm from [pause] I gave the name of the village and one of them immediately named another village [pause] he said his maternal aunt's home was there [pause] he said "was" [pause] whether it is still there even he doesn't know [pause] I didn't like that word "was" tonight

In the night ward time runs by the clock but people's waiting doesn't [pause] medicine at two-twenty [pause] temperature at two-thirty [pause] urine output at three [pause] but for the family sitting in the corridor time is only the sound of the door opening [pause] there is no column in which to write that [pause] and yet it exists

Baba [pause] are you eating on time [pause] I want an answer to that question [pause] your medicines too [pause] and please don't sit on the floor for an hour while lifting wet pages [pause] last time your knee swelled [pause] yes I'm giving orders from here [pause] a granddaughter is allowed to give orders [pause] is there a prohibition against it in the genealogical register or not

[inaudible] [pause] I've asked about leave [pause] nothing is certain yet [pause] I'll know after the roster is made [pause] if I can put two days together I'll come [pause] but don't tell Mohan Babu yet [pause] he'll send someone all the way to the station again [pause] I can come by myself [pause] boarding a train from Delhi isn't such a great undertaking

[pause] I'm going back to the ward now [pause] the bell rang [pause] two injections are still due [pause] after you hear this just send me one line [pause] "I am well" [pause] that's enough [pause] and if some pages of the genealogical books have dried enough to read send me a photo [pause] but no flash [pause] there'll be glare on the paper

[pause] Baba [pause] one more thing [pause] those three names Mohan Babu began to mention and then stopped midway [pause] leave them for now [pause] I'll hear about them when I come home [pause] not on the phone [pause] not among the sounds of this ward [pause] a thing like that needs the sounds of one's own house [pause] that's all [pause] good night

Body and Caste

The genealogical register does not record the colour of the body. It does not record height. It does not record the hardness of the palms, the marks of childbirth, wounds, fever, hunger, pain in the back, dimness of sight. There are no separate columns for such things. But it would be an error to conclude from this that the genealogical register has no relation to the body. It does not describe bodies; it records the boundaries of the relations society recognizes among bodies.

In the old books of our house there is no heading called “right of touch.” I use that expression in later reflection. What the books contain are lineage—origin, village, descent, relations of marriage, prohibited degrees of nearness, witnesses, births, and sometimes remarks from which one can understand which relations were accepted as valid and which were objected to. The rule remains on the page; its consequence falls upon the body.

Beside a man’s name his father is written. When he marries, the lineage—origin and village of the wife’s side are added. When a son is born, there is a new line. In this sequence the genealogical register treats the body as a route through which lineage travels. The woman’s body is present in that route, but her own experience is mostly absent. There is no pain of childbirth, no blood, no milk, no fever. Only whether a birth took place, whether the line continued.

It is much the same with death. How someone died, how many days the illness lasted, whose hand the person was holding—these are generally not matters for the genealogical register. Death is a boundary in a line of descent. If the date is known, it is written. If not, the grounds of an estimate ought to be recorded separately. The body ends; the register’s interest lies in where the order of relationship goes after it.

The question of caste enters here. When judging eligibility for marriage, the panjikar did not look only at the wishes of two people. He considered lineage—origin, branch, distance of generations, village, relationship and the accepted boundaries of society. Within this inquiry were many matters that reached into the conduct of bodies—at whose house one ate, whose water one drank, with whom one sat in a common row, whose wedding invitation one accepted. Not all of this was written in the genealogical register, but decisions about marriage—standing were not separate from that larger arrangement.

In my childhood some old people used the phrase “the practices of touchability and untouchability”; some would not even name it. A practice

outlives its name. The rim of the well, entry into a courtyard, the place where a leaf-plate was set, the row at a feast, water given at the edge of a doorway—these were small arrangements. The genealogical register was not their daily chronicle. Yet one line about marriage could strengthen the social authority behind these small arrangements.

For that reason it is incomplete to call the genealogical register merely a book of memory. Memory selects. The register selects too. Whose name enters the order of descent, whose relation is written briefly, about whom a remark is added, beside whom a blank remains—such decisions can become history. The hand that writes the decision does not touch the body, but its ink can go on to affect the body's relations.

When I examine the handwriting of my grandfather's father, I look at pressure, curvature, the shape of the 'r', vowel marks, the spaces between words in order to identify the hand. In all these the writer's hand is present. The hand itself is not written into the book, yet the handwriting is a bodily trace of it. The strange thing is that the genealogical register kept making other people's bodies subjects of rules, and now the bodily traces of the writer's own hand give me evidence about that same register.

On the wet page, the direction of scraping can be seen beside the erased line. The fibres of the paper are raised to one side. Here and there a fine residue of ink remains. In reading these things I do not write "pure" or "impure." I write only: original writing existed; abrasion was carried out later; the abrasion does not appear to belong to a single moment; the blank was carried into the copies. Official language can say this much.

But the limit of official language is clear here. If a line was erased, a place on paper became blank. Where did the body bound up with the relationship pushed outside social recognition by that erasure go? The page does not answer. A body feels hunger, conceives, labours, sweats, is wounded. The genealogical register keeps no account of those experiences.

The silent page of Chapter 25 seems necessary to me for that reason—though I do not call it a "chapter" in my work, because my work is with the genealogical book. One may count how many records concerning a woman have been found; how the day passed within her body cannot be recovered from the register. It is easy to fill an absence in the record with imagination; without evidence, it is improper. Where the evidence ends, I too must stop.

The record of caste demands the same restraint. To write down the order described by an old page is not the same thing as endorsing that order. The panjikar's task is to read the old entry as it stands, note differences, identify sources, and invent nothing that is not there. He has no authority to become a judge. But if the panjikar knows that a line was deliberately erased and still presents the resulting blank as original truth, then he is no longer merely a reader.

At this point the difficulty becomes my own. The erased line is not in someone else's hand; it is in the hand of my lineage. Did my family cut and trim,

for its own convenience, within the very rules I spent my life reading for other families? The question is now on the paper. The answer is not yet there.

I made a list. First—the physical condition of the original page. Second—differences in the age of the inks. Third—the match of handwriting. Fourth—the blank in later copies. Fifth—references to the marriage in oral testimonies. Sixth—the word “murder” used in the ploughman’s testimony. Seventh—the place where the bone was found. Of these seven points, not one is sufficient by itself. Even after all are placed together, whatever still cannot be said must not be said.

The word “standing” appears in the genealogical register in several senses: who has standing to marry into which relation, which branch belongs to which line of descent, who is permitted to read which record. But there is one right of the body that the register seldom writes—the right to choose one’s own relationship. I did not put this sentence in the genealogical book. I put it in my diary. The genealogical register is a historical record; the diary is my responsibility. The distinction between the two must be kept.

When I close the book I wash my hands. This is not a rite of purification. Mould, dust and ink from the wet pages cling to my fingers; that is why. The water is dark at first, then gradually clears. A faint mark of ink remains in the lines of my fingers. I feel no need to scrub it away.

A record does not write every truth of the body. But sometimes the body preserves signs of a record’s falsehood—the pressure of a hand, the direction of scraping, the place of a bone, the length of a silence. My work is to place these signs before one another. No judgment yet.

Voice Message Two

Baba [pause] this is the second message [pause] the first time I said I'd hear it when I came home [pause] but Mohan Babu sent two photographs last night [pause] one of a wet page [pause] the other taken from a distance of the list you made in your diary [pause] the list wasn't clear [pause] but I could read three or four names [pause] that's why I'm sending this message now

My duty has just ended [pause] dawn is coming through the staff-room window [pause] the cleaning vehicle passed outside [pause] there is a smell of phenyl in the corridor [pause] there were three emergencies during the night [pause] an old man [pause] a woman in labour [pause] a child whose fever is coming down [pause] each has a separate file [pause] each has different people at home [pause] but the page I kept turning over in my mind all night was that wet page of your genealogical register

At first Mohan Babu only said there was something wrong in an old line [pause] I asked what was wrong [pause] he kept saying ask you [pause] then he sent the photograph [pause] I could read the name Shridhar Mishra [pause] beneath it the paper looks rubbed away [pause] and in the other photo on your list I could read Phuljhari [pause] Jagesar Sada [pause] Harinarayan [pause] I could read these three names [pause] the rest was blurred

I want to say one thing clearly Baba [pause] I don't need a lecture on the old caste rules of marriage [pause] you've explained all that to me since childhood [pause] lineage-origin [pause] village [pause] generation [pause] prohibited relationship [pause] my question isn't about the rule [pause] my question is about the family [pause] because if Harinarayan is our ancestor and the line about Phuljhari was erased by his hand [pause] then this is no longer an error in somebody else's genealogical register

I can hear your voice already [pause] you'll say no conclusion without evidence [pause] I accept that [pause] but you don't need a conclusion in order to ask a question [pause] in the hospital too we ask the patient questions before the test result comes [pause] a question isn't an answer [pause] it only points to the place where an answer is needed

Baba [pause] who was Phuljhari in our family [pause] what was her relation to Shridhar Mishra [pause] how was her relation with Jagesar Sada originally written in the genealogical register [pause] and why did Harinarayan erase that line [pause] these are four questions [pause] but really they are one question [pause] why did our house erase a woman of its own family from its own book

[pause] if you don't want to say anything yet about the killing then don't [pause] I won't drag that out by force [pause] I won't put pressure on you [pause] but was the marriage line erased or not [pause] is it Harinarayan's hand or not [pause] was Phuljhari within our lineage or not [pause] where there is evidence on these three points why the silence

Last night a patient's daughter told me her mother didn't want anyone at home to be told about her illness [pause] I said that was her right [pause] then I took her signature on the consent form [pause] at that moment I thought silence too has two kinds [pause] one silence a person chooses for herself [pause] another silence that someone else places upon her [pause] from outside both can look the same [pause] inside the difference is immense

I don't know anything yet about Phuljhari [pause] there's a name in a photograph [pause] Mohan Babu's unfinished words [pause] your list [pause] that's all [pause] so I'm not making a story about her [pause] I'm asking only whether she had a place in our family's papers [pause] if she did who erased that place [pause] and when did you learn it

[inaudible] [pause] you can't keep back the answer because you think I'm a little girl Baba [pause] I'm twenty-eight [pause] night after night I take responsibility for people's bodies [pause] I stand beside the doctor when news of a death has to be given to a family [pause] I see blood [pause] I clean wounds [pause] I fill forms [pause] I can come home and laugh on the phone [pause] so I am capable of hearing one uncomfortable line from an old family history

I'm not asking you for a statement for a court [pause] not even a voice message [pause] if you want write four lines on paper and send me a photograph [pause] first who Phuljhari is [pause] second who Jagesar is [pause] third Harinarayan's relation [pause] fourth the evidence for the erasure [pause] only as much as is certain [pause] write uncertain beside what is uncertain [pause] after all you are the one who taught me this method

Baba [pause] I want one straight answer [pause] was the line about Phuljhari erased by someone of our own lineage or not [pause] you can write only yes or no [pause] if you write "yes" I'll ask the next question when I come home [pause] if you write "no" I'll look at the evidence [pause] but don't hear this message and remain silent [pause] silence too sounds like an answer [pause] and sometimes it is heavier than one

[pause] I'm going home now [pause] I'll put the phone on silent [pause] sleep till seven [pause] when I wake I'll see whether one line from you has come [pause] take your medicine on time [pause] put a warm cloth on your knee [pause] don't lift the wet books alone [pause] and yes [pause] don't erase my question [pause] good morning Baba

Bone

In the third week after the water receded, two labourers clearing earth beside the unpaved relief road saw a long bone. At first they took it to be from cattle. More earth was removed and another fragment appeared. Work stopped at once. The hand hoe was left where it lay. Two bamboo stakes were driven beside the mound of earth and a rope tied between them. Word reached the camp office.

I was called after noon. Not because I could identify bones. Only because I had pages concerning the old settlement and the location of the Musahar hamlet. I took with me a hand-drawn site sketch made after 1934, a copy of the 1954 survey, and my diary. The scales of the three papers were not the same. North was not marked in the same way on all three. But the old bank of the pond, the stump of the peepal tree, and the low ground to the south corresponded in all three records.

An officer and two constables came from the police station. At first they allowed no one to touch the bone. Photographs of the site were taken. The distance of the bone from the bamboo stake was measured. The distance to the peepal stump was recorded. The height of the ground surface was noted. How high the water had stood was estimated from the line of mud left on the wall at the edge. Two local men were taken as witnesses. Their names and their fathers' names were written on a separate sheet.

The earth was removed slowly. Beside the first long fragment a smaller curved piece was found. North of it something resembling part of a tooth became visible. The officer allowed no one to write down a guess. Even the word "human" was not yet put on paper. The objects were numbered—Bone One, Bone Two, tooth-like fragment, sample of site soil. The distance from the place where each object had been found was recorded separately.

The doctor arrived before evening. Holding the long bone, he did not immediately identify any person, age, or cause of death. He said only that there was a possibility that it was human bone and that forensic examination was necessary. After that sentence, the voices of the people at the site changed. Those who had been standing in a cluster watching moved a little farther back. The officer widened the rope enclosure.

I opened my site sketch. If the 1934 ridge was taken as the reference, the old raised part of the Musahar hamlet lay about twenty-two cubits to the south-west. But in the 1954 survey the same area was marked "old settlement," and the boundary line had moved somewhat north. I could not say whether the earth had

shifted because of the earthquake, erosion, and later floods, or whether the boundary had been straightened for convenience when the map was made. I merely showed the officer both copies.

He asked whether this place was connected with the story of Phuljhari or Jagesar. I did not answer. All I had by way of an answer was a correspondence in the records. The ploughman's testimony mentioned the southern channel by the hamlet. The genealogical register contained an erased line. At this place there was bone. All three facts could be written together; they could not be turned into a single conclusion.

Before the bones were lifted, a thin layer of earth was removed. Small roots, a shard of glass, rusted wire, bits of charcoal, and two conch shells were also found. Which of these belonged to that time, which to a later year, which had been carried in by water—none of this was decided at the site. Objects thought potentially useful were put in separate wrappings. Each wrapping was marked with its number, place, date, and time of recovery. Later they were all sealed.

A thick layer of earth had adhered to the surface of one bone. Someone proposed washing it with water, but the doctor refused. Soil adhering to the surface might itself form part of the examination. The bone was preserved in the condition in which it had been found. The meaning of this small rule was clear to me. While drying the wet genealogical book, I too had resisted the urge to brush away the dust first. Sometimes dirt itself is evidence.

The sealed wrappings were placed in a vehicle. The officer did not give me a copy of the site description; I did not ask for one. In my diary I wrote only five lines: Water receded. Bone found near the boundary of the old Musahar hamlet. Doctor stated possibility of human bone. Identity unknown. Forensic examination pending. In those five lines I did not write "Phuljhari." Nor did I write "Jagesar."

By evening many stories had arisen in the village. Someone said it was the bone of a person who had died in the flood of 2008. Someone said it came from an old cremation ground. Someone said it dated from the earthquake. Two old men of the Musahar hamlet said there had never been a cremation ground at that place. One man asked: if there had been no cremation ground, how had bone come beneath the earth? No one had an answer.

That night I opened the old map again. A red-pencil line on the 1954 copy cut across the old boundary of the Musahar hamlet. It was not clear whether the line meant a proposed auxiliary line of the embankment or merely a survey correction. A corner of the map had already been torn, but the tear was not where the bone had been found. The paper therefore gave me no new answer.

Anuradha's voice message was on my phone. She had asked a direct question. I listened to the message again. I opened the field for typing a reply. I could have written "yes," I could have written "no," or I could have written "evidence insufficient at present." I sent none of the three sentences. I switched the phone off and put it away.

The next morning I added one more line to the diary: confirmation of the bone site against the old map is partial, not complete. Beneath the line I left a blank space. The laboratory's answer had not yet come.

Bone is not a record. A bone bears no written name. But if its place, soil, time, and surrounding objects are preserved, it can change the shape of a question. I had no name yet, only a place. And that place was not far from the old boundary of the Musahar hamlet.

Mohan's Admission

On the evening after I saw the bone site, Mohan came home. He had not brought the government jeep. He stopped his motorcycle near the neem tree, some distance from the veranda. He carried a blue plastic file, and the right sleeve of his shirt was rolled to the elbow. Before coming inside he took off his shoes, drew water from the earthen pitcher, washed his hands and face, then sat down before me without asking anything.

I closed the genealogical book. The phone lay face down on the table. Anuradha's second voice message was in that phone. I had still not sent her a reply. Mohan looked once toward the phone, then opened the blue file. The top sheet bore an old stamp of the Water Resources Department. One corner of the paper was worn. Inside were two photocopies from a measurement book, a copy of a bill, and a payment sheet bearing the contractor's name.

Mohan said, "Babuji, I have something I want recorded." His voice was lower than usual. I opened the diary and wrote the date. I told him that his statement and the evidence would remain separate. He nodded.

He spoke of the year 2007. Before the rains, protection work had been sanctioned on a section of the embankment. The proposal included earth filling, sand-filled sacks, bamboo fencing, clearing brush, and material for temporary protection along an eroding edge. Mohan was then a junior engineer in the local subdivision. His job was to verify quantities at the site, enter figures in the measurement book, and certify the material that had actually arrived.

In the first week the material came up short. The quantities proposed in the measurement book were not present at the site. The sand-filled sacks were short by two consignments. The bamboo bundles were fewer in number. In one section, the earth filling had not reached the specified height. Mohan had written these differences in red pencil in the margin on the first day. On the second day the assistant engineer came. The contractor was there too. A meeting of about half an hour took place at the site. According to Mohan, no separate minutes of that meeting were prepared.

Mohan said he was told that if payment was held up before the rains, the remaining material would not come; the bill should first be passed, and the shortage would be made up afterward. He struck out his red-pencil note. In the final measurement the proposed quantities were entered. His signature is below. He pushed the file toward me.

I looked at the signature. The letters were Mohan's—the first curve of 'म', the upper stroke of 'ठ', his way of writing the numeral seven in a date. I knew them all. But identifying a signature and proving the actual quantity of material at a site are not the same thing. I wrote in the diary: Mohan's signature present on copy of measurement book. Verification of quantity requires original stock register, receipts, and site records.

Mohan said, "It isn't that I didn't see the quantities. I saw them. They were short. Even then I wrote them as complete."

He fell silent there. A cow bell sounded from the cattle shed outside. I said nothing.

After a while he took a small paper from the back section of the blue file. It was a photocopy of a bank deposit slip. The deposited sum was forty thousand rupees. The date was three days after the final bill for the protection work had been passed. Depositor: Mohan Mishra.

Mohan said the contractor's man had not given him the money at home. The envelope had been handed over in a back room of a tea shop at the district headquarters. He accepted it. He did not count the money there. He opened it that night at his quarters. The next day he deposited the money in the bank.

I asked, "Who told you?"

He said, "No one."

"On whose orders?"

"No written order."

"Did the assistant engineer know?"

Mohan was silent for a while. Then he said, "I cannot say that on the evidence."

I wrote the answer in the diary exactly as it was. I added no inference.

He said that some of the money went toward paying an old household debt, and some toward Anuradha's nursing admission fees and travel. He said Anuradha's name softly. I did not stop him. What the money was spent on did not change the nature of his admission. The measurement had been recorded falsely, and cash had been accepted. These were the facts he himself was stating.

I asked, "A direct connection between this work and the erosion?"

Mohan did not answer at once. He opened the measurement book again. He looked at the section number. He looked at the distance figures. He said that the section whose measurements he had certified was separate from the principal point of the Kusaha breach, but the method of payment belonged to the same system of protection work. He could not say that his signature caused the breach. He could say only that the quantities the department expected him to verify were not quantities he had recorded truthfully.

The distinction was necessary. I wrote: improper certification admitted. Improper receipt of money admitted. Causal relation to the breach not established.

Mohan's head was lowered. He said, "If you want, keep these papers."

I said, "The originals stay with you. Give me photocopies."

He left the copies.

After a while he asked about the bone. I said the examination report had not come. He did not take Phuljhari's name. He did not take Jagesar's name. He did not ask about the erased line. Nor did he mention Anuradha's message. His admission that night remained confined to the file on the protection work.

I asked why he had brought these papers now. Mohan replied that the news of the bone had reminded him of the old departmental file. He said, "If I keep one thing hidden inside me, how can I sit in front of you about another?" I did not unpack the meaning of that sentence in the diary. I wrote only: statement presented voluntarily.

What he admitted answered none of Anuradha's four questions. Phuljhari, Jagesar, Harinarayan and the erased line—all four remained outside the file. That night Mohan chose the paper that bore the signature of his own hand. I did not write why.

I understood that people often admit first to the offence whose paper is in their own hand. What has no paper requires another way of being told. I did not write this sentence in the diary. In the diary I wrote only the date of his statement, the papers present, the signature, the deposit slip, and the unanswered questions.

Mohan rose and went outside. The motorcycle was still beside the neem tree. He did not leave at once. For a while he stood at the edge of the veranda. I turned the phone over. Anuradha's message showed on the screen. The reply box was still empty.

I turned the phone face down again.

The One Without a Name

After Mohan left, the blue file remained on the table. I did not paste its photocopies into the diary. The diary was for the dates of events and for statements. This file needed another place—a place where evidence, doubt, silence and omitted names could remain together, yet without becoming a line in the original panji and turning falsehood into truth.

I opened an old wooden chest. At the bottom, beneath two folds of cloth, lay an unused ledger. Its cover was faded green, its corners worn, its paper thick. I had bought it long ago, not to record any client's lineage. There was nothing on its first page.

At the top of the first page I wrote only the date. Beneath it I wrote: "Counter-Panji."

My hand stopped as soon as I wrote "counter." This was not a copy of the original panji. It was not a transcript of the original. Nor was it a book made in opposition to the original. It was a place for entries that ought to have been in the original but were not; a place for questions the panji system had failed to hold; a place for statements which, if written, would become evidence, and if left unwritten would remain merely in the air of the house.

I wrote the first rule: "Do not write inference as fact." Second: "When a source is known, write the source with the statement." Third: "A name absent from the original may appear here only with evidence." Fourth: "Leave blank space for doubt." Fifth: "Do not strike out the original line."

After writing the rules, I opened Shridhar's page. I measured the erased place again. I examined the abrasion of the paper, the edge of the ink, the distance to the next line, and the blank carried into later copies. In the Counter-Panji I wrote: "The line following Shridhar was erased from the original sheet by abrasion. The handwriting of the erasing hand matches Harinarayan's writing. Original words illegible."

I stopped there. It would have been easy to write, "Harinarayan erased it." The evidence did not go that far. The handwriting matched; there was no direct witness to whose hand had performed the act. So the sentence remained as it was.

Then came the time to write Phuljhari's name on the next page. Her name was not in the panji. It was indicated in the priest's testimony. In the sister-in-law's domestic account there were the work of her body, her clothes, her plate, the doorway. In the ploughman's testimony there were Jagesar Sada and the word murder. In Harinarayan's panji entry there was a blank. The four sources did not

say the same thing. I therefore made four small marks beside the name and wrote a source against each.

“Phuljhari — name appears in oral testimonies. Absent from the original panji.”

Below it: “Jagesar Sada — explicit in the ploughman’s testimony. Consistent with memory of the old settlement. Absent from the original panji.”

I lifted my pen to write the word “marriage,” then put it down. The priest called it a marriage. The sister-in-law spoke of preparations inside the house. The ploughman spoke of social prohibition. The panji gave a blank instead of a marriage line. To add all this together and call the marriage proved would be haste on my part. I wrote: “Nature of relationship disputed; marriage asserted directly in one source, indirectly in the others.”

Beside the word murder I sat even longer. The ploughman had said “murder.” Bones had been found, but had not been identified. There was domestic testimony about Phuljhari’s last presence, but no death record. I wrote: “Statement of violent death available; identity of the deceased not established.”

After that sentence I left half the page blank.

The phone lay face down. Anuradha’s voice message was still unanswered. Her questions had entered this ledger now, but not as answers. As questions. For the first time I understood that giving an answer and making a record are not the same act. An answer is given to a human being. A record is placed before an unknown reader of the future.

I picked up the phone. I opened the message. In the reply box I wrote: “I have read your questions.” That was all. I did not send it. Then I erased it.

On the third page of the Counter-Panji I wrote the description of the bones: distances from the site, partial correspondence with the old map, soil sample, police serial numbers, bones sent for examination. I left the name field blank. Beside the blank I wrote no conjecture.

The fourth page was for Mohan’s blue file. I entered his admission, the measurement book, the forty-thousand-rupee deposit slip, the date, and the fact that causal connection had not been established, each on a separate line. Under Mohan’s admission I did not add Phuljhari’s name. Under the Kusaha breach I did not add Harinarayan’s. To draw a line between things whose relation was unproved would be the first offence of the Counter-Panji.

Night deepened. Everyone in the house had gone to sleep. I kept turning the pages of the ledger. On the fifth page I wrote a heading: “The One Without a Name.”

Under that heading I left the first line blank. On the second I wrote: “The woman whose name is not in the line of descent.” On the third: “The man whose name is not in the marriage line.” On the fourth: “The child or lineage for whom the evidence remains incomplete.”

After writing the word “child” I looked at the page for a long time. The word was itself a possibility, not evidence. I did not strike it out; I wrote

“possibility” in brackets. In the Counter-Panji, striking something out was itself an archival act. The existence of what had first been written was not to be hidden.

On the last page of the ledger I wrote one line: “This book will not take the place of the original panji.”

Below it: “What the original panji says is evidence of the original. What this book asks is evidence of the question.”

Before dawn I did not put the ledger back in the chest. Nor did I put it with the other panji books. I placed it in an old cloth bag beneath the table and tied the mouth of the bag. I told no one.

For the first time I possessed a record whose client was no family, no marriage, no certificate. Its client was the future—or perhaps one human being who would one day ask where we should look for the person whose name was never written.

I extinguished the lamp. The ledger remained in the bag. The original panji remained in the chest. Both were in the same house, but now no single book held sole authority over a single truth.

Muscat

Anuradha's decision to go to Muscat was not made in a single day. The first sign of it was not a passport but a hospital payslip. After night shifts in Delhi, rent, food, phone expenses, money sent home, and the monthly instalment on her nursing loan were deducted, she wrote what remained in pencil at the corner of the paper. Three months of accounts said the same thing: on this salary the debt would not be cleared quickly.

She first heard the name Muscat from her colleague Reshma. Reshma was from Kerala, had worked for two years in Oman and returned to Delhi, and used to say that a foreign salary was worth hearing about, but going abroad without reading the papers was not worth it. The first time Anuradha took the sentence as a joke. The second time she saved an agent's number on her phone. The third time she called.

The agent introduced the business as an 'overseas employment consultancy.' The office was in a lane in Karol Bagh. There were plastic chairs beneath the stairs, a coloured map of Oman on the wall, a picture of a hospital behind glass, and photocopies of passports on the desk. Once seated, Anuradha's first question was not about salary but fees. The answer came in three parts—file fee, medical examination, and service charge.

She wrote all three amounts in her small notebook. Then she asked, 'Will I see the contract first?' The agent said, after the appointment letter arrived. 'Name of the hospital?' she asked. The agent turned a paper toward her. It was in Arabic and English. The hospital was private. City—Muscat. Position—staff nurse. Term—two years. Accommodation—employer. Food—not included. Transport—employer. Leave—as per contract.

Anuradha asked for a photocopy. The agent looked at her first, then said it was the office copy. She asked permission to photograph it on her phone. Permission was given. The photograph was blurred, but the hospital's name, salary, term, and place for signature could be read. During a break on night duty Anuradha enlarged the image and read it three times.

She had already applied for a passport. On the day of police verification the landlord was not at home. There was a phone call, a wait, then another day. When the passport arrived, she read her own name on the first page three times. Father's name, date of birth, place of birth, address. In one small book were gathered all the proofs by which a body became eligible to travel.

In a second call the agent said a medical examination was necessary. Anuradha was a nurse in a hospital, but in this examination she was neither patient nor employee; she was a body fit to go abroad. Blood, X-ray, urine, eyesight, weight, blood pressure. A number on every slip. A queue outside every room. In one room the women sat separately. One held papers for Saudi Arabia, another Kuwait, another Oman.

While her blood was being drawn, the technician asked, 'First time abroad?' Anuradha nodded. He asked nothing else. The vial carried not her name but a number. Anuradha memorized that number. At the hospital she checked patients' wristbands; here she watched the number on her own vial.

Outside the chest X-ray room five women sat together. One from Gorakhpur, one from Kottayam, one from Jalandhar, one from Darbhanga, one Anuradha. The woman from Darbhanga started at the sound of Maithili. Within two minutes the two of them had linked village, police station, railway line, and nursing-school names. The other woman was going to Salalah. Anuradha asked, 'How far from Muscat?' Neither knew.

The medical report came two days later. 'FIT' was stamped at the top in English. Anuradha did not fold the paper. She put it in a plastic folder. When she submitted it at the agent's office, she asked for a receipt. The receipt showed only part of the total amount. She asked, 'The rest?' The answer came: 'Service charge is separate.' Anuradha said, 'Give me a separate paper.' A paper was given.

She made photocopies of all the receipts. One copy in the Delhi cupboard, one in an envelope sent to the village, one as an image on the phone. She had not yet told Grandfather. She told Mohan. Mohan's first question was, 'Is the agent registered?' Anuradha said she had seen a number but had yet to verify it. Mohan was silent on the phone, then said, 'Not one rupee more without papers.'

Anuradha did not laugh at the sentence. She remembered what papers meant in Mohan's life. But this time the advice was useful. She searched the ministry website for the recruiting agent's details. She matched the spelling of the office name against the paper. The registration number matched. She checked the validity period. The address matched. Only then did she pay the next amount.

The appointment letter arrived a week later. This time the paper was cleaner. Hospital name, Muscat, monthly salary, accommodation, duty hours, overtime rules, annual leave, travel expenses, probation. Anuradha marked the paragraph on 'probation.' She showed it to Reshma. Reshma circled two lines—the conditions under which the employer could terminate the contract, and an ambiguous sentence about the keeping of the passport.

Anuradha phoned the agent. The answer was, 'Ask HR after you reach there.' Anuradha said, 'I'll go when it is written here.' For three days there was no call. On the fourth, a revised copy arrived. The sentence had changed: the passport would remain with the employee and would be produced when required for administrative purposes. She read the paper again.

The ticket was from Delhi to Muscat. The departure was at night. Two weeks before leaving, Anuradha made a packing list—two sets of duty clothes, a

stethoscope, no blood-pressure instrument because the hospital would provide one; three saris, two salwar-kurtas, slippers, shoes, medicines, originals and photocopies of certificates, nursing registration, marksheets, passport photographs, receipts, appointment letter, medical report, a small box of thread; but no earth from home in a metal box—she did not want to carry earth with her.

She herself noticed the decision not to take earth from home. She had heard stories of people carrying some token when they went abroad. She did not want a token. She wanted papers, shoes, medicines, and a phone charger.

She had three days in the village. Grandfather looked at her passport. He read the first page. He turned the pages. He said nothing. Anuradha herself said, 'I'm going to Muscat.' Grandfather asked, 'For how long?' She said, 'The contract is for two years.' Grandfather looked through the pages of the passport again, as though time might be written there.

He still had not answered the questions in Anuradha's first voice message. Anuradha did not ask again that day. The papers for going abroad lay on the table; the old panji was in the chest. Four arm-lengths lay between them.

Mohan came to see her off at the station. In the car he examined the agent's receipts again. Annoyed, Anuradha said, 'I can read.' Mohan turned the papers back to her. 'That much I know,' he said, and nothing more.

After returning to Delhi, the shifts of her last week at the hospital felt heavy. She gave medicines, filled charts, took blood pressure, explained the handover list to a new nurse. Work familiar for five years suddenly became countable—the last night shift, the last locker key, the last staff meal, the last attendance signature. She did not use the word 'last' before anyone.

On the day of departure her baggage was two kilos over the limit at the airport. She removed one heavy book and gave it to Mohan. Of the two saris, she took one out. The folder of papers remained in her hand luggage. Medical report, contract, passport, ticket—she checked all four repeatedly.

At immigration the officer looked at the passport, looked at the visa, looked at the screen. He asked, 'Employment?' Anuradha said, 'Yes.' 'Nurse?' 'Yes.' Then the stamp came down. The sound was small. After that the passport was back in her hand.

In the waiting area she opened her phone. Grandfather's name was at the top. She began recording a voice message, then stopped. She sent a written message: 'I am inside. The flight is on time.' After sending it, she wanted to write a second line: 'My questions are still there.' She did not write it.

When the plane rose, the lights of Delhi became points below. Anuradha saw her own face in the window glass. She was not looking for the opening of a new life. The folder lay in her lap. A safety card was in the seat pocket. The phone was in flight mode. The decision that had taken shape over a month through papers, fees, tests, signatures, and revisions was now only a journey.

On reaching Muscat, the first thing she noticed was not the heat but the airport light: white, steady, shadowless. Arrival queue, passport check, baggage

belt, a driver standing with a small placard bearing the hospital's name. She saw her own name. The driver did not ask for her passport; he merely matched the name.

The car moved along the city road. Outside were the black shapes of mountains, yellow road lights, white buildings in the distance. Anuradha looked at the time on her phone. It differed from Delhi. She did not change it; the phone changed itself.

There were two beds in the room at the residence. On the other bed lay the belongings of a nurse already living there—a blue suitcase, a bottle of water, a charger, a small Arabic-English phrasebook. Anuradha put her folder not beneath the pillow but on the top shelf of the cupboard. Her passport remained in her own bag.

That night she made a voice message. Before sending it, she listened to it. The first sentence was, 'I have arrived.' The second: 'All the papers are with me.' The third sentence stopped as it was being formed: 'Grandfather, those questions...' She deleted the recording. She made a new message. Only two sentences. She sent it.

Her first night in Muscat began with those two sentences. The first record of foreign land was not the stamp in the passport. It was a voice in which what had not been said weighed as much as the sentences that had.

Kosi — 5

I flow and this time the number of feet on the road beside me grows smaller and the number of closed chests inside houses grows larger and the key to a door stays with someone's cousin or someone's maternal uncle or hangs from a neighbour's peg and in the house where smoke once rose as evening fell the hearth now burns once a month and in the courtyard where children wrote names in the earth grass rises and I do not call this change migration because to me migration has no direction I see only fewer feet I see the load in the boat grow lighter I see fewer people crossing on market day and I see a small phone glinting in a hand in place of a letter and I see new tin laid on the roofs of some houses and colour painted on some walls and new iron chests arriving in some rooms and I understand that money does not come here merely from one pocket to another it moves from labour in a distant country becomes a number in a bank then becomes a sack from the market becomes a packet of medicine becomes a school fee becomes tin for a roof becomes a motor pump becomes the expense of a wedding and sometimes becomes an object kept inside an empty house whose user does not himself live in that house and I do not see the wires of money but I see its weight upon the earth when a brick wall rises in place of a raw-earth wall when an iron window replaces bamboo slats when a plastic drum stands beside an old earthen jar when motorcycle wheels cut into the bullock-cart road but among all this I also see that the stronger the walls of a house become the fewer the voices inside it and someone's mother hears her son's voice on a phone and someone's father looks at a bank slip at the end of the month and someone's wife sits late into the night calculating the time in a distant country and someone's child sees his father's face on a screen and cannot touch it and I keep no account of the absence of touch I count only the bodies standing at the ghat when the morning boat fills early I feel the weight against the bottom of the boat when the boat is half full I feel that lightness and year after year the lightness increases and within the village the work of old bodies and women increases and on the ridge of a field where two pairs of feet once walked now one pair walks and at paddy harvest labourers come from outside and to repair a roof a mason comes from another village and a son arrives by plane for a wedding and at a death someone cannot get a ticket and then his voice comes by phone and I do not hear that voice inside the water but I see the light of a phone placed at the ghat and the faces bent toward it and when day in the distant country is night here the people of the house stay awake and when it is day here a work shift is running

there and time divides into two within the same clock like a map dividing a river into two banks but inside the water that division does not hold I flow at the same temperature carry the same sand cut the same earth and human beings divide their time by the clocks of countries and divide their bodies by employment contracts and keep the memory of home in phone messages and those who go to Muscat carry clothes papers medicine shoes and a charger but cannot carry the whole smell of home with them and those who go to Delhi board a train and those who go to Punjab carry a sack and a blanket and those who go toward Kathmandu cross the border and I keep no names for directions I see only that the bodies remaining inside the village become fewer and the earnings made outside return inward as objects but people themselves cannot return like objects sometimes after two years sometimes after five years sometimes only for a wedding sometimes only for a death and sometimes sometimes never and then the key of the house remains with someone else and the colour on the wall fades in the sun and in a closed room the smell of clothes changes and the line of descent continues in the panji but the people in that line live in the time of different countries and questions of marriage are asked over the phone and the name of the ancestral village becomes the permanent address in a passport and the house bearing that permanent address stays empty most days of the year and I do not understand the word permanent because beside me the earth itself shifts sand rises the bank is cut old channels fill new channels open but human beings write permanent address because paper asks them for one place and the body carries them to another and between those two places money travels messages travel instructions travel worry travels and sometimes silence travels and I see this silence when an old father at the ghat moves a finger over the screen of his phone but puts the phone back in his pocket before pressing anyone's name and when a woman after a night shift in a hospital in a distant country opens the device to hear the voice of home but sends only two sentences and stops the third and I flow and do not ask the meaning of the stopped sentence because beyond words for me there is water there is earth there is slope and there is the emptying courtyard on which rain falls and the person far from the house does not see that rain himself but on the tin roof bought with the money he sent the rain makes a sound and the people left in the house hear that sound and beneath that sound I keep my flow unbroken and a boat passes beside me and seats in the boat remain empty and in someone's hand a phone shines and in someone's pocket a bank slip lies folded and on someone's face rests the time of a distant country and a village does not lose its people all at once a village slowly counts days counts keys counts closed doors counts the waiting for phone calls and I flow outside this counting but the ghats beside me keep the marks of all of it

CHAPTER 35

All of Us

We have no single day of departure. Our village did not empty on a single day. First two or four young men left, then two brothers from one household, then five men from the neighbouring hamlet, then two of those five called five more. Some carried railway tickets; some carried only a small slip of paper on which a city's name and a phone number were written. Some had a contractor's introduction, some a brother-in-law's promise, some only the news that a day's work in such-and-such city paid what two days' labour paid here.

Those of us who left understood our village for the first time not on a map but through distance. The train kept moving, station names kept changing, the colour of the earth beyond the window kept changing. Our sack, blanket, gamchha, dry chura, sattu, salt and chilli, one change of clothes, an envelope of papers, and the small packet given from home stayed with us. When we stepped down at a station we understood that no one here knew our names, but the work of our hands had value.

Some of us transplanted paddy in the fields of Punjab, harvested wheat, stood knee-deep in mud amid jets from motor pumps. Some carried bricks at construction sites in Delhi, lifted iron reinforcing rods, spent nights in rooms of unfinished buildings. Some breathed thread-dust in the loom sheds of Surat. Some washed plates in hotel kitchens. Some kept watch. Some worked in hospitals, domestic service, shops, warehouses, factories and small office jobs. Our employments differed, but the route taken by the money we sent was usually the same—the account at home.

Those of us who stayed were inside migration too. To call the women, old people, children and infirm bodies left in the village merely “those who stayed at home” is incomplete. Weeding, transplantation, cattle fodder, school fees, medicine, bank, post office, ration, weddings, shraddha, roof repairs, a broken tubewell—all this came onto hands that had earlier carried only half the burden. The absence of the one who had gone away became work in itself: waiting for his call, whether the money had come, when he would return, how many days he would stay, when he would leave again. These calculations entered the daily life of the house.

At first we wrote letters. Yellow envelopes, blue inland letters, sometimes postcards. We wrote: I am well; may all of you be well; I have sent money; write about the fields; has the cow calved; has the roof stopped leaking? There was little room for what had to be written, and infinite room for what was not to be

written. Later came the telephone. First the queue at the PCO, then small mobile phones, then screens. The voice began to arrive more quickly, but the number of things said did not increase.

Sometimes an evening came to our homes when the time of three countries gathered at one doorway. It was mealtime in the village, shift-change in Delhi, a short break from work in a Gulf country. When the phone rang everyone in the house gathered in one place, but only two people spoke. "Have you eaten?" "Yes." "Did you take the medicine?" "Yes." "Did the money arrive?" "Yes." A third question reached someone's throat and stopped there.

Our migration is not only a story of money. Money certainly came. Earthen walls became brick; tin replaced thatch; one house got a pump; someone's daughter continued her education; someone's illness was treated; someone's debt was paid off. But time did not arrive with the money. If a person stayed away for five years, the evenings of those five years did not come home. When a child learned to walk, the body that might have watched the first steps remained in a distant city. When an old person's hearing weakened, the son's voice became still fainter over the phone.

Those of us who lived in cities did not call the city our own, but after returning to the village we were not exactly as before either. Outside words tried to enter our speech, the way we dressed changed, mealtimes changed, the hour of sleep changed. We tried to mix those words into the village tongue; some settled, some remained outside. The pace of work learned in the city did not fit the seasons of the field. The city said time is money; the village said time is rain, transplantation, harvest, festival, marriage, death and waiting.

When we returned we brought gifts. Clothes for someone, a watch for someone, plastic toys for children, steel boxes for the house, scented oil, slippers, a torch, a small radio, later a mobile phone. From the list of gifts the household understood how far away the outside world was and how close. But the body that brought the gifts usually left again after two weeks. The objects remained. The door sounded less often again.

Even our marriages began to be fixed according to the arithmetic of migration. The date depended on when leave would be granted, how expensive the ticket was, how many days could be taken away from the place of work. Sometimes the bridegroom arrived two days before the wedding; sometimes he left four days after it. A newly married couple's first month passed across a phone screen. The marital home, the natal home, the city of employment and the village—between these four places a new household came into being without a single roof over it.

On forms we kept writing the village as our permanent address. The paper said we belonged here. Our bodies said we worked elsewhere. The bank account said money arrived here. The phone said the voice was there. Electoral roll, ration card, school certificate, land record—all kept binding us to the village; employment contracts kept us outside it. One person had two or three places, but was complete in none.

Some of us shared rooms in the city. Four beds for eight people: two on night shift, two on day shift, so the bodies using the same bed changed in turn. There was no picture of the village on the wall, only a calendar. A stove in one corner, a bucket in another, clothes on a rope above. Food was simple—rice, dal, potatoes, sometimes pickle. On salary day money for home was set aside first, then rent, food, travel, phone. What remained for ourselves we called not earnings but expenses.

Some of us borrowed from agents to go abroad. Passport, medical examination, visa, ticket, service charge—before departure, earnings had already become debt. The first month's wage did not reach home; it reduced the debt account. People at home waited. On the phone we said: next month I will send it. The next month we sent something. When the debt was cleared, half of the first money to reach the village went toward older debts. Again we said: next month. Many years of migration moved on the promise of "next month."

Locks increased in our village. At first locks were only on chests; later on rooms, then on the main door. The key stayed with a neighbour, cousin, sister, old mother, or whoever watched the fields. Twice a year the door opened, the house was swept, windows opened, mattresses put in the sun. Then the lock again. Such a house was not ownerless: it had owners, an address, taxes were paid, utensils stood inside, but it had no daily breath.

Our fields changed too. The field of someone away was given on sharecropping, another leased out, another left fallow. Labourers came from other villages for farm work. A family that had once worked its own land with its own hands now paid wages from money received through the bank. The field slowly ceased to be only the source of the family's food and became property, security, prestige in marriage, and the possibility of returning. We were outside, but whenever the question of selling land arose, every voice in the house suddenly became heavy.

We watched village festivals through phones. Puja, aripan, Sama-Chakeva, wedding songs, the Chhath ghat, rites after a death—someone raised a phone, someone turned the camera, we watched on a screen. The image reached us; the smell did not. The song reached us; courtyard earth did not touch our feet. We learned to accept this insufficiency of the screen because there was no other way to be absent.

Our children's relation to the village was not uniform. Some grew up in the village, some in cities, some at their mother's natal home, some with grandparents. One child's father came once a year, another's mother once in two years. Children learned recognition from a voice on the phone; when the body finally returned, there was shyness for the first two days. On the third day the child asked for a toy. On the fifth, sat in the lap. On the seventh, the departure ticket was again present in the courtyard.

We measured the age of our elders through phone calls. "Now the hearing is weak." "Now the knee hurts." "Now eye medicine is needed every day." These sentences travelled to distant cities. We asked for leave; sometimes it came,

sometimes not. Illness does not obey a timetable. Death, more than once, arrived before the ticket. Then we remained silent across the phone, sent money, exchanged shifts with a colleague, and afterward went back to work. A day of mourning has no separate box on a payslip.

Those of us who stayed in the village did not see the people outside as fixed pictures either. On the phone they said: everything is fine here. We knew everything could not be fine. We did not ask, because asking would increase the burden of answering. They asked: is everyone at home well? We said: well. Water might have risen in the fields, the roof might be leaking, medicine might have been bought on credit; still the first answer remained “well.” On both sides people went on telling half-truths to protect one another from worry.

Our collective story was made of these half-truths. There is no single hero and no single victim. At times we are migrants; at times people waiting for migrants; at times senders of money; at times receivers; at times keepers of keys to locked houses; at times watchers of fields; at times people going to see someone off at a station; at times people recognizing a returning body at the station. Our roles changed with the years.

In the speech of our village, outside cities slowly became directions. “He is in Delhi.” “He is in Punjab.” “He is in Surat.” “He is toward the Gulf.” These sentences became part of identification. Earlier one asked lineage-origin, village, father, clan, hamlet; now place of employment joined them. In marriage discussions came new questions: how much salary, how much leave, will the family live with him or will he stay alone, how many years is the contract? The old accounting of lineage began to sit beside the new accounting of employment.

At first we thought we would earn and return. “Two years,” “three years,” “when the debt is paid,” “when the roof is built,” “when my sister is married,” “when the child’s studies are complete”—the conditions for return kept changing. Once one condition was fulfilled, another stood up. The decision to return to the village became a future line that remained written while the date stayed blank.

Some of us finally returned. We returned and found other things in our rooms, field boundaries changed, old friends away, children grown, the gait of elders slowed. In our own houses we asked where things were kept. Those who had remained in the village showed us the way. We had lived outside and sent money; they had lived inside and preserved the memory of the house. Without the other, each task was incomplete.

Some of us could not return. Employment became permanent in another country, children went to school there, and the house in the village became a place for only a few days each year. Even then the permanent address on forms remained the village. In many houses the question began to be asked in advance: after death, will the body return or not? Migration became not only a question of life but a question of arrangements for death.

We do not tell this story in a single colour of sorrow. Going outside saved some bodies, raised some houses, made some education possible, let some women

operate bank accounts in their own names for the first time, freed some families from old debts. Going outside also broke some marriages, made some children grow up at a distance, left some elders alone, abandoned some fields, locked some houses. Gain and loss are not written on the same slip, and therefore it is difficult to count them separately.

In government lists our numbers were divided among many boxes: migrant labourer, service worker, construction worker, nurse, driver, guard, domestic helper, factory worker, student, dependent. In the language of the village we were simply people who had “gone outside.” Within that one phrase were contained distance, profession, wage, country, risk, loneliness and hope.

When we returned, we crossed the river, crossed the embankment, crossed the station, crossed borders, crossed airports. Each crossing had its own paper. But once inside the doorway at home, the first things we did were usually the same—take off our shoes, wash our feet, look at the people inside, remain silent. In those few moments the city’s salary, ticket, contract, identity card and bank slip all remained outside.

Then we left again. The door closed. The key stayed with someone again. Money came into the bank again. The phone rang again. Seasons changed in the fields. Children grew taller. The gait of old people slowed. The colour of the house faded. The village population remained on paper and diminished in bodies.

We are the story of our village in this interval. Those who left, those who remained, those who returned, those who left again, those who waited, those who sent money, those who kept keys, those who answered the phone, those who told half-truths—together we are “all of us.” We have no single face, no single voice, no single departure. Our story does not fit into one line of the genealogical register, because the register writes lineage but not the years of distance; it writes marriage but not the nights of the absent body; it writes birth but not the waiting of the father who first saw his child on a screen. We are in that blank space where the village remains and its people work far away.

The Village That Emptied

In Jeth of 2016 I was given the key to a locked house in the eastern hamlet. The key was brass-coloured, rusted at the teeth, with red thread tied to its ring. The cousin who gave it to me said the owners were all away: one son in Surat, another in Delhi, the daughter married toward Nepal, the old woman of the house dead two years before. There was a possibility that an old copy of the genealogical register or some paper concerning marriage lay inside. I was given only the task of finding papers.

There was an iron lock on the main door. A layer of dust lay on the lock. Two dry leaves had slipped under the bottom of the door. A spider web crossed the frame. Beside the latch remained a brown mark of old cow-dung plaster. On the veranda stood a bamboo stool with one leg broken; an earthen water jar with a steel plate turned upside down over its mouth; a tin canister with its lid apart; a pair of rubber slippers, the strap of the right one broken; an empty coconut-oil bottle; an old kerosene tin; two dry brooms; a rusted lantern hanging from an iron hook. On the wall was a calendar—2011—open to the month of Phagun. The clock had stopped, its hands at seven-eighteen.

In the kitchen were three brass plates, two bowls, one bell-metal lota, one aluminium cooking pot without a lid. The clay stove held old ash. In the ash lay two half-burnt pieces of wood. The grinding stone for spices, its roller beside it. In an old salt tin there was only a hardened white crust. A brass measure for paddy, its edge flaking. A bamboo winnowing tray gnawed at one end by rats. Iron tongs. An earthen jar for pithar, with a dried insect inside. A small pot for setting curd, overturned. A black layer of smoke rose on the wall to the height where the hearth fire must once have reached.

In the first room was a chest. It had an old coat of blue paint, with two letters once painted in white at the centre, now only half remaining. Inside were five saris, all folded: one with a green border, one ochre, one blue, two white. Dry neem leaves lay between the clothes. A man's dhoti, two gamchhas, a woollen shawl, a child's sweater with short sleeves. In a paper envelope were four photographs: one wedding photograph, one school group, one young man in what looked like an airport, one old woman seated in the veranda. No names were written on the backs. In a plastic bag lay a vermilion box, three glass bangles, one silver-coloured anklet without its pair.

At the bottom of the chest were papers. Three years of electricity bills. Bank deposit slips. A life-insurance receipt. A school-fee book. An old land-revenue

receipt. A photocopy of a ration card. Two slips for money sent from Muscat. A prescription from a Delhi hospital. A post-office savings book. An envelope with an address written on it but no stamp. Inside was only the beginning of a letter: "Mother, I am well"—after that the page was blank. Among these papers there was no copy of the genealogical register.

The bolt of the second room had not been fastened from inside. A mattress lay folded on the bed. Four bamboo poles of a mosquito net had been placed together on top of it. The pillowcase had yellowed. Under the bed were a large pair of leather shoes; a child's plastic ball, deflated; the bellows of a broken harmonium; a small iron toolbox containing screwdrivers, a hammer, nails and pieces of wire. In one corner stood a plastic drum with dry earth inside. Pigeon droppings lay on the window ledge. Limewash had flaked from the wall in scales.

At the other end of the veranda hung a bag of keys. Six keys. No one had written which key opened which lock. One key opened the back room. Agricultural implements were stored there—two sickles, a hoe, an old ploughshare, a bundle of rope, empty paddy sacks, printed fertilizer sacks reused for storage, a bamboo basket, a mustard-oil tin, an empty pesticide container, two old seed bags. On the wall three numbers had been written in charcoal—12, 7, 4. Their meaning was unknown.

The tulsi altar in the courtyard was not dead. No one watered it regularly, yet from rainwater and moisture in the earth two leaves remained green. Beside the altar lay a broken bell, a small iron trident, ash from incense sticks. In the northern corner of the courtyard the pump handle was rusted, but when pressed it gave air twice and muddy water on the third stroke. The drain was choked with grass. In the cattle shed were a bamboo peg, a short piece of rope, an old hard layer of dung, a cracked trough. No cattle.

The objects in the house did not belong to one time. The brass plates were from an older generation. The plastic drum was later. The airport photograph later still. The bank slips later than that. An empty mobile-phone box was the newest thing. The house had not become empty at a single moment: people must have returned from time to time, brought something, taken something away, left something behind. The emptiness of a house was not an event of one day.

Searching for papers, I lifted the bottom panel of the chest a third time. Beneath the wooden board I found a cloth bundle. In it were an old marriage paper, two horoscopes, a yellowed family-tree list and a small notebook. The family-tree list was not a panji; someone in the household had copied it for private use. There were slight differences in the spelling of some names. The dates of two marriages differed by one day from the dates in the main register. Beside one woman's name her natal village was written; it was absent from the main panji. I set that page apart and marked it for copying, but returned the original to the same bundle.

The notebook was a household expense account. Rice, salt, oil, soap, medicine, school fee, diesel, seed, wages, mobile recharge, railway ticket. On some pages only sums. On some, initials. Regular entries for three months, then

a gap, then two pages, then a long blank. The last written line: “Key with Chhotka.” Who Chhotka was had not been written. It may have been the cousin who had given me the key, but inference cannot be written as fact.

I remained inside the house for about an hour and a half. During that time no one came. Outside, bicycles passed twice, a goat’s bell sounded once, once the sound of a motor came from far away. Inside, the clock remained fixed at seven-eighteen. The dust remained as it was. The photographs remained as they were. The blank half of the letter remained as it was.

Above the shed was a bamboo loft. Two rungs of the ladder were loose. Five objects could be seen clearly on the loft: an old spinning wheel with cotton dust clinging to it; an iron box without a lock; two earthen surahis with their mouths tied in cloth; a bamboo basket holding dried makhana shells; a tin trunk with faded red letters on it. Inside the tin trunk were school certificates, an old copy of a voter card, a photocopy of a service book, two postcards, a wedding invitation from Nepal and three railway tickets. The tickets were from different years. Destinations: Delhi, Ludhiana, Surat. The names printed on the tickets matched names in the household family list. The match could not establish lineage; it could only help indicate when people of the house had travelled outside.

The writing on the postcards had faded. The first asked about the crop. The second gave a train’s arrival date. The third said only: “If I get leave, I will come in Aghan.” The postal mark on the back could be read, but the year was unclear. No line on any card announced that the house would be sold, abandoned, or that the sender would settle permanently outside. Paper recorded people’s intentions; the condition of the house pointed in a different direction from those intentions.

Many small marks remained on the walls as well. In one corner were five horizontal lines measuring a child’s height, drawn in kajal or charcoal. Beside the lines were the years—2001, 2002, 2003; after that no year. On the southern wall were four nail marks, but no photographs. Inside the doorway two phone numbers had been written in pencil, one digit rubbed away. An old bunch of thread hung from a kitchen beam. A trace of yellow paint remained on the veranda post, perhaps from a wedding or festival. Here “perhaps” had to be written: the colour itself does not tell the cause of its presence.

Behind the house was a small garden. The jackfruit tree was alive, with little fruit. A guava tree had dried. The bamboo grove was dense. The shapes of old beds could still be made out in the earth, though no vegetables grew there. An old irrigation pipe lay among the grass. One end was near the pump; the other had split before reaching the beds. New barbed wire ran along the garden boundary. I later learned that the neighbouring farmer had put it up to keep his cattle out. After the house was locked, its boundary survived through another person’s habits.

Before closing the door I looked once at the order of the objects. Things used every day lay under dust. Things used once a year lay under dust too. Objects that may have been brought from abroad—an empty box of foreign soap, a shiny thermos, a small plastic clock—looked newer but bore fewer marks of use.

Things made in the village—the stool, winnowing tray, basket, sickle—were old, but the wear of hands was clear. The emptiness of the house was understood not by the number of objects but by the absence of use.

Once the papers had been found, my work was over. I photographed the family-tree list for copying, wrote down the dates from the marriage paper, and did not copy the notebook's final line because it was not evidence relating to the panji. I tied the bundle again. I restored the layers of the chest in the same order. I turned the steel plate upside down over the mouth of the earthen jar. I closed the door. I locked it. I put the key back into the cousin's hand.

Two weeks later the family living away called. They wanted a copy of the family-tree list. No one asked about the condition of the house. Nor did I say that the clock had stopped at seven-eighteen, that there were only three bangles, that there was only one anklet, that the letter was half written, or that two leaves on the tulusi altar were green. None of these belonged to the genealogical register.

But in the Counter-Register I wrote one line: "Locked house in eastern hamlet; family away; private family-tree list in house records one woman's natal village, absent from main panji; original paper returned safely to house." Beneath it I wrote the source. I wrote the date. I did not write who held the key, because that was not evidence of lineage.

The following year I saw new tin on the roof of that house. The door was still locked most days. The lock had been changed. Whether the clock was still inside, I do not know. Whether the family-tree list remained there or had been taken away, I do not know that either. Only this much can be written: at one time there was a home there; later objects remained in the house, the people remained away, and the key stayed in someone else's hand.

Chapter 37 — Voice Messages

Three—Four—Five

Voice Message Three · Muscat · Three Months Later

[voice-note transcript]

Baba [pause] my first full month's salary has come [pause] the bank message came in the middle of the night shift and I didn't open it at once [pause] after making my round of the ward I sat in the staff room and looked [pause] the amount in hand is lower than the gross salary written on the paper [pause] nothing was deducted for accommodation but insurance and two administrative items were deducted [pause] when I asked HR they said it is in the appendix to the contract [pause] the appendix was in my copy [pause] I had read it but only now have I understood the meaning of that line

The first thing I did was set aside the loan instalment [pause] the second was write down how much to send home [pause] the third was make a limit for my own monthly expenses [pause] food depends on the hospital shift [pause] I share the room with four women [pause] the hospital pays the bus fare [pause] phone and clothes are mine [pause] so I save more than I did in Delhi but the salary one hears about and the salary that reaches one's hand are not the same thing [pause] the agent did not say that

Today I sent money through the bank [pause] first I filled in the form [pause] checked the account number twice [pause] checked the spelling of the name again [pause] there was a separate fee [pause] the exchange rate at that hour is printed on the receipt [pause] I have sent a photograph of the receipt to Mohan Babu [pause] I told him to tell Baba only that the money has been sent [pause] not the amount [pause] if you ask me the amount I will tell you [pause] but first understand that this is not a gift [pause] it is wages for my labour

After I had the bank receipt in my hand I checked the figures three times [pause] amount sent [pause] fee [pause] estimated amount to reach the home account [pause] the employee said the rate changes from day to day [pause] I said the figure printed on the receipt is today's truth for me [pause] if tomorrow's rate is different that is tomorrow's matter [pause] I laughed at myself as I said it [pause] living here the language of papers is entering me

Baba [pause] the answer to my earlier question has still not come [pause] I am not repeating it again [pause] I am only saying that silence too has a shape [pause] in the hospital if I see an empty box on a chart I understand that something was

not written [pause] but in the silence at home it is difficult to know what was never written and what was knowingly held back [pause] if you are well send one line [pause] “I am well” [pause] that is enough

Voice Message Four · Four Months Later

[voice-note transcript]

Baba [pause] this time I am on day shift not night [pause] the sunlight outside the window is so strong that the blind is half drawn [pause] here the body notices the change of season first [pause] when the heat increases the air-conditioning inside the hospital feels colder [pause] going from outside to inside and inside to outside the body has to bear two seasons in one day

In these four months I have had overtime twice [pause] once I came in on a day off as well [pause] the salary did not rise but the total deposit was larger [pause] I sent money home a second time [pause] this time the final part of the agent's debt has been paid [pause] Mohan Babu said one part of the roof at home was repaired [pause] your medicine expenses also came from that account [pause] I was glad to hear it [pause] but it also made me understand that when the number in a bank reaches the village it becomes a cooking pot a roof medicine school fees and seed [pause] the same amount keeps changing form as it changes place

I now keep all the remittance receipts in a folder [pause] month date amount fee exchange rate [pause] everything is written [pause] I was not this disciplined in Delhi [pause] here nothing is accepted without papers [pause] so I keep my own papers [pause] copy of passport [pause] copy of contract [pause] duty roster [pause] payslip [pause] bank receipt [pause] medical insurance [pause] looking at all these sometimes I remember your books [pause] different work [pause] but in both what is not written causes difficulty later

Three women share my room with me [pause] each sends money home on a different day [pause] one at the beginning of the month [pause] one after overtime comes [pause] one after putting two months together [pause] one night all of us were looking at bank messages on our own phones [pause] there was no celebration [pause] only numbers [pause] but behind those numbers were someone's natal-home roof someone's brother's education someone's father's medicine someone's debt [pause] then I understood that money going home does not remain merely money

I have not stopped waiting for your answer [pause] but I have reduced the number of times I send the question [pause] at first I thought it was the distance of the phone [pause] then I thought perhaps age makes you tired [pause] then Mohan Babu said you look at the books every day [pause] then I understood tiredness alone is not the reason [pause] now I will not infer [pause] when you speak I will listen [pause] if you do not tell me then one day I will read it from whatever papers survive

[voice-note transcript]

Baba [pause] this time I'll keep the message short [pause] salary came [pause] money was sent [pause] Mohan Babu has the receipt [pause] I kept some in my own account [pause] the rest went home

There is nothing new here [pause] the same road to the hospital [pause] the same lift [pause] the same smell of medicine [pause] the same room [pause] when I return at night I look at the village time on the phone screen [pause] the difference in time can be measured on a clock [pause] the difference in silence cannot

Two new nurses have come to the hospital this month [pause] one has the name of a small town as her place of birth in her passport [pause] the other's papers list a district [pause] both work the same shift here [pause] the places behind the names are different but on night duty everyone hears the same bell [pause] sometimes I think if a home were like that how many things would be easier [pause] then I understand a home is not a hospital [pause] old rules of relationship live longer there

Mohan Babu says you are well [pause] I have accepted that [pause] I will not even say "send me one line" as before [pause] I remember my old questions [pause] you will remember them too [pause] this time I am not asking for an answer [pause] say it when it is time to say it [pause] for now I am leaving only this message that I am well [pause] I am working [pause] I am sending money [pause] and I still keep a place open for listening

The Panjekar's Clients

The questions clients brought into my room slowly changed. Earlier people asked about lineage-origin, asked the village, matched the grandfather's name, examined the line concerning marriage-standing. Now many clients arrived with a mobile phone in hand and, as soon as they sat down, asked, "May I take a photograph of the page?" In the order of some people's questions, lineage-origin had become second and the mobile first.

The book and the wooden chest had once been the principal objects of my work. Later the photocopy shop at the market square became an unofficial station in panji work as well. A client would write down the page number, open the leaf carefully, then go to the square for a photocopy. Then the mobile camera arrived. The need to go to the square diminished, but hands bending over the page, glowing screens, and requests for repeated photographs increased. The edges of old paper had not been made for so much convenience.

There was one page whose right edge had already been weak before the water of 2008. I used to show it between two sheets of paper. A young man, trying to bring his mobile lower for a photograph, pressed down on the page from above. I moved his hand away. Grey fibres fell from the edge. The young man said, "Baba, it isn't coming out clearly." I told him, "Keeping the paper intact comes first; the photograph comes afterward." He increased the brightness of his phone. The paper did not become brighter.

I remember the first client who came because of a matrimony website. A young man came with his father. The father knew the genealogical register; the son knew the profile page on the website. The father spoke of examining lineage-origin. The son showed four boxes on the mobile screen—clan, lineage-origin, gotra, village. He asked, "Which of these four boxes does this line go into?"

I said, "Put each word where it belongs."

He asked again, "Can it be shortened?"

I said, "The line was not made to fit the size of a website box."

The father looked at the son's phone, then at the genealogical book. The son looked at the genealogical book, then at the phone. This time no one laughed. I had cause for laughter inside me, but it was not pleasant laughter. Seven generations were seeking admission into a four-box form.

After that, clients seeking marriage matches increased. Some wanted five generations, some seven. Some wanted only to know whether the lineage-origin supplied by the other family was accurate. One family came three times. The first

time for lineage-origin. The second for the maternal village. The third with the question: "Did the village of this branch ever change?" The answer was not in one book. I had to open three—one for the lineage-origin, one for marriage, a third for a sign of village change. It took nearly three hours. At the end the young man asked, "Will it all fit in one photograph?"

I said, "No."

"Three photographs?"

"Three books."

He left with three photographs. I had spent three hours; his mobile, three minutes. The fee was given not for three hours but at the equivalent of three photocopies. I recorded the amount in the diary. I made no comment.

Another kind of client came for caste certificates. Here the expectation concerned a government form more than the genealogical register itself. Some believed that once a photocopy of a genealogical page was attached, the block office would issue the certificate. I used to say, "The government office has its own inquiry, its own records, its own rules; the genealogical register is not a government certificate." Then came the question: "What use is it, then?"

I answered, "It is a genealogical record."

Many clients were not satisfied with that answer. They did not want to know what the record was; they wanted its use. If the government form said "supporting document," then every old paper was expected to become supportive. Old paper itself gives no such assurance.

An elderly man came whose father's name had one spelling in a government paper and another in the genealogical register. He wanted me to change one vowel sign in the panji. I refused. He said, "Only one vowel sign." I told him, "Changing one vowel sign changes what was written." He became angry. He sat silently for a while. Then he wrote both spellings in his application and took a photocopy of the genealogical page. As he left he placed the customary offering on the tray. Disagreement and offering can remain in the same tray; the genealogical register has no rule on that subject.

One day two brothers came together. Both needed the same father's name. The first for his son's marriage matching. The second for an application for a caste certificate. The first asked, "Shall we add the maternal grandmother's village?" The second immediately said, "If you write that much the form will fill up." I told them both, "The form has little space; the line in the panji will not become shorter for that reason." The first brother laughed. The second did not. They were sons of the same father; the form had given them different states of mind.

With the mobile came a new demand—the image must be clear. If the letters were faded, the client said, "Take it again." Someone wanted to carry the page nearer the window light. Someone swiped a finger across the phone screen and showed me the paper made whiter. Again and again I said, "The screen has become brighter, not the paper." Some understood. Some took another photograph.

The photocopy-shop man sometimes darkened a page too much. Then the letters looked clear, but stains on the paper also turned as black as letters. One client put a finger on such a stain and asked, "Is this part of a name?" I looked at the original. I told him, "No. This is a water stain." On the photocopy he drew a small circle around it in pencil and wrote "stain." I liked the caution. At least the stain did not become a name.

A woman came alone regarding her daughter's marriage. In her hand were a profile page printed from a website, a notebook, and a blue pen. She did not take photographs with a mobile. She copied the names by hand. Reading one woman's name, she asked, "Is this the bride's name?" I looked again at the original line, matched the date, read the word indicating the relationship, then said, "Yes, the name is written here." She copied the name slowly. In the next line there was no woman's name. She asked nothing. I too added nothing. The reason for an absence should not be left entirely to a client's imagination; but without evidence I could not write the reason either.

Some clients wanted not proof from the panji but prestige. Two lines of "old lineage" on the back of a marriage document. A list of ancestors in a family-ceremony booklet. A short account of "ancestral tradition" on a website profile. Such clients would say, "Give it briefly." I asked, "How brief?" The answer was, "Two lines." It was not within my authority to turn two hundred years of record into two lines. I could give names and sources; not a panegyric.

One young man said he needed only five generations because the website had room for no more. I wrote five names for him. He asked, "The sixth?" I said, "It exists." He said, "I don't need it now." The sixth name remained in the book. Then I understood that scraping is not necessary in order to erase something from sight. If the box is small, what does not fit can remain outside the reader's field of view. I wrote that observation not on the client's paper but in my own diary.

Fees changed too. Earlier someone gave paddy, someone cloth, someone cash as an offering. Later cash became ordinary. Then a young man asked, "Shall I send it by mobile?" I repeated the question because I thought he meant sending the money somewhere together with the phone. Mohan later explained: the money itself does not enter the phone; the account entry changes. The arrangement did not seem wholly unfamiliar to the work of genealogy. A person may be in one place, yet changing the written account of a relation can change a right. I did not make this comparison even to Mohan.

On the first day of digital payment I wrote the amount in the diary, but before writing "received" I asked Mohan what it meant that the figure had appeared on the screen. He said to check the account. I checked the account. Only then did I write "received." The client said, "Baba, keep a screenshot." I said, "Send a receipt." He sent a receipt. The word "screenshot" did not enter the diary; the receipt did.

In these years the body of the panji was changing as well. The edges of some pages had become brittle. In some, the water stains of 2008 had darkened. Some

ink had turned grey against yellow paper. As the number of clients increased, the number of times pages were opened increased too. I made a rule of placing thin paper strips between leaves, made one good photograph of weak pages and kept it, and asked clients not to make me open the original page again and again. People said, "If it is on the mobile, why the original?" The next day someone else would say, "Not the mobile image—show me the original." A record exists between two opposite demands.

I wrote five rules in my notebook. Do not add modern spelling to the original page. If the client wants it, write the present spelling on a separate sheet. Do not press a hand on the page while photographing. Do not call an incomplete line complete. The client's use may be marriage matching or a certificate; show only what the genealogical register actually states.

I did not paste these rules on the wall. People generally read a rule on the wall only when it blocks their work. Clients coming to me looked first at the mobile, then at me, finally at the book. The rules remained safe in the notebook.

One day five clients came one after another. First—a matrimony website. Second—a caste certificate. Third—a copy of the lineage for a son living abroad. Fourth—to understand an ancestral relationship in a land dispute. Fifth—a grandson's school homework to make a family tree. The fifth stayed the shortest time, but his question was the oldest: "Who comes above great-grandfather?" I wrote five names. He folded the paper and put it in his pocket; he did not take out a mobile.

In the evening I wrote the day's account: five clients; three photocopies; seven mobile photographs; one spelling dispute; one government form; one school family tree; fees such-and-such; one digital payment. Beneath the list there was room for a comment. At first I left it blank.

At night I took out the Counter-Panji. Separate from the original panji. I did not write the clients' names; their names were not necessary for this matter. I wrote: "Contemporary uses: marriage matching, supporting document for caste certificate, school family tree, copy for migrant family. Sources: dated client requests and direct observation. Original line to remain unchanged." Beneath it I left one line blank.

After the blank line I wrote: "The erosion of a record is of two kinds: the edge of the paper crumbles; the user cuts away the edge of meaning. The second statement is inferential." Having written the word "inferential," I stopped. The first rule of the Counter-Panji applied there. I did not strike out the sentence. I put a question mark after it.

When I closed the book there was a new message on the phone. The number was unfamiliar. It read: "Baba, can the genealogy be had as a PDF?"

I did not reply. First I had to ask Mohan whether a PDF was paper, a photocopy, or some third thing in which the body of paper was absent yet people asked for it as though it were paper.

CHAPTER 39
Kosi — 6

I flow and paper does not endure for long beside me but human beings want to preserve their long span of time within paper and when the edge of a page grows brittle they make an image of it and when the image grows blurred they brighten it again and when the letters in one line become too many they fit them into a smaller box and when the box fills they leave some names out and these changes do not seem different to me from the changes of water because I too cut earth from one bank and leave sand upon another erase the line of an old channel and make the edge of a new channel but human beings differ from me in one thing they want to write the reason for what they leave out and they want proof for what they write and then a copy of the proof and then a number for the copy and behind the number a seal and behind the seal an office and behind the office someone who can say that this line is true but beside a river truth has no seal there is only wet earth on which a foot falls and after the foot lifts the mark remains for a while then another foot comes then the water rises then the mark dissolves and to escape this dissolving human beings write names write fathers write grandfathers write villages write lineage-origins write marriages write dates write standing and when the written page grows old they keep its image on the screen of a mobile and slide a finger to enlarge the letters but making the letters larger does not make the old page new and brightening a faded line does not make an absent name present and fitting five generations into a small box does not erase the sixth generation it merely leaves it outside the screen and being outside and not existing are not the same thing this difference human beings sometimes understand and sometimes for their own convenience do not understand and I know this convenience because beside me too people build houses on higher earth and leave fields on lower earth and after seeing one year's water trust the next and lay a foundation a little distance from the site of the previous erosion and say it is safe here but beneath the earth the old sand is still present and the memory of my course remains not on paper but in the ground then paper itself begins to travel becomes a photocopy goes into a pocket becomes a mobile image reaches a distant city lives in a computer file and someone opens it and asks where in these four boxes does my ancestor belong and I have no four boxes I have many channels some lasting one year some ten years some many generations and some opening again in a single night of rain and so there is friction between the two but friction can make the edge of paper crumble and the edge of meaning can crumble too when the original line is long and the

form is short people cut when a name has two spellings people choose one when a village name has changed people enter the new name when an old relation does not fit the present box people leave it blank and a later reader looking at the empty box may assume nothing was ever there but blankness is not always absence sometimes it is an incomplete inquiry sometimes an inconvenient extension sometimes an unread letter sometimes a knowingly omitted name and sometimes only this that the edge of the page broke away at that place I do not judge these causes I see only that paper erodes like earth and human beings make copies to stop the erosion but in making a copy they select and within selection a new erosion is born at one place water carries letters away at another a small box keeps letters outside at a third a dark photocopy makes a stain look like a letter at a fourth a glowing screen gives the illusion that a blurred line is clear and amid all this someone writes the word stain beside the stain in pencil and one small word prevents many confusions the ways human beings protect against loss are not always large systems sometimes one careful word is enough sometimes the date of a source is enough sometimes a question mark is enough sometimes not striking out the original line is enough and sometimes admitting that it is not known is enough I flow and beside me the names of many villages are written differently in the papers of two countries one branch of a family is on this side another branch on that side the old road of marriage sometimes goes by ferry sometimes by road sometimes border-post paperwork comes between and people follow the thread of their lineage to seek kin in a distant city but to me the waters of north and south finally seek slope I do not ask permission to cross a border but human names do and with a name travels a certificate and with the certificate a photocopy and with the photocopy a mobile and inside the mobile again a file that has no smell of paper no thickness of ink no roughness of a water stain only letters and the image of letters but when the original page remains in a locked chest the truthfulness of that image depends upon someone's care and if care diminishes then even without river water a line can change and for this reason an old hand writes sources in a separate book keeps statement apart from inference leaves a blank place blank does not strike out the original line and beside me the water keeps rising and falling the sand keeps rising and settling the feet in the boat keep changing the locks on houses keep changing the shape of the mobile keeps changing the boxes on forms keep changing but people still carry the weight of names with them and when someone from far away asks whether my line is still in the book the question no longer belongs only to paper it becomes a question of place a question of relationship a question of memory and I do not answer this question I only flow onward touching an old bank where the name of one branch is written with another spelling in the record of another country and someone opens another page to make the spellings meet

Kathmandu and Madhes

In the last week of Ashwin 2015 an envelope arrived from Kathmandu. The postal mark was blurred, but the papers inside had been freshly printed. The first page was a photocopy of a Nepali citizenship certificate, the second a copy of a birth registration, the third a genealogy drawn by hand, the fourth a copy of an old wedding invitation. On top of them lay a small sheet written in Maithili: “Ramanugrah Babu, please see where this branch joins the panji. I do not need the law; I need the lineage.”

The sender belonged to the bride's family from the marriage of Shyamanand Jha. I remembered that wedding because the wedding party had been stopped near Bhimnagar and I myself had made the list of the wedding trunks. The genealogical paper had no box for country, while at the border we had been asked Indian or Nepali. That day the bride's maternal uncle had been written as the recipient. The paper still lay pressed inside one of my old ledgers.

I opened the genealogical register first. Then the marriage entry. Then the list of goods made at the border. I did not think it proper to reverse this order, because before answering a new question the order of old sources ought to be clear. The bride's village in the marriage line was in Saptari. The border list contained the name of the bride's maternal uncle, his father's name, village and district. In the new hand-drawn genealogy the same name appeared two generations above. One vowel sign differed in spelling.

I set the papers from the envelope out separately. On the citizenship certificate the name was in Nepali script, but not difficult to read. The birth registration contained the mother's name. The father's name was from a village on the Indian side. In the family tree, the maternal branch was written in detail and the paternal side in only three names. The paper did not say why the two sides were unequal.

Two days later a young man came. He himself lived in Kathmandu; his mother was in Saptari. The envelope had been sent from his family. After greeting me he asked, “Did the papers arrive?”

“They did. I am matching them against the panji.”

He sat down. He had a mobile in his hand, papers in his bag, and a folded newspaper page. He did not open the mobile first. He opened the newspaper and put it on the table. At the top of the first page was news concerning the promulgation of the constitution on 20 September 2015. A second clipping mentioned protests in Janakpur, Jaleswar, Rajbiraj and Birgunj. A third

reported freight vehicles held up at the border. One paper used the word “blockade,” another “border obstruction.” I read both words. I did not write which was more accurate.

The young man said, “People in Kathmandu say one thing. Call home in Madhes and you hear another.”

I asked, “What is your genealogical question?”

He was silent for a few moments. Then he took the original copy of the birth registration from his bag. “This is my sister’s daughter. My sister is a Nepali citizen. Her husband is from India. Now everyone at home is looking through papers again. Some say make the mother’s lineage clear. Some say attach the father’s papers. I have not come to understand citizenship law. I only want to know whether the line of my maternal grandmother’s paternal house is in your book.”

I said, “The panji will not determine citizenship. It can state only as much as is written concerning lineage and relationship.”

At once he said, “That is all I need.”

Clients seldom gave such an answer at the beginning. Most wanted an old document to supply the entire answer to a new right. This young man’s request was limited. When the boundary is clear, the work of a record becomes simpler.

I placed the marriage entry before him. The page was weak, so I showed it beneath a transparent sheet. Bride’s name, father, village, lineage-origin, date of marriage. The young man read the name. Then he put a finger on the same family tree he had brought. Across a distance of two generations one name matched. The third name had a different spelling. I opened another book. There was a copy of a marriage paper there. Its spelling stood closer to the new paper.

“So they are the same person?” the young man asked.

“There are two sources. The father and village agree. The spelling differs. Before writing ‘the same person,’ the dates should agree too.”

The dates agreed. In my notebook I wrote three sources: panji; copy of the marriage paper; border list. After them, the new photocopy of the citizenship certificate. The four papers served four different purposes in the same family. The panji for marriage eligibility. The marriage paper for relationship. The border list for taking objects across. The citizenship certificate for identity before the state.

The young man stopped when he saw my old border list. “What is this?”

“List of articles from your grandmother’s wedding.”

He began to read: dhoti, sari, shawl, plate, lota, makhana, betel nut, radio, sewing machine. His finger stopped at the recipient’s name. “This is my maternal great-grandfather.”

“On that paper, at that time, the bride’s maternal uncle.”

He did not laugh. He asked if he might photograph it. I did not give him the original page; I gave him a copy made earlier. He said, “If I show this in Kathmandu, no one will believe that a list of wedding goods would connect a lineage.”

I said, "The list does not connect the lineage. The identity of the person named in the list corresponds with another source. Understand the difference."

He nodded.

At that moment Mohan came into the room. His eyes fell on the young man's newspaper. He read the name Janakpur and asked, "Is everyone at home well?"

"For now. The roads are not always open. Petrol is difficult. In Kathmandu there are queues for gas cylinders. Toward home, transport is uncertain because of the shutdowns. Phones work, so news arrives first and people afterward."

Mohan said only, "Yes." He had come to take some departmental papers; he took them and left. My attention remained on the young man's last sentence—news first, people afterward. In the genealogical register, people had always come first and news afterward.

The young man took a small slip from his bag: a receipt from a grocery shop in Kathmandu. Rice, salt, oil, candles. At the bottom, the words for cooking gas had been crossed out. He had no need to show me the receipt. He said himself, "Mother says take all the papers, then Grandfather will understand that there is not only politics there; there is the household kitchen too."

I looked at the receipt but did not copy it. A kitchen paper was not a source for lineage. Even so, the list recalled the slips from the famine of 1966—rice, salt, oil. Different time, different cause, some of the same objects. I did not write the comparison in the diary. Comparison attracts the mind, but attraction is not evidence.

I asked the young man once more for his grandmother's name. He pronounced it. The form in the panji was slightly different. He said, "Everyone at home called her by another short name."

"Source for the short name?" I asked.

He laughed. "Home."

"Written?"

"There may be an old letter. I'll look."

I did not add the short name. Rule Four of the Counter-Panji: leave blank space for doubt. There was no question of altering the original line.

By noon the matching was complete. I made a one-page copy of the genealogical relationship. At the top I wrote: "This is only a copy of a genealogical record; it is not proof of citizenship or any other right before the state." Beneath it I listed the sources one by one: page of the old panji, copy of the marriage paper, border list, family genealogy sent by the family. I entered the new citizenship certificate only as a supporting contemporary identification document, not as a source for the panji.

The young man read it. "Will you write Madhes?"

"Where?"

"After the village. We now say Madhes."

I said, "The old source gives the village in Saptari. The present administrative place on the new paper may be written separately. 'Madhes' as regional identity would be your statement, with source."

He thought for a moment. "Leave it. Write the village for now."

I wrote only the village.

After he left, the three newspaper clippings remained on the table. I called him. He said, "Keep them. I have images on my phone."

I kept all three. First—constitution promulgated. Second—protests in Madhes. Third—movement of essential goods obstructed at the border. Three papers from the same month. The first declared a new structure of the state. The second recorded people's dissent. The third reported shortages of rice, oil, gas, medicine and petrol. It was not my work to compress all three into one sentence.

A few weeks later a call came from Saptari. An elderly woman's voice. She was the sister of the young man's grandmother. She asked, "Did you find my father's name?"

"Yes."

"My mother's name?"

I looked at the page. Her mother's name appeared in the copy of the marriage paper, not in the principal line of the panji. I said, "It is in one source. Not in the main panji."

She was silent. Then asked, "Will it be written?"

I said, "I will not add new material to the original panji. It can be entered in the Counter-Panji with the source."

"Write it. Children look for names now."

I said yes, but I did not write it as soon as the call ended. First I looked at the source again. The marriage paper was yellow, its edge broken. The name was clear. The date was clear. The relationship was clear. Then I opened the Counter-Panji. I wrote: "Saptari branch; woman's name absent from main panji; available in copy of marriage paper; source attached." No inference. No reason.

There is no political comment in the diary for that day. Only five entries: young man from Kathmandu; four-source comparison; one spelling variation; genealogical copy supplied; call from Saptari. The newspaper clippings are recorded separately: "Three newspaper cuttings preserved concerning the 2015 constitution and protests in Madhes."

That night the old border list came into my hand again. The ink of that time still survived on the paper. "Purpose—marriage." "Recipient—" followed by the name. Nearly half a century later, the same name became the basis for matching the same family against new citizenship papers. Yet I did not write even the word "basis" in the diary. I wrote: "Name corresponds across four sources." That was enough.

I did not place the newspaper clippings, the new copy and the old border list in the same file. The old paper was weak. I put thin acid-free sheets on both sides. The new papers went in a separate cover. On top I wrote in pencil: "Nepal branch—Saptari—Kathmandu correspondence—2015."

As I closed the file I remembered the line in that old marriage record: there had been no box for country. In the papers of 2015 there were many boxes—country, citizenship, border, province, movement, identity. The old panji did not answer them. It supplied only the older order of name, village, lineage-origin, marriage and relationship.

I made the final entry in the Counter-Panji: “State documents and genealogical records may assist one another; neither takes the place of the other.” Beside it I wrote the source: “Direct comparison of documents, 2015.”

I wrote nothing beneath it.

Return

In the third week of March 2020 the first change appeared in red ink on Anuradha's hospital duty roster. Against her leave was written: suspended. Two days later a notice was pasted on the staff-residence board: avoid unnecessary travel. After that, flights were reduced. Then one night a message came from Mohan in Delhi saying that a nationwide shutdown was about to be imposed in India. Anuradha read the message and put the phone away. Her next shift began at ten that night. Before she entered the ward, her temperature was recorded, a mask was issued, and she signed the duty sheet.

She had already applied for leave to come home in April. She had not bought a ticket because the date depended on the hospital's approval. Now the approval had become meaningless. Some of her clothes remained in the old cupboard in Delhi. Her grandfather's questions remained in the village. In Muscat her passport, residence permit, nursing registration, copy of her contract and salary receipts remained together in a plastic folder. The roads outside emptied, but the hospital corridors did not.

During a night shift, when she opened her phone in the staff room, she saw photographs of people walking along Indian roads: bundles on heads, children in arms, bottles of water in hands, trains stopped, vehicles stopped. She opened some images, not others. The distance walked by feet could not be measured on a phone screen. She knew the distance to her own home in kilometres; now that distance had been divided among flight lists, state permissions, airport checks, quarantine and local transport.

Colleagues at the hospital asked, "When are you going home?" Anuradha answered, "When flights open." There was no reassurance in the short answer.

At the beginning of May a registration form opened on the Indian embassy website. After her shift she filled it in on her mobile. Name. Passport number. Visa status. Address in Oman. State in India. District. Police station. Phone. Emergency contact. Reason for return. She first wrote "family reasons," erased it, and wrote "approved leave pending since April." The box for the reason was small. Her reason was not larger than the box; it was merely unclear. She wished to go home, but not to abandon the hospital. Her contract had not ended, but her leave was stranded. Her grandfather was old, but had not been declared ill. In the end she wrote: "Home leave pending since April; available for travel under prescribed rules."

After she pressed submit, a registration number appeared on the screen. Anuradha took a photograph of it, then copied the digits by hand into her notebook. There was no paper copy, so writing the number herself felt necessary.

For two weeks there was no answer. Meanwhile the ward roster changed again. Two nurses went into quarantine. One tested negative; the other was tested again. Anuradha began keeping two extra masks in her bag. Seats were assigned even at meal times. On the staff bus, alternate seats were left empty.

Then an email came. Its subject concerned a special return flight: Muscat to Gaya. Her name was on the list. Reporting time. Baggage limit. Self-declaration form. Mask. Instruction to reach the airport early. Anuradha read the email three times: first the date, second the flight number, third the lines concerning the fee and quarantine.

She went to HR. Her old leave application was taken out. The supervisor said, "If you go, your date of return will be uncertain." Anuradha said, "It is uncertain here too." The supervisor was silent for a few moments, then signed the paper.

She had to complete a hospital handover form. Locker key. Account of uniforms. Temporary surrender of staff identity card. Remaining salary. Bed in the residence. A small square box beside each item. Five years earlier, when she left Delhi, certain things had felt "final." This time nothing felt final. Whether she would return to Muscat or not—no paper answered that question.

She packed less than the first time. Two saris. Three sets of clothes. Not the originals of her nursing certificates, only attested copies. Passport. Residence permit. Contract. Payslips. Bank receipts. Thermos bottle. Charger. Two packets of biscuits. An empty water bottle to fill inside the airport. Masks. Sanitizer. A pair of slippers. A pair of shoes. This time the thought of carrying earth from home did not even arise.

On the day of departure the hospital vehicle dropped her at the airport. The handle of her bag was wet with sanitizer by the time she got down at the entrance. Her temperature was taken at the door. Her passport was checked. Her name was struck off the registration list. She was given a declaration form: symptoms during the last fourteen days, contacts, travel, address in India, undertaking to accept quarantine. At the line for destination address Anuradha paused. She wrote the name of the village. Post office. District. Bihar. PIN code.

The counter employee said, "Indian phone number?"

Anuradha wrote the number of her Indian SIM, which had been inactive for months. Beneath it, Mohan's number.

"App?"

She showed the phone. She had already tried to download the Indian app; verification with a foreign number had stalled. The employee pointed her toward another desk. At the second desk: passport again. Form again. Question again. Finally a small mark was put on the boarding pass. Anuradha returned to her line.

Ahead of her stood a woman from Salalah; behind her, two men from a factory at Sohar. None of them had known one another before. All held the same

kind of transparent folder. Their passports were the same colour. The papers inside were different.

Meal packets had already been placed on the seats in the aircraft. Bottles of water. Masks were to be removed for as little time as possible. The announcement about keeping hands clean repeated again and again. Anuradha did not look out of the window. She watched the route map: Muscat. Sea. India. Gaya. There was no checkpoint in the sky between them.

On landing at Gaya the sequence began again. Rise by seat order. Temperature check. Second copy of the self-declaration. Immigration. Baggage. State counter. District. Name. Mobile number. Village. Passport number. Flight number. A slip marked "arrived from abroad."

An employee misspelled her name. Anuradha stopped him at once.

"It is 'धा' (dha), not 'दा' (da)."

The employee turned the page. "What difference will that much make?"

From behind her mask Anuradha said, "If someone later has to find me from this page, it will make a difference."

The employee corrected the letter.

Outside the airport, vehicles stood with district names displayed. She was not to go directly home. Groups were made for institutional quarantine in Bodh Gaya. Anuradha put her suitcase in the luggage compartment. She was given a serial number. The room number would come later. Meal times were separate. Temperature twice.

Whether the quarantine building was a hotel or a hostel was of no interest to her. Her room had two beds, but the second was to remain empty. Folded sheet. Plastic bucket. Mug. Soap. Two bottles of water. Meal packets were left outside the door. Morning temperature. Evening temperature. Name. Signature.

On the first day she slept. On the second she washed clothes. On the third a message came from the Muscat hospital: "Reached?" She wrote "Yes." She did not call home. She sent only her location to Mohan. His reply: "Babuji is asking." Anuradha wrote: "Tell him the papers say I cannot go home yet."

On the fourth day she had a missed call from Ramanugrah. She called back.

"Reached?"

"I've reached India. Not home yet."

"Where?"

"In quarantine."

"For how many days?"

"What the paper says: first seven days here. After that I stay separately at home."

Ramanugrah was silent for a few moments. Then he asked, "They gave you a paper?"

Anuradha did not laugh. "Yes, Baba. They gave me a paper."

That night she opened her notebook. She had no objection to the quarantine rules; as a nurse, the discipline of infection control was familiar to her. But writing the same address on four forms, reading out the same passport number at

five desks, then spelling her name again on the phone—she recorded these separately. In her notebook she wrote: “Name 5 times. Address 4 times. Passport 5 times. Temperature 6 times.” Beneath it: “This is not a complaint about quarantine; it is about repeated rewriting.”

On the seventh day a sample was taken. After the result came back negative she received a discharge slip. Its instructions: on reaching home remain separately for the prescribed period; report any symptoms. Anuradha sent a photograph of the slip to Mohan. The original went into the folder.

Outside the building, transport was arranged again by district. The sun was hard that day. Dust caught on the wheels of the suitcase. One vehicle headed north from Gaya. Inside were migrants—some from Gulf countries, some who had reached the district centre by train from Delhi, some by special train from Gujarat. The papers in their hands were different colours. One had a pink slip. Another a white pass. Another a rail ticket. Anuradha’s passport was blue.

A roadside dhaba was closed. At another place there was only water. At a police checkpoint the vehicle was stopped. The list was examined. Passengers counted. A stamp was placed on the driver’s paper. Anuradha watched people walking in lines outside the window—bundles on shoulders, bedding tied to bicycles, rubber slippers worn thin on their feet. She did not take out her phone. Photographing them felt improper.

By the time they reached the district centre it was evening. Again: name. Block. Panchayat. Village. A mark against “foreign.” Test—negative. Home quarantine—yes. An employee asked, “Will someone from home come to collect you?”

“Mohan Babu is on the way,” Anuradha said.

A call was made. Mohan’s vehicle had been stopped on the far side of a checkpoint. His permit allowed entry only as far as the block. Other vehicles were not being allowed into the district centre. Anuradha explained this at the counter. The answer: “A panchayat vehicle will go from here.”

The panchayat vehicle came half an hour later. Eight people. Luggage. Driver. One assistant. Anuradha sat down. After two villages the route of the vehicle was to turn another way. Seven kilometres remained to her village. The assistant said another vehicle was behind them. He did not know how far behind.

Anuradha unloaded her suitcase at the roadside.

“Wait. It will come,” the assistant said.

“How long?”

“Can’t say.”

She looked at the phone. Mohan was four kilometres away, beyond the checkpoint. Vehicles were forbidden on the unpaved road between them. Anuradha raised the suitcase handle. Its wheels caught in the earth. She pulled. Then she began to walk.

After the first half kilometre one wheel loosened. She stopped and tightened the strap of her shoulder bag. Her shoes were hot inside. Her mask was damp.

There was a hand pump beside the road, but red cloth was tied to its handle: "Outsiders do not use." She opened her water bottle. Drank half. Saved half.

Mohan kept saying on the phone, "Stand where you are. I'll arrange something."

Anuradha said, "Anything you can do is four kilometres away now. I'm walking."

"The load?"

"It's one suitcase, not the Kosi."

Mohan fell silent. Anuradha thought her reply harsh, but did not take it back.

Two young men came from the opposite direction on bicycles. One asked, "Didi, from quarantine?" Anuradha showed the discharge slip. Keeping their distance, they moved off the road for her. No mockery. No one came close. One of them said, "There's bamboo across the bridge ahead. The footpath is open on the right." Anuradha said, "Thank you."

There was indeed bamboo across the bridge, blocking motor vehicles. On the right, a passage two feet wide. The suitcase had to be lifted. She clenched her teeth, lifted it, carried it across, and set it down again. Her fingers were red. This time her anger was not directed at one person. It seemed to her that no one had ever looked at the whole journey on paper from beginning to end. The Muscat form went as far as Gaya. The Gaya slip as far as the district. The district list as far as the block. The block arrangement as far as the panchayat turning. The remaining seven kilometres were answered by her feet.

She did not stop to take out her notebook. This account would be written later.

Two kilometres farther on Mohan appeared on the other side of the road. In his hand were a mask, water, and an old bicycle. The guard at the checkpoint had allowed him to take the bicycle. Mohan tried to come nearer. Anuradha raised her hand.

"Distance."

Mohan stopped.

"Put the water down."

He set the bottle on the road and stepped back four paces. Anuradha picked it up.

"Let me take the suitcase—"

"No. Don't touch it."

Mohan's eyes were above the mask. He seemed to want to say something, but did not. He turned the bicycle and began walking at a distance. Anuradha followed, pulling the suitcase. Whenever the wheel caught, she lifted it.

At the first house of the village two people watched from inside the doorway. No one came out. The panchayat had already announced that a woman was returning from abroad and would isolate at home. The word "foreign" had arrived before her name. Anuradha did not find this amusing.

Ramanugrah stood at the gate of the house. A white cloth covered his nose and mouth. No book in his hand. Anuradha stopped five arm-lengths from the gate and set the suitcase upright.

Ramanugrah said, "You've come."

Anuradha said, "Yes."

That was all.

Mohan had already opened the door of the eastern room. Anuradha would remain separately there for seven days. Fresh sheet on the bed. Bucket in the corner. Lota. Soap. Water. Plate. A long extension cord for the phone charger. The window opened toward the courtyard.

Before entering, Anuradha took out her folder: discharge slip, quarantine instructions, passport, boarding pass, the copied Muscat registration number, the Gaya slip. Ramanugrah watched from a distance. His gaze rested on the papers longer than on anything else.

Anuradha said, "Don't touch them. We'll look after seven days."

Ramanugrah nodded.

She went into the room. Put the suitcase just inside the door. Left her shoes outside. Washed her hands. Washed her face. Put the clothes in a separate bucket. Then she did not sit on the bed. First she plugged in the phone charger. The battery was at six per cent.

From a distance at the doorway Mohan asked, "Tired?"

Anuradha looked at him. "I came from Muscat to Gaya by plane. Gaya to district in one vehicle. District to block in a second. Block to panchayat in a third. The arrangements ended seven kilometres short. I walked four kilometres. Do you want an account of fatigue or of anger?"

Mohan did not answer.

Through the mesh of the window Anuradha saw Ramanugrah looking at the mud on the wheels of the suitcase left near the gate. Perhaps he was thinking of bringing it inside. She called loudly, "Baba, leave it there. Let it get some sun first."

Ramanugrah nodded again.

Until evening, three people in the house remained in three places. Ramanugrah in the western room. Mohan on the veranda. Anuradha in the eastern room. Between them, in the courtyard, her suitcase stood in the sun.

At night a plate of food was set two arm-lengths from the door. Anuradha lifted it from inside. Rice. Dal. Potato curry. Lemon. Before taking the first mouthful she looked at the plate for a few moments. After staff meals in Muscat, the packet on the plane, quarantine boxes, biscuits on the road—there was home rice. She said nothing about it.

After eating she opened her notebook. She wrote the journey account: Muscat airport—four desks. Gaya—five desks. Quarantine—seven days. District—three registers. Local transport—three segments. On foot—four kilometres.

Beneath it she wrote: "Returning is not one act; it is the road left over between many permissions."

She read the sentence and found it too literary. She struck it out. She wrote a new line: "Reached home 5:40 p.m. Discharge slip safe."

She closed the notebook.

Three Generations in One Room

At 7:12 on the morning of the eighth day, a call came from the block health office. The call was on Anuradha's mobile, but she did not put it on speaker. I was standing in the courtyard beside the pot of tulsi. Mohan was folding an old newspaper on the veranda. From inside the eastern room I could hear Anuradha answering: "No fever. No cough. No difficulty breathing. Yes, I have taken my temperature."

At the end of the call she was told that the seven days of home isolation were complete, but she should still avoid crowds, keep wearing a face covering, and report any symptom immediately. Anuradha said, "All right." Five minutes later she opened the door. During those seven days the door had opened many times—to take a plate inside, to put a bucket outside, to hand over rubbish—but this time she herself came out.

I know of no ritual prescribed for such an event. No arati, no grains of rice, no line in the genealogical register. Anuradha first put her slippers outside, then went back in and washed her hands, then came out. Mohan stood. His first impulse was to step forward; Anuradha raised a hand.

"Still keep your distance."

"Seven days are over," Mohan said.

"The seven days are over. Understanding isn't."

I did not ask what the sentence meant. The eighth day began in the house.

Our house has three principal rooms, one veranda, one kitchen, one bathroom, one latrine, and a courtyard. I had never before understood the importance of this architectural description so clearly. The first question when three generations lived under one roof was not lineage but the bathroom.

Anuradha wrote three names on a sheet of paper—Ramanugrah, Mohan, Anuradha. Times beside the names. Five to six. Six to seven. After seven. She pasted the paper on the bathroom door.

I asked, "Date?"

She looked at me. "What?"

"There is no date of writing."

She took the pen and wrote the date at the top. "Is the record complete now?"

"No source."

She laughed. "I am the source."

"Then sign it."

From the veranda Mohan said, “Babuji, do we need a witness for the bathroom too?”

I answered, “If there is a dispute.”

For the first time since coming home Anuradha laughed loudly. It was a short laugh, but different from the seven days behind the closed door of the eastern room.

A second sheet of rules was pasted beside the kitchen. Do not use one towel. Separate drinking glasses. No mobile phone on the kitchen platform. Bags arriving from outside stay first in the courtyard. Wash milk packets. Wash vegetables with water, not soap. Mohan underlined “not soap” twice.

Anuradha said, “Last time you put soap on the brinjals.”

Mohan objected, “Once.”

“Not one brinjal. Four.”

I did not determine the number in this dispute. The brinjals had been eaten; the evidence no longer existed.

Anuradha tied three different colours of thread around the handles of three steel glasses. White on mine, blue on Mohan’s, red on hers. I asked whether writing the names would not be easier. She said, “The ink will wash away.”

I said, “Then the thread will grow old too.”

“When it grows old, we’ll replace it.”

“That is not the rule of a lineage.”

“It’s a glass, Baba.”

I accepted the point. Rules ought to suit the nature of the object. A genealogical register and a drinking glass do not operate by one method.

Breakfast was chura and curd. I brought out my old brass bowl. Anuradha did not take it from my hand. From a distance she said, “Only you use that.”

“It was mine already.”

“Then that is the first rule-compliant object in this house.”

I understood her remark, but answered in Maithili: “That brass bowl has seen many regimes.”

Mohan laughed again. Anuradha said, “Not regimes. Washings.”

The arrangement for eating changed too. Earlier there had been places for two generations on the veranda—I on a wooden platform, Mohan on a low stool. A third stool was brought out for Anuradha. She set the three like the points of a triangle, though she did not use the word triangle. She said only, “Keep this much distance.”

During the first meal my voice was louder than usual. When distance increases, people do not speak more softly. Mohan asked for dal. The bowl did not pass from hand to hand. Anuradha placed an extra ladle between us. Mohan served himself.

“There were this many ladles in the house?” Mohan asked.

“There were,” I said. “They had no work.”

Anuradha said, “When people are here, objects find work.”

The sentence was ordinary. Even so, all three of us fell silent for a few moments. The empty houses of the village, their keys, locked cupboards, people gone abroad—none of those words was spoken, yet all of them were present.

By noon the second stage of dividing space in the house had begun. Mohan had spread old Water Resources Department papers over the veranda table. Anuradha asked for one corner of the same table for her laptop.

“These files are in order,” Mohan said.

“Where is the order? They’re all on top of one another.”

“I know which one is where.”

“Then your order is invisible.”

I did not intervene. In the matter of invisible order my profession supplied evidence on Mohan’s side, but the household table was not a genealogical register.

In the end Anuradha put the laptop on the window ledge. Then arose the question of the electrical point. There was only one socket on that side of the house. Mohan’s mobile was already plugged in. Anuradha’s laptop battery was at eighteen per cent. The symbol on my small phone showed half a battery.

The first major domestic dispute among three generations was not over property but over an electrical socket.

“My phone, ten minutes,” Mohan said.

“How long is ten minutes on your clock?” Anuradha asked.

“Ten minutes.”

“Kusaha ten minutes or household ten minutes?”

Mohan’s hand stopped on the charger. His expression changed, but Anuradha immediately opened her bag and took out an extension cord. “All right. Not a fight over this.”

She plugged it in. There were now three sockets. Mohan did not remove his phone. Anuradha connected the laptop. The third socket remained empty. I plugged in my small phone.

“Baba!” Anuradha said.

“What?”

“Your battery was half full.”

“An empty place has come into use.”

She sat down holding her head. Mohan’s laughter crossed the veranda and reached the courtyard.

In the afternoon a client called. From the voice I recognized the man who, three months earlier, had asked for a lineage line for his son’s marriage. Now he asked, “Panditji, during the lockdown we’ve found a boy on a website. Can the panji be matched?”

“There is no arrangement for coming to the house just now,” I said.

“Look on the mobile, then.”

“Send the name, village and lineage-origin in writing.”

“Shall I send the caste certificate too?”

"If it is useful as a source for the genealogical examination, I will look at it. A certificate does not take the place of the panji."

Anuradha was listening from the window ledge. After the call ended she asked, "Marriage even now?"

"The restrictions of government are not upon the need to marry," I said.

"They are upon crowds."

"That is why people are matching lineages first."

She said, "Even during a pandemic, matching does not stop."

I said, "Clients of the genealogical register do not disappear when disease is announced."

She stopped after beginning to say something. Perhaps she had wanted to ask something about the caste certificate. Then she turned back toward the laptop screen. The question remained deferred.

Before evening Anuradha looked into the cupboard in the western room. That room held my genealogical registers, diaries, blank paper, old envelopes, thread, red cloth, seals and the Counter-Panji notebook. Standing in the doorway she said, "Baba, there is too much dust in this room."

"It is a room of paper."

"Does paper create dust?"

"Paper keeps dust."

"We'll clean it tomorrow."

At once I said, "No. I will."

She looked at me. "Why?"

"The order will be disturbed."

"I won't touch anything. Only the dust."

"The dust too is in order."

She looked at me silently for a while, then said, "Fine. Keep your own historical dust."

After she left I opened the cupboard. The Counter-Panji notebook lay in the rear layer. I did not move it. I merely straightened two envelopes above it. If one wants to hide something, it is unwise to touch it repeatedly. A touched object attracts attention.

In the evening Mohan was gathering his old files. The cover of one bore the year of contract-material certification. I already knew the paper. When Anuradha came there, Mohan turned the file face down. I saw the action. Whether Anuradha saw it, I cannot say. I made no comment.

At night, while dinner was being cooked, the third dispute was about salt. Anuradha said Baba should eat less salt. I asked, "Whose written instruction?"

She opened her mobile. "There is an old doctor's prescription."

"Date?"

"Two years ago."

"A new check-up?"

"No."

"Then the old instruction is only one source for a present decision."

She put down the ladle and looked at me. "You'll turn illness into a panji too."

"No. There is no box for the quantity of salt in a genealogical register."

Mohan intervened. "By this argument, does the salt increase or decrease?"

Anuradha took the salt tin and put it in the upper cupboard. "Decision deferred."

After dinner the electricity went out. Darkness fell into the courtyard. Mohan switched on the torch of his mobile. Anuradha switched on hers. I held my little phone; I often forgot the button for its torch. Anuradha took it and pressed the button. There were three small lights.

"Now three generations are doing the same work," she said.

"Looking at the darkness?" Mohan asked.

"No. Finishing their batteries."

The electricity returned fifteen minutes later. All three phones moved toward the extension cord. This time Anuradha would not let me plug mine in. "Your battery is still sufficient."

I did not object. A new level of governance had been established in the house.

Before sleeping she brought out her mosquito net. Not from Muscat, but from the old chest at home. The cloth had been dried in the sun. Mohan tied the rope. Anuradha said, "This knot is loose."

"I'm an engineer," Mohan said.

"Then why is the knot loose?"

"An engineer is not a rope contractor."

I said, "That statement can be recorded."

Both of them looked at me at once.

"Don't write it," they both said.

For the first time in four decades, the account of a single night in my house brought together the arrangements for food, bathing, medicine, mobile phones, papers and sleeping for three generations. Alongside them were three separate silences. Mohan said nothing about his file. Anuradha did not repeat her old questions about the family. I said nothing about the Counter-Panji.

One roof does not end silence. It only reduces its distance.

At 10:35 p.m. I opened the diary. I wrote the milk account, the client's telephone call, the time the electricity failed. Then I added a new line: "Present in the house: Ramanugrah, Mohan, Anuradha."

Beneath it: "Food from one kitchen. Bathroom schedule in writing. Disagreement over electrical point resolved."

I considered writing "three generations," but did not. The names were enough.

I closed the diary. Outside on the veranda were three pairs of slippers. Inside, three mobile phones lay in three different places. Anuradha's paper was still pasted to the bathroom door, with the date at the top and her signature below.

Kosi — 7

I flow and this time the roads are nearly empty and the long daylight lies empty upon the railway tracks and no dust rises at the market square and the school gate is closed and factory smoke has ceased in many places and human beings remain inside their houses counting numbers counting days counting distance counting temperature counting breaths and I do not count numbers I understand only the rise and fall of water I understand the weight of streams descending from the mountains I understand the meeting of tributaries I understand a new layer of sand and while human beings confine their bodies from one room to another I touch old banks cut new edges and from within the embankment take in the smell of the fields outside and from outside carry with me the soil from within and no order to stop applies to me but there is no happiness in this freedom because when I flow earth moves with me grass moves dry stalks move plastic bags move empty medicine strips move broken slippers move the ash of hearths moves and sometimes a scrap of paper moves on which half a letter of a name survives and inside human houses cupboards are made so that names may remain safe trunks are made memories are kept in mobile phones paper envelopes are made but beside me even half a letter of a name is only a mere light particle of weight and when the water falls that particle catches on the sand and someone lifts it and someone crushes it underfoot and someone does not even see it and while three generations live beneath one roof each keeps its objects separate one person's medicine there another's mobile here the third's papers inside a chest and on a bathroom door times are written and I do not see a door of time I understand the coolness of dawn the heat of noon the evening wind the dwindling sounds of night and when buses do not run on the road distant footsteps sound more clearly and when trains stop grass raises its head beside the rails again and when people return toward the village sacks rise onto backs children into arms bottles of water remain in hands tickets are sometimes there and sometimes not and lists of names are made at many posts the same name is written again and again the same age arrives as different numbers the same village takes two spellings and the body's temperature travels from one page to another and I do not read all this writing from afar but when paper gets wet the smell of ink enters the water and I understand that in crisis human beings first save their papers along with their bodies and sometimes paper arrives before the body and sometimes the body arrives while paper remains behind and sometimes both are in the same vehicle but get down at different places and such separations

are old things beside me water from one channel enters another soil from one field settles at the edge of another bamboo from one village catches in the sand of another and people again make boundaries boundaries of house boundaries of hamlet boundaries of district boundaries of country boundaries of disease boundaries of touch and inside every boundary they leave a small blank where doubt remains and no seal can be placed upon doubt and in this blank I do not hear the voices of old years but the old path of water remains beneath the soil and when heavy rain comes that path opens easily again and people wonder why the water came here but the soil does not wonder because soil keeps old pressure sand keeps old slope the hollow below keeps the memory of old water and human beings too keep certain things they do not say a father does not tell his son a son does not tell his daughter the daughter defers her question again and under one roof the distance of silence diminishes but silence does not end and beside me too there are silent reaches where water seems to flow above while heavy sand below moves slowly and to the outer eye nothing changes but within the weight keeps changing place and one day because of that shifted weight the bank caves in and people then search for causes open old papers read old lines and find some lines clear some erased some wet some incomplete and some where the writer has left a blank and I do not fill blanks I cross them I flow and in this flowing I pass beside the stone that stands wash the roots of the bamboo that leans pull upon the rope of the tied boat wet the earth beneath the closed door of a house and inside three people listen to the rhythm of their own breathing and the old clock runs on the wall and the sounds of kitchen vessels mark divisions of the day and the edge of the paper pasted to the door slowly curls and in that small house the order of the day remains written while no written order on the wide land outside stops me and outside I move in my own rhythm and the two rhythms do not command one another yet they live in the same time and within this coexistence of time an old line and a new signature remain in the same house and are still separate from one another but the distance has become so small that one day someone will lift the paper turn a page one handwriting will touch another handwriting and even then I will go on flowing

Counter-Panji

The Kosi's water had receded that week. Inside the house, however, objects were still changing places. Anuradha moved her Muscat bag out of the eastern room and onto the veranda, Mohan was tying up old newspapers, and I was separating the lineage papers of two clients on the table. Beneath the table lay an old cloth bag. I had told no one in the house about it.

Anuradha was looking for an extension cord. The lead on her phone charger was too short. She reached under the table and first pulled out a dust-covered box, then the bag behind it.

"Grandfather, what's in this?"

Before I could answer, the knot of the bag was in her hand. It was not tight. She opened it. A faded green cover appeared.

"Give me that book," I said.

She lifted it, but before handing it over she opened the first page.

At the top was a date. Beneath it, in my handwriting, two words: "Counter-Panji."

Anuradha read the words twice. The first time to herself, the second time so I could hear.

"Counter-Panji."

I held out my hand. She gave me the book. Its weight was familiar. With my fingers I recognized the worn place at the left corner of the cover. I opened the page. I could see the letters but not the distinctions within them. I brought the book close to my eyes, moved it away again, turned it toward the window. There was enough light.

Anuradha said nothing.

I turned the second page. The lines looked like my own handwriting, yet I could not read them. For so many years I had recognized other people's ancestors through those letters. Now I had to hear the words written by my own hand from Anuradha's mouth.

I gave her the book.

"Read it to me."

She sat down. Mohan stopped tying the newspapers and stood beside a veranda pillar. I did not ask him to leave. Anuradha opened the first page again.

"First rule—do not write inference as fact."

She paused.

"Second—where the source is known, write the source with the statement."

Instead of nodding, I tapped one finger once on the table.

“Third—if a name is not in the original, enter it here only with evidence. Fourth—leave blank space for doubt. Fifth—do not strike out the original line.”

She turned the page.

“The line following Shridhar was erased from the original sheet by abrasion. The handwriting of the erasing hand matches Harinarayan’s writing. Original words illegible.”

After that line Anuradha looked at me.

“Go on,” I said.

She read: “Phuljhari—name appears in oral testimonies. Absent from the original panji.”

The string was still in Mohan’s hand. He did not move away from the pillar.

“Jagesar Sada—explicit in the ploughman’s testimony. Consistent with memory of the old settlement. Absent from the original panji.”

Anuradha stopped a finger at one place on the page.

“Here it says: ‘Nature of relationship disputed; marriage asserted directly in one source, indirectly in the others.’”

“Yes.”

“You wrote this?”

“The handwriting is mine.”

“I asked whether the statement is yours.”

“Where a source is cited, the statement belongs to the source. Where there is no source, do not take it as mine.”

She looked again at the page. Whether there was anger or fatigue on her face I could not say with certainty. If it is not certain, do not write it—the rule was in the book; it can be applied to a human face as well. I did not write that sentence in the diary.

Anuradha read: “Statement of violent death available; identity of deceased not established.”

This time there was no sound in the house. A lid in the kitchen clinked once in a light breeze. Someone rode a bicycle outside. The bell rang once.

She opened the third page. Location of the bones, soil sample, police serial number, bones sent for examination. The name field was blank.

“Why no name?”

“No evidence for a name.”

“You have doubts?”

“I left blank space for doubt.”

“Can doubt be read inside a blank space?”

“No. A blank space is only a blank space.”

Anuradha did not laugh at the answer. Neither did Mohan.

On the fourth page came Mohan’s blue file. Anuradha read: measurement book, forty thousand rupees, deposit slip, causal connection not established. Once she looked toward her father. Mohan said, “I had said this.”

Anuradha said only, “Yes,” and went on.

The fifth page had the heading: "The One Without a Name."

The first line blank.

Second line: "The woman whose name is absent from the line of descent."

Third: "The man whose name is absent from the marriage line."

Fourth: "The child or lineage for whom the evidence remains incomplete."

Anuradha stopped at the word "child." Beside it, in my small hand, was written in brackets: "possibility."

"Whose possibility is this?"

I looked at the book. I could see the shapes of the letters; not the words.

"Read what is written."

"I am reading it."

"Then the possibility is still only a possibility."

She did not close the book. She went to the final page.

"This book will not take the place of the original panji."

Beneath it she read: "What the original panji says is evidence of the original. What this book asks is evidence of the question."

I held out my hand. This time she did not give me the book. She set it open on the table before me, the page uppermost.

"Grandfather, can you read this line yourself?"

The question was simple.

I took off my spectacles and wiped them with a cloth. Put them on again. Turned the page toward the light. By inference I recognized the first letter of the word "original." The next letter was blurred. I took a round magnifying glass from the drawer. I had used that glass for years to read faded ink. The glass made the letters larger, not clearer.

I turned the page toward Anuradha.

"Read it again."

She read. Not slowly, not theatrically. As she might read the name of a medicine in a hospital, or repeat a number over the phone.

"What the original panji says is evidence of the original. What this book asks is evidence of the question."

I listened.

Mohan came in from the veranda. He did not pull up a chair. He remained standing beside the table.

Anuradha returned to the first page. She looked again at the five rules. Then she closed the book.

"Put it back in the bag?"

I took a little time to answer.

"No."

"Where?"

I looked toward the chest holding the original panji. Then at the table.

"Here."

She placed the Counter-Panji at the right corner of the table, separate from the diary, separate from the original panji.

In the evening I opened the diary. Wrote the date. Beneath it: "The Counter-Panji came into Anuradha's hands."

A little later I added another line: "She read it aloud to me."

I lifted the pen to write a third. I looked at the letters as I wrote them. While the pen moved, I could see the letters; as soon as it lifted, their edges blurred.

I did not write the third line.

At the right corner of the table the green book was not open, but neither was it any longer inside a tied bag.

What Survived

The Counter-Panji now stayed open on the table. Anuradha did not put it back in the bag. The next morning she opened the fifth page and placed her finger on the line “child or lineage.”

“Grandfather, where is the source for this possibility?”

“The source is incomplete.”

“How incomplete?”

I did not answer. From the old chest I took out three papers from after the flood of 1934—the list of damaged houses, the grain-relief ledger, and the village-meeting page concerning the new settlement. The southern Musahar hamlet had been uprooted from its old site by the flood. In a ledger from one year later, seven families from that hamlet appeared under the names of different villages. Beside one of the seven was written: “remaining members of Dalit Sada’s family.” How many “remaining members” there were, and what their names were, was not written.

In Budhan Sada’s testimony, Jagesar’s father’s name was Dalit Sada. A match of names is not proof. For that reason, years earlier, I had written beside that line not a question mark but only a reference to Budhan Sada’s testimony.

Anuradha looked at the paper.

“What village is written beside this family?”

I tried to read the name. The first letter showed; what came after was blurred. I gave her the paper. She read it. The village lay to the south-east of here. I knew the name.

She looked up the distance on the map in her mobile.

“Eleven kilometres.”

“By road?”

“Yes. Less in a straight line.”

There was no need to record that distinction of distance in the diary. My work was to reach the place.

Three days later Mohan hired a small vehicle. I, Anuradha and Mohan went. After we left the main road, the way was unpaved. The vehicle could not cover the final two hundred paces. We got down and walked. The hamlet began at a hand pump. Beside it were three brass-coloured plastic buckets, one iron bucket, two pairs of slippers, half a cake of soap and wet earth.

I did not first ask about anyone's house. I asked the name Dalit Sada. The first young man did not recognize it. An old man said, "It is an old name. Whom are you looking for?"

I gave Budhan Sada's name. He did not recognize it. At Jagesar Sada's name his eyes paused slightly.

"My father used to say it. That name came into an old story."

I did not ask for the story. I said, "Does that family have descendants here?"

The old man pointed toward a house. A new tin roof over earthen walls. A bicycle beside the door. From inside came the sound of a sewing machine.

A woman came out. Between forty and forty-five. In her hand was a half-sewn piece of blue cloth. The old man said, "Lakshmi, these people have come asking about an old name."

Lakshmi Sada looked first at me, then at Anuradha. Mohan stood behind us.

"What name?"

"Phuljhari."

Inside, the foot-wheel of the sewing machine turned slowly to a stop. Before answering, Lakshmi Sada folded the cloth.

"My great-grandmother's mother."

Anuradha looked at me. I said to Lakshmi Sada, "Can you give the complete sequence of names?"

She went inside and brought out a tin box. In it were an old bank passbook, two school certificates, a photocopy of a house-site slip for a landless family, a wedding invitation, a medical prescription, and three papers tied in red cloth. She opened the red cloth.

The first paper was a privately written record of a marriage. Its edge was cut, and a fold-mark ran through the middle. The date was in the 1950s. Groom's name. Bride's name—Sugni. Bride's mother's name—Phuljhari. In the place for the mother's village was written the old name of our village, in the same spelling found in an old revenue receipt. At the place for the father's name the ink had spread. Two letters could be read; the rest could not.

"Who wrote this paper?" I asked.

"I don't know. Grandmother used to keep it. Mother said it was from the time of the marriage."

"Grandmother Sugni?"

"Yes."

The second paper contained Sugni's name, the name of her son Bindeshwar, and the family's old place of residence. The third was later—a written family account prepared after Bindeshwar's death. On that sheet were the names of Lakshmi and her two brothers.

The three papers were not evidence of one kind. The first was a private marriage record, the second a family list written in the village, the third a later household paper. But the sequence of names from Sugni to Bindeshwar, and Bindeshwar to Lakshmi, did not break. The first paper named Phuljhari as Sugni's mother.

“What is said in your house about Phuljhari?” I asked.

Lakshmi did not answer at once. She pulled a cot out and set it down. I sat. Anuradha took a plastic chair beside it, not the cot. Mohan remained standing.

“I’ve heard three things,” Lakshmi said. “First, that she came from a large household to the north. Second, that her own people never accepted her back. Third, that some years after leaving Sugni she either went somewhere else or died —people in the house do not all say the same thing about that.”

“Jagesar?” I asked.

“I’ve heard the name. People differed about what the relationship was.”

“Did anyone say Sugni was his daughter?”

Lakshmi looked at me for a little while.

“Some said so. Some said not. Look at the papers I have. Why should I invent what isn’t here?”

The answer accorded with the first rule of the Counter-Panji. I did not praise her for that. I simply looked at the papers again.

Anuradha asked, “Who still speaks Phuljhari’s name in the house?”

“When Mother was alive, she did. Now I do if someone asks. Most people don’t ask.”

The old man who had brought us to the house had now sat down beside the doorway. He said, “My mother knew Sugni. She used to say her mother was from a Brahmin house. Name Phuljhari. But I never saw Phuljhari with my own eyes.”

I asked the source of his statement. He gave his mother’s name. No date. In my notebook I wrote: “Second-order oral testimony; not direct.”

Lakshmi watched me write.

“Are you a panjekar?”

“Yes.”

“Then were our names in that panji?”

“No.”

“Phuljhari’s?”

Before answering I gathered the papers together.

“Not in the main line.”

She did not laugh. Nor was anger clearly visible on her face. She asked only, “Why are you looking now, after so many years?”

“The inquiry began after an erased line was found.”

“What will writing it now do?”

“Part of what was absent from the paper will become present.”

“What will I get?”

“Nothing.”

After giving the answer, I did not alter it.

Lakshmi tied the red cloth again. I asked permission to photograph the first paper. She said, “Take it. But the original stays here.”

“The original stays here,” I repeated.

Anuradha photographed it with the mobile. First the whole page, then the section with the names. She did not press a hand upon the paper. The rules I had

made for clients in Chapter 38, my granddaughter followed here more exactly than I did. I did not tell her so.

Lakshmi asked, "Are you people from Phuljhari's family?"

I said, "I belong to the lineage of the family from whose panji her name was erased."

After that sentence there was silence at the doorway. No one apologized. No one forgave. A bucket was changed at the hand pump. Inside, the sewing machine began again.

At last Lakshmi said, "Then write it. But leave the papers of my house with me."

"No original paper will leave here."

She put the red-cloth bundle back into the tin box. The box went under the cot.

On the way back Anuradha asked, "What will you call this visit?"

"Collection of evidence."

"That's all?"

"That is all."

When we reached home I opened the Counter-Panji. Beneath the line "child or lineage" on the fifth page I added a new entry: "Evidence of a living branch available. Place—Musahar hamlet eleven kilometres to the south-east. Source one—private marriage record of Sugni; mother Phuljhari. Source two—written family sequence from Sugni to Bindeshwar, Bindeshwar to Lakshmi. Source three—oral memory of the hamlet; no direct testimony. Jagesar's paternity remains unproved."

I did not strike out the word "possibility." Beside it I wrote the new date. After that: "Lineage branch verified; question of paternity separate."

Anuradha read it.

"Now?"

I opened the chest containing the original panji. I took out the page with the abraded line. On the table, the Counter-Panji to the right, the original panji to the left. Between them was placed a printed copy of the photograph of the paper Lakshmi had shown us.

I took out the pen, but did not place it on the page.

The writing of the name was left for the next day.

Writing the Name

Shridhar Mishra. Father — Vachaspati. Grandfather — Raghupati.

Daughter — Phuljhari.

Phuljhari — reported household relationship with Jagesar Sada. No clan consent. Marriage rite disputed.

Sugni — mother Phuljhari. Father — illegible; Jagesar Sada's paternity unproved.

Sugni's son — Bindeshwar.

Bindeshwar's daughter — Lakshmi.

Living lineage branch — Musahar hamlet eleven kilometres to the south-east.

Phuljhari's name re-entered in the main lineage line.

Death and the Book

In the rains of 2024 my diary began to grow short again. Earlier I wrote ten or fifteen lines in a day; now two or three were enough. My eyes tired. The magnifying glass had become a permanent object on the table. When Anuradha was at home she read papers aloud to me. By listening to the words I recognized the order of the page. That letters I had written all my life now needed another person's voice before I could hear their names—I made no comment on this in the diary.

I kept the page on which Phuljhari's name had been rewritten in the upper layer of the chest. The Counter-Panji beneath it. The printed copy of Lakshmi's paper in a separate envelope. On the envelope was written: "Source; not original." The question of Jagesar Sada's paternity remained as before. No new ink was laid upon it.

In the diary for a Monday in Bhadon it says: "Two clients for panji consultation. Offering from one. One client photographed page on mobile. Original page not placed in hand." Second line: "Showed Anuradha the key of the eastern chest." Third: "No second copy of key."

Anuradha had asked, "Why show it to me?"

"So its place is known."

"Am I to keep it too?"

"I have not said that yet."

She examined the shape of the key. Brass, four teeth, round hole at the head. Then put it back on the table.

That week Mohan brought me new spectacles. The shopkeeper's name was printed on the case. With the spectacles the letters grew a little larger, but the distinctions did not all return. I opened one page of the original panji and tried to read three lines. The first name was read. For the second I took Anuradha's help. The third I left. In the diary I wrote: "Reading and writing do not weaken at the same rate." I could not decide whether the sentence was fact or autobiography, so I put a question mark after it.

The day before his death no client came to the house. It was raining. Mohan spent time clearing leaves from the roof gutter. Anuradha was in the northern room opening bundles of old cloth. In the diary he wrote five objects—magnifying glass, black pen, two empty medicine strips, brass key, the page on which Phuljhari's name had been rewritten. Beneath them he wrote: "Key given to Anuradha."

That is the last complete line in the diary. Beneath it is half a line: "The last rain..." The two words are clear; after them the fine line of the pen slopes downward. There is no reason to give it meaning.

The next morning Mohan went into the room with tea. The cup was placed on the table. Ramanugrah Mishra did not answer then. The village doctor was called. On the death certificate prepared later were written name, age, village, date and time of death. In the box for cause were medical words. The word *panjika*r appeared nowhere.

On the day of cremation the northern room remained closed. So did the chest. The outer latch of the door was not locked because people were in the house. The key of the chest was in Anuradha's small cloth pouch. It was the same key whose four teeth she had examined that Monday.

On the third day the number of people diminished. Brass *lota*, *kusha* grass, cloth, leaf-plates, leftover rice, medicine strips, spectacle case—objects began returning to their places. The diary, magnifying glass and black pen still remained on the table. Anuradha closed the diary. She added no word to the half-line.

In the evening two *panjika*rs and three relatives came. The questions concerned the death less than the book. First question: "How many bundles are in the chest?" Second: "Where will clients go now?" Third: "To whom will the *panji* be given?"

Mohan said, "First an inventory will be made."

One *panjika*r asked, "Who has the key?"

Anuradha said, "I do."

For a few moments there was silence in the room.

One relative said, "But you have not been trained in this method."

"No," Anuradha said.

Another said, "By tradition this work has been done by men."

Anuradha looked at him. "I am not a man."

The first *panjika*r leaned forward slightly. "What I mean is—the book must continue in use."

"Whether it continues in use or is preserved will be understood after the inventory," Anuradha said. "I do not want to become a *panjika*r either."

Three sentences remained in one place—not trained in the method; not a man; not willing. Even after that, the key remained with her.

The next morning the chest was opened. Anuradha, Mohan and both *panjika*rs were present. Objects were counted first, not decisions. Bundles tied in red cloth, bundles in yellow cloth, the palm-leaf box, separate papers concerning marriage disputes, old diaries, client papers from recent years, the Counter-*Panji*, the page on which *Phuljhari*'s name had been rewritten. Anuradha read each object aloud; Mohan entered its number in the inventory. The *panjika*rs did not turn pages until the item's order had been entered.

When they reached the Counter-*Panji* one *panjika*r asked, "Is this part of the main *panji*?"

Anuradha opened the cover. She read the first rule: "Do not write inference as fact." Then the final line: "This book will not take the place of the original panji."

"Then keep it separately," he said.

Anuradha placed it beside the original, not on top of it.

There was no long discussion over the page containing Phuljhari's new line. One panjekar looked at the freshness of the ink, the date, and the envelope containing the sources. He said, "This was Ramanugrah Babu's final correction?"

"Yes," Mohan said.

"The sources for the correction are in this envelope," Anuradha said.

That was all.

In the final line of the inventory they wrote: "All archival material placed in the custody of Anuradha Mishra for temporary preservation; no decision as to ownership or panjekar authority." Not everyone present signed that sentence. Both panjekars signed as witnesses. Mohan signed. Anuradha signed last. The relatives who did not agree were named as present; their signature boxes remained blank.

Anuradha gave everyone a photocopy of the inventory. She did not put the original inventory inside the chest. She placed it in a separate file with the diary. The death certificate went into the same file. Death and the temporary custody of the book lay together in one file.

That evening the first client came. The matter concerned his son's marriage. After taking off his slippers at the doorway and coming inside, he asked about Ramanugrah Mishra. Mohan answered. The client remained silent for a while, then asked, "And now, to see the panji?"

Anuradha did not answer. Mohan wrote on a piece of paper the name of whichever of the two panjekars lived in the nearer village. The client folded the paper and put it in his pocket. The chest was not opened.

At night Anuradha cleared the table in the northern room. She put the magnifying glass beside the spectacle case. The black pen not on top of the diary, but beside it. The empty medicine strips she threw away. The brass key she put in her small cloth pouch.

The chest remained closed. Inside were the original panji, the Counter-Panji, and the page on which Phuljhari's name had been written again. There was no panjekar in the house. The book remained.

Kosi — 8

I flow and this time the chest in the northern room is closed and the brass key is in a small cloth pouch and the hand that wrote names for many years no longer rises but the papers remain dry and the ink remains settled inside the letters and I do not see the walls of the house I understand the earth beneath the walls I understand within that earth the old layers of sand I understand the slope of those layers where water once passing leaves behind a fine sign of its habit and people build houses upon that sign plough fields plant bamboo make roads write names and as time passes they believe the old path has ended but inside the earth it does not end the grains of sand change new silt rises above old silt roots descend to old layers the water of the well moves up and down with the season and I understand only this much that a path once low may someday again become easy for water and in 1934 the earth shakes walls fall wells lean soil splits and the current beside me seeks its old easy course and in the hamlet near the water roof tiles bamboo hearths wooden stools cooking pots sacks of paddy and nameless papers become different weights inside the same flow and someone writes the event of that year someone preserves an oral account someone leaves a name out of a line someone cuts a line but I do not distinguish between what is cut and what is written I understand only the rise and fall of the bank and time keeps laying new layers upon the earth and in 2008 pressure grows upon one part of the eastern embankment and water does not invent a new road water takes the aid of the slope the land already gives it and the channel called old upon the human map remains possible within the earth and after the breach toward Kusaha water moves among fields and villages and many people call the direction abnormal but the layers of sand do not find it unfamiliar and the path of 1934 and the path of 2008 are not one line yet beneath both the same old low places the same slopes of silt the same insistence of flow in many places touch one another and what are two separate years as numbers upon a map remain inside the earth as two water-marks layer over layer and I do not count years I do not count height but I understand differences of pressure I understand the weight of rainwater I understand the movement of particles descending from the Himalaya I understand the fine seepage within the earth of an embankment I see the roots of bamboo opening at the edge I pull the rope of a boat I wash the roots of grass and when human beings open an old genealogical book they find a name find a blank find an abraded line and when they close the book no page within the earth closes for me and in one house the original panji the Counter-Panji the

diary the death certificate and the envelope of sources remain beside the same chest and a name once erased returns in ink but ink does not stop water and a name does not alter the direction of water and social acceptance does not alter the slope of sand and therefore what can be completed as a correction on paper becomes no final order upon the land and a society that cuts away one line cannot cut away the old course of a river and a society that writes back one name cannot erase old violence and I do not judge this I only flow and whatever falls within me some of it travels a little way some sinks at once some gets caught in sand some remains until the next rain and some rises again and a fragment of bone may come up from the earth a coin may shine half a letter on paper may become wet a piece of wood may catch on a distant bank but the meaning of all these objects is not made inside me meaning is made on the bank when a hand lifts them an eye reads them and a mouth makes a statement about them and now the hand that opened the genealogical books for so long is still and another hand keeps the key but I do not count the inheritance of hands I see the inheritance of water that goes from one tributary to another that falls and rises from one season to the next that leaves one year's silt in another year's field that cuts one bank and makes another and within this inheritance there is no box for eligible ineligible man woman client panjkar witness offender victim there is only slope there is obstruction there is weight there is velocity and there is time and time too for me is not the figure on a clock it is in the smell of rain in the cracked earth of summer in the low water of winter in the fog of late winter and on the day people say the river is changing course again I make no new decision within myself I go toward the side of pressure turn toward the low place lift sand leave silt touch the old bank and when one part of the old path becomes wet again the wet mark of 1934 does not emerge whole from beneath the silt of 2008 but both remain inside the same earth and above them the grass of 2024 grows new feet pass new house-posts are driven new dates are written on new papers and in the chest old pages remain in their order and whether anyone reads them again I do not know and whether someone adds a new name after an old name I do not know and whether someone keeps the panji only for marriage or for the archive or closes it inside a cupboard I do not know but I do not need to know because rain comes again water descends from the hills tributaries fill pressure changes at the bank the belly of a boat touches water soil at the edge loosens sand moves one old hollow fills and another opens and at the same time I flow beside both old and new paths and beneath the line that looks fixed on a map the earth moves and outside the name that looks fixed in the panji life moves and of the life thought ended some mark remains on paper and the edge of the paper that survived one day grows brittle again and I am neither outside nor inside all this only flowing alongside it alongside it and at the end beneath above and between all the names all the lines all the blanks all the embankments all the houses all the chests all the maps all the years in their own places water goes on moving without cease

JAL - PANJI

A register keeps names. A river erases them.

Kusaha, 2008. When the Kosi breaks its embankment again, Mohan returns to a village half-swallowed by water and finds an old panjika's bundle of manuscripts — genealogies that survived 1934's earthquake and 1966's famine, but not the silences entered between their lines. Moving between witness accounts, voice messages from Muscat, and a name that was never written down, JAL-PANJI follows three generations of one Mithila family through flood, caste, migration and the counter-panji they must finally compile — a record of everyone the official register left out.

Translated into English by the author from his acclaimed Maithili original.



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